

Exposition

ISSUE 20 The Magazine that Bridges Management & IT

A DRASTIC GROWTH IN
AI POWER DEMAND

THE SURGE IN
GLOBAL LOGISTICS

HUMANITY TO FALL IN LOVE
WITH AI?

"LIVING FULL TIME,
WORKING PART-TIME"

- DEEPAL SOORIYAARACHCHI

- **BLOCK CHAIN AND GLOBAL LOGISTICS**
- **AI AND ENERGY CONSUMPTION**
- **STARTUPS AND INNOVATION**

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Editors' Note

As we begin the journey of Exposition Issue 20, we find ourselves at the crossroads of innovation and tradition, ready to navigate the dynamic world of progress and exploration. In this digital transformation era, our vision to be a thought leader continues to guide us, inspiring us to bring you a magazine that celebrates growth, creativity, and the limitless potential of undergraduates.

Exposition Issue 20 recognizes the profound impact of our students, not only in academics but also in shaping the future, breaking barriers, and contributing to the ever-evolving landscape of knowledge. It showcases the brilliance and versatility of MIT undergraduates, emphasizing their contributions to academia and industry.

A heartfelt note of gratitude goes out to everyone who made this issue possible. The steadfast support of the academic and non-

academic staff of the Department of Industrial Management, the valuable insights shared by alumni, and the collaborative efforts of the Exposition community have been instrumental in nurturing this magazine into a beacon of knowledge and inspiration.

Continuing the tradition of excellence, we proudly bring forward initiatives like "Edify" and the Inter-University Article Competition, fostering a culture of creativity and intellectual exchange. Additionally, this issue highlights the Industrial Week and the Exposition Magazine Launch, which promise to bring engaging workshops, networking opportunities, and a dynamic Career Fair.

As the Exposition team, we remain dedicated to advancing our platform, taking yet another step forward to enrich the experience for our readers. Exposition Issue 20 is a comprehensive guide that presents innovative ideas and



Editors-in-chief

Mr. Tharindu Ananda
Ms. Shehara Rajakaruna

insightful perspectives. Thank you for being part of this journey. We hope Exposition Issue 20 inspires, enlightens, and leaves a lasting impact.

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The Industrial Management Science Students Association also known as IMSSA, is the prominent student body of the Department of Industrial Management of the University of Kelaniya. This leading student body stands as a vibrant force in the Sri Lankan university landscape, that thrives on the collective spirit of its undergraduates, consistently making a significant impact.

Each year, IMSSA reshapes the academic and professional spheres of Sri Lanka through its 3 key events, hackX, hackX Jr., Exposition, and the Industrial Week. These events forge closer ties between undergraduates and the corporate world, offering unparalleled industry exposure.

During the most recent term, IMSSA touched new dimensions by pioneering enhanced digital marketing campaigns, brand exposure initiatives, and collaborations with reputed mass media companies to amplify the success of the association.

These efforts were complemented by supportive programs designed to promote academic and intellectual growth among undergraduates. By partnering with industry leaders and experts, IMSSA empowered students to deepen their knowledge in contemporary managerial and technical domains.

Continuous efforts were taken to merge the Exposition Industrial Week with the Exposition Magazine launch, establishing IMSSA as a central hub for job seekers and talent acquisition.

All these ongoing efforts solidify IMSSA's reputation as a trailblazer in the academic and professional arenas, setting new benchmarks for excellence and innovation year after year.

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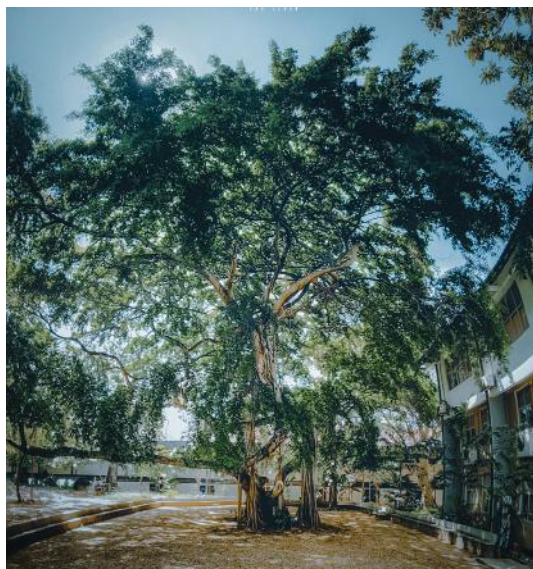
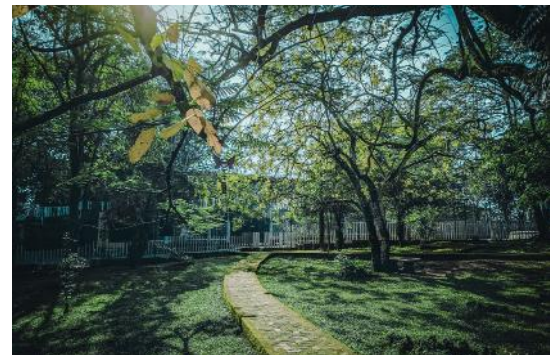
Cultivating Innovation and Excellence

The University of Kelaniya, one of the premier state universities of Sri Lanka, is located in the Kelaniya Dalugama area. With a mission "To nurture intellectual citizens through creativity and innovation, who contribute to national development", the university stands as a leading institution of higher education and research.

Focused on forward-thinking education, the university aims to produce well-rounded graduates who are prepared to face modern challenges. Its dynamic academic community prioritizes creativity and innovation, contributing to sustainable development and national progress. With faculties in Science, Humanities, Social Sciences, Medicine, Postgraduate Studies, Commerce and Management Studies, and Computing and Technology, the University of Kelaniya offers a diverse academic experience. Students benefit from 55 departments and 27 specialized units, promoting research, skill-building, and industry collaborations.

Evolving from Vidyalandara Pirivena, the university continues to uphold values of knowledge, integrity, and service. It adapts to meet the needs of local and global communities while driving excellence in higher education. Looking ahead, the University of Kelaniya is committed to preparing future leaders, innovators, and thinkers. By fostering excellence and innovation, the university ensures that its graduates are equipped to inspire meaningful change in the world.

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Department of Industrial Management



The Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya has been a leader in integrating management and IT education since its establishment in 1967. Over the years, it has grown into a key institution, shaping science students into professionals with managerial and technical skills. This blend of skills ensures that graduates are well-prepared to succeed in a fast-changing world where both managerial and technical expertise are equally valuable.

At the undergraduate level, the department offers two distinct degrees, the Bachelor of Science (Hons) in Management and Information Technology (MIT) and the Bachelor of Science (Hons) in Information Technology (IT). These programs focus not only on theoretical knowledge but also on essential soft skills such as leadership, communication, and problem-solving skills that are crucial in today's competitive professional world.

The department also extends its reach to postgraduate education, offering both the Master of Information Technology and Master of Data Analytics. These programs are designed to cater to professionals looking to expand their expertise in IT or data analytics.

The department offers a well-rounded learning environment with access to advanced resources, including a comprehensive tech library, which creates an ideal environment for academic and practical learning. Beyond academics, it is also renowned for extracurricular opportunities through the Industrial Management Science Students' Association (IMSSA), which actively supports undergraduates by offering opportunities to strengthen leadership, communication, and decision-making skills through various initiatives such as expert talks, interactive sessions like InfoStudio, and field trips. Additionally, students gain hands-on experience and industry insights through events like hackX, hackX Jr., and Exposition, which provide valuable exposure to the professional world.

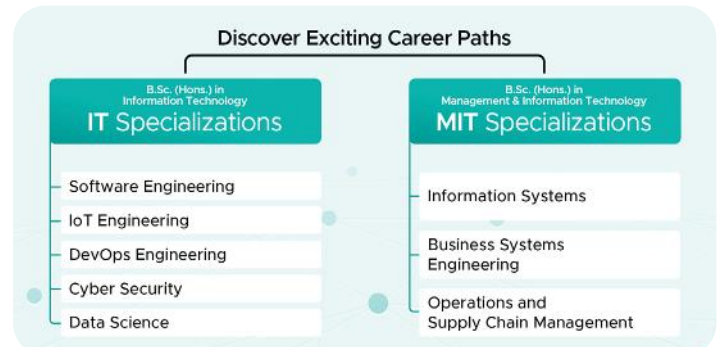
Recognized for its excellence, the department was awarded the ISO 9001:2015 Quality Management System Certificate for the third time in 2020, further solidifying its reputation as a leading institution in management and IT education in Sri Lanka. This achievement reflects its unwavering commitment to delivering high-quality education and fostering continuous improvement.

The Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya is pioneering innovative education through its B.Sc. (Hons.) in Management and Information Technology (MIT) and B.Sc. (Hons.) in Information Technology (IT) programs. These comprehensive four-year degree programs blend management principles with IT expertise, equipping students with the skills to thrive in today's fast-evolving business landscape.

Beyond academic excellence, programs emphasize soft skills and personality development, ensuring graduates are well-rounded professionals with the adaptability and interpersonal abilities vital for success. A six-month internship further enriches the experience, offering students a chance to apply their knowledge in real-world settings and establish valuable professional networks.

The journey begins in the first academic year, where all undergraduates follow a shared curriculum encompassing both management and IT, providing a solid foundation for corporate success. From the second year onward, students can specialize based on their interests and career goals.

The B.Sc. (Hons.) in Management and Information Technology is ideal for those passionate about management, with a strong IT foundation. In the third year, students can specialize in one of three tracks: Business Systems Engineering, Information Systems, or Operations and Supply Chain Management, equipping them with expertise to excel in digital transformation, enterprise solutions, and logistics.



For those passionate about Information Technology, the specialized B.Sc. (Hons.) in Information Technology, introduced in 2019, offers a focused pathway. This program prepares students for the ever-changing IT industry by instilling core competencies in fields such as Software Engineering, IoT Engineering, DevOps Engineering, Security Engineering, and Data Engineering.

Both programs adhere to the latest standards set by professional bodies, ensuring that graduates are not only industry-ready but also equipped with a competitive edge. Graduates from these programs are highly sought after by employers across diverse sectors, empowering them to climb the career ladder and make a lasting impact on their professions.

These degrees foster technical and managerial expertise as also nurture an entrepreneurial mindset, encouraging graduates to innovate and lead in their fields. With a commitment to excellence, the Department of Industrial Management continues to shape the next generation of visionary professionals, bridging the gap between academia and industry.





Innovative Synergy :

How Hackathons Foster Collaboration Between Academia and Industry

Hackathons have evolved from simple coding marathons into dynamic platforms for fostering innovation, providing opportunities for diverse talents to collaborate and solve real-world problems. By bridging the gap between theoretical knowledge and practical application, they have become essential tools in addressing industry challenges while equipping participants with skills crucial for the modern workforce. They also integrate academia's fresh perspectives with the industry's real-world needs, creating valuable synergies that drive creativity and problem-solving in real-time environments.

One prime example of this innovative synergy is the CrowdSnap Market Minds Challenge 2024, which was organized by the Department of Industrial Management, University of Kelaniya, in collaboration with CrowdSnap. This innovative hackathon provided undergraduates with the opportunity to work on industry-specific projects sourced directly from professionals in the hotel, environmental, and social research sectors. Using the cutting-edge CrowdSnap platform, undergraduates conducted surveys, analyzed data, and delivered actionable insights that addressed some pressing industry needs. This event perfectly embodied the spirit of industry-academia collaboration, where theoretical knowledge merged seamlessly with practical application.

Collaboration with industry professionals during hackathons opens new avenues for research by addressing contemporary, real-world problems. Faculty and students collaborate on innovative solutions, often resulting in published research that has a meaningful and lasting impact. This active engagement helps participants refine their problem-solving abilities while simultaneously gaining hands-on experience in fields such as data analysis, market research, and project management.

The recognition and rewards provided in hackathons—such as certificates, cash prizes, and public acknowledgment—serve as powerful motivators for undergraduates to excel. They inspire continued learning and innovation, fostering a culture of excellence within academic institutions. In the CrowdSnap Market Minds Challenge 2024, as well, the top-performing teams were recognized during a grand finale on November 25, 2024, for their exceptional innovation and dedication. Below are the teams that stood out after a competitive idea marathon among multiple teams.

Winners

Team MaRRsi - Domestic Travel Preferences and Trends Among Sri Lankan Residents

First Runner-Up

Team NOMADS - Impact of Digital Nomadism on Sri Lanka's Tourism Industry

Second Runner-Up

Paradise Predictors - Tourism demand forecast for Sri Lanka

Hackathons also play a pivotal role in preparing students for the workforce by fostering essential skills such as teamwork, effective communication, and innovative problem-solving. The experience of collaborating on industry-driven projects builds confidence, enriches students' portfolios, and provides tangible outcomes that make them stand out to prospective employers. Furthermore, students gain a deeper understanding of how to navigate fast-paced, complex environments, thus enhancing their career readiness.

For industries, hackathons offer access to fresh perspectives and cost-effective solutions that can



drive innovation. These events also serve as platforms for talent identification, enabling companies to spot potential interns or future employees. Additionally, hackathons create opportunities for long-term partnerships with academic institutions, fostering collaboration between the two sectors. Through student involvement in hackathons, companies also engage in technology evangelism, spreading awareness of their tools, methodologies, and platforms.

By collaborating on industry-specific problems, CrowdSnap Market Minds Challenge 2024 offered students valuable insights into data analysis, market research, and teamwork in real-world settings. The unique hackathon served as a launchpad for students to refine their skills, develop their online presence, and forge connections with industry leaders. Industry professionals praised the creativity of the solutions presented, noting the fresh perspectives that students brought to longstanding challenges. Academic organizers lauded the event for fostering teamwork, critical thinking, and problem-solving skills, with many stating that the experience empowered students to see the tangible impact of their academic work.

The CrowdSnap Market Minds Challenge 2024 exemplifies how hackathons can serve as a catalyst for collaboration between academia and industry, fostering mutual growth and innovation. It is crucial for universities and companies to engage in similar initiatives to help students bridge the gap between theory and practice. By fostering closer ties between academic institutions and industries, we can ensure that graduates are industry-ready and equipped to address complex, global challenges.



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From Paper Trails to Digital Chains

Blockchain Systems in the Global Logistics Industry

Blockchain is a distributed ledger technology that is based on the principles of decentralization. No single entity has control over the entire network. As the name suggests, transactions in the blockchain are grouped into blocks, where each record, or block, is linked to the previous one, forming a chain of blocks. It allows for secure, transparent, and immutable record-keeping of transactions, ultimately ensuring all participants have access to the same set of information.



The most common application of blockchain is in cryptocurrencies like Bitcoin. Blockchains were first introduced in 2009 and today, they are evolving beyond cryptocurrencies to become an influence in how every industry operates business. This revolution is significantly visible in the Global Logistics Industry by providing transparency, security, and efficiency in tracking and managing the flow of goods. The complexity of the logistics industry, which involves multiple parties, numerous intermediaries, errors, and fraud magnifies the need to take advantage of using blockchain technology in it.

Achieving excellence in logistics primarily relies on effective collaboration with other stakeholders to streamline the movement of physical goods, as well as the intricate flows of information and financial exchanges. Currently, a substantial amount of untapped value exists within the logistics sector due to its fragmented and competitive nature. In 2023, the global logistics market was valued at around \$9.96 trillion and is projected to grow to approximately \$13.7 trillion by 2027, with an estimated annual growth rate of 6% to 7% between 2022 and 2027. The number of logistics companies worldwide varies based on the sector definition such as freight forwarding, warehousing, third-party logistics, and project cargo, but there are over 500,000 logistics companies worldwide.

With such a huge number of stakeholders involved in the supply chain, this often creates low transparency, non-standardized processes, data silos and diverse levels of technology adoption. Within this context, there are also various global social and economic shifts occurring. Major globally impactful transitions such as 'One Belt-One Road' led by China, 'Brexit' – Global Britain, 'Shift2Rail', the increasing importance of airport resilience and operational efficiency, and other broad socio-economic transitions also relate to the technological evolution of blockchains.

Blockchain enables smart contracts that automate the processes and trigger actions when certain conditions are met. As an example, the required payments will be released when goods arrive at the port. This reduces delays and removes the need for intermediaries in the process. It also digitizes the entire process, significantly reducing the need for physical documentation like bills of lading and letters of credit. In this way, we can identify some key

benefits of using blockchain in the global logistics industry, which include, real-time records, strategic implementation of processes and faster routes, eliminating unnecessary steps in the delivery process, reduced errors, increased transparency and trust, improved security, enhanced efficiency and cost reduction.

Blockchain enables real-time tracking of goods from the point of origin to the destination. Each stakeholder, including the manufacturers, suppliers, distributors and consumers can access these records of the product's journey. All parties involved in this chain have access to the same information (even though there might be different permission levels), reducing disputes and ensuring trust among partners.

The decentralized and immutable nature of blockchain means that once data is recorded, it cannot be altered without the consensus of the network. This feature helps prevent fraud and ensures the authenticity of goods, as any attempt to tamper with records would be immediately detected. On the other hand, traditional supply chains often involve time-consuming processes like cross-border payments, customs clearance, and contract verification. Blockchain streamlines these processes, speeding up the entire system. By automating processes and eliminating intermediaries, blockchain also can significantly reduce administrative costs related to shipping, verification, and handling disputes ultimately increasing the profitability of the companies involved.

Maersk A/S, DHL, FedEx and UPS are some global giants in the global logistics industry. TradeLens is a blockchain-based platform developed by Maersk and IBM to improve global trade by offering real-time access to shipping data and a transparent, secure environment for tracking container movements. The platform connects different parties of the supply chain, including shipping companies, port operators, customs authorities, and logistics providers.

DHL, in collaboration with Accenture, is leveraging blockchain to enhance its pharmaceutical supply chain. They are able to track drugs from the manufacturer to the end customer, ensuring that counterfeit medicines are identified and removed from circulation. FedEx is also exploring blockchain to improve the customer dispute resolution process. By storing shipment data on a blockchain, they aim to increase transparency and quickly resolve disputes regarding the location and condition of shipped items.



In the Sri Lankan context, blockchain technology has been explored and implemented in the logistics industry notably through the TradeLens platform. Despite its potential, the implementation of TradeLens faced several challenges, including internal resistance to change, resource allocation issues, and the broader economic crisis in Sri Lanka. Even though TradeLens was discontinued in 2023, the valuable insights and experience it provided highlight the promise of blockchain technology for enhancing collaboration and visibility even in the local context.

Scalability, standardization, data privacy, level of IT literacy, and regulatory compliance are some major barriers to blockchain adoption in the logistics industry. Scalability is a significant challenge for blockchain in logistics, as supply chains often involve thousands or even millions of transactions that must be handled efficiently. The ability of blockchain systems to manage such large-scale data is crucial for widespread adoption. Another issue is the lack of standardization; there is no universally accepted standard for blockchain systems in the logistics industry, which makes it difficult for different systems to integrate and communicate effectively.

Data privacy also poses a concern, as while transparency is a core advantage of blockchain, companies may be reluctant to share sensitive information, especially with competitors. Additionally, regulatory compliance adds complexity, as international logistics must adhere to varying regulations across different countries, making blockchain implementation even more challenging. However, Blockchain is still in its early stages in the realm of logistics; but it is gaining momentum. As more companies adopt blockchain, we can expect further integration with technologies like IoT (Internet of Things), AI (Artificial Intelligence), and RFID (Radio Frequency Identification) to create a highly automated and intelligent supply chain network.



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Mr. Deepal Sooriyaarachchi

Mr. Deepal Sooriyaarachchi, a leading corporate leader, management consultant, and author, stands as a first-class leader and a mentor who worked to bring the best out of people. In this thought-provoking conversation, Exposition Issue 20 sits down with a man whose wisdom has guided the lives of many, helping them navigate toward today's fast-phasing professional world. Join us as we uncover the mindset, strategies, and philosophies that have defined Deepal Sooriyaarachchi's fascinating journey, one filled with lessons that transcend industries.

1. As a child, did you ever imagine yourself on this path to leadership, or did your journey unfold in an unexpected way?

I belong to the last century, so leadership wasn't a term we commonly used back then. However, looking back, I can see the traits were always there.

My mother, a class teacher, often told me that I would always stand up and speak whenever possible. Perhaps I picked it up from watching my father speak at meetings. I would even imitate him, standing on windows and addressing an imaginary audience.

Throughout school, I naturally took on leadership roles. When I joined Ananda College for my A-Levels as an outsider, I became the first student from outside Colombo to be appointed as a prefect.

I wouldn't say it was a conscious decision to be a leader, but leadership naturally became a part of my journey.

2. Mr. Deepal, as a product of Sri Lankan education, what are the challenges and advantages of university life today compared to your time?

I never attended university in Sri Lanka because I failed my A-Levels multiple times. My first visit to a university was to sell castor wheels at a library, which made me realize I had never experienced university life. Since I didn't study during school, I had to learn while working.

You can be successful today, but if your success lacks integrity, it won't be fulfilling in the long run.

The ability to keep learning and adapting is what keeps me going.

My education truly began after starting my career. I completed a marketing diploma, followed by a Master's and PhD. Thanks to my job at Eagle Insurance, I had the opportunity to study short courses at institutions like the University of Singapore and Stanford Business School. However, since I have never experienced full-time university life, I'm not the best person to compare past and present undergraduate experiences.

During my involvement with the Sri Lanka Chamber of Commerce HR Subcommittee, we worked on university collaborations, mentoring programs, and industry connections. Many students we noticed, particularly from rural areas, struggled with accommodations and preferred to go home during breaks rather than seize career opportunities.

Over time, students have become more proactive and tech-savvy. Unfortunately, Sri Lankan university education doesn't always receive the recognition it deserves. While protests make headlines, student achievements often go unnoticed. Some criticize Sri Lankan education without firsthand experience, but I prefer not to comment on areas I haven't been directly involved in.

3. You began your career as a sales clerk at Moosajee Sons and eventually rose to become the CEO of Eagle Insurance, leading multiple companies along the way. Your journey has been long and enriching. How would you describe the experiences and challenges that shaped your path to leadership?

There are a few key moments that truly shaped my journey. From my first day as a sales clerk in 1980 to becoming CEO, my passion for my work drove me forward. One example was introducing lunch sheets to Sri Lanka by using high-density polyethylene offcuts, an idea that took off in the 1980s. Although lunch sheets are now recognized as harmful and efforts are being made to reduce their use, they once played a significant role in making meal transportation more convenient.

I was always eager to learn. And I developed a catalog of polyethylene uses within three months, driven by curiosity rather than instruction. My commitment to giving 100% to everything I did, whether writing bills, selling products, or working in advertising, propelled my growth.

Continuous learning was crucial. I improved my English by studying difficult words and took a loan from the company to study at the British Council. When computers emerged, I pushed my company to train every employee in computer literacy and mandated digital presentations with PowerPoint.

Today, I'm still a lifelong learner, currently exploring artificial intelligence through Stanford lectures. The ability to keep learning and adapting is what keeps me going.

4. Since you emphasized the importance of continuous learning, let's talk about language proficiency, particularly in English. In today's

corporate world, how crucial is it to have strong English skills when climbing the corporate ladder?

Well, before mastering English, you need to develop your thinking. Even if you don't speak perfect English, your skills and capabilities will still find a place. In Sri Lanka, there's a misconception that if you can't speak flawless English, you shouldn't speak at all. But think about it, we take risks every day. We cross roads recklessly, ride motorcycles without helmets, and jump onto moving buses and trains. Yet, no one has ever died from making a mistake while speaking English.

My message is simple. Use English as a tool. Don't worry about your accent or perfect grammar. If the other person understands you, that's what truly matters. I was part of the Presidential Task Force on English Education, where Professor Manique Gunasekera from the University of Kelaniya once pointed out a key issue. We spend 12 years studying English in school, but we don't use it. The first step to mastering a language is to speak it.

So, my advice is to start using English, make mistakes, and learn from them. Today, there's no excuse for not improving your language literacy because countless free resources, AI tools, and language apps can help with pronunciation and grammar.

Learning languages also expands your thinking. Every language carries a unique perspective. For example, in English, we say, "I am in pain," as if pain is something



surrounding us. But in Sinhala, you can't say that. You say, "මම වේදනාවෙන් පෙළෙමින් ඉන්නවා" which means "I am experiencing pain", and that reflects a different philosophical view.

In today's world, English has become the language of the internet and global communication. While other languages like Chinese and Italian are valuable, even China is set to become the largest English-speaking country soon. So, embrace language learning. It broadens your perspective and opens doors to new opportunities.

5. You've successfully transitioned from a corporate leader to a mentor, guiding individuals in the management sector. Could you share how this shift into management consultancy took place and what it entails?

I now dedicate much of my time to mentoring senior executives—those aiming to become CEOs, CFOs, or CHROs. This shift happened for two key reasons. First, in the post-COVID era and amid the economic crisis, many seasoned professionals with 20-30 years of experience have left the country, leaving a significant gap. As a result, those who remain are being tasked with greater challenges, and I support them in navigating these demands.

In my role, I build relationships over a few months, identifying areas where individuals need to grow. The challenge in senior positions is that your results depend more on others than yourself. When you're a newcomer, your work is 100% your own, but as you rise, you lead teams, and the challenge becomes "how to get them to perform effectively". The transition from doing things yourself to getting things done through others is fascinating.

I have regular conversations with these executives, where they share their concerns. My approach isn't about telling them what to do; it's more about asking



the right questions to help them look at issues from a broader perspective.

6. In the corporate sector, maintaining a clear and focused mind is crucial. How do you ensure that mindfulness is consistently practised and maintained throughout corporate activities, especially in such a fast-paced and high-pressure environment?

Mindfulness is not about having a mind full of things; it's about being fully present in the moment. The core concept of mindfulness comes from Buddhism, but its universal application makes it relevant across cultures. Becoming aware is a birthright, and mindfulness is the skill to improve this awareness. It's like singing. Anyone can speak, but to sing well, practice is needed. There's a famous Japanese saying, "Die with what you're doing," which emphasizes the importance of being fully present in the moment. For instance, if I were to constantly worry about how others perceive me or strive for the "perfect" answer during this interview, it would only slow down my thinking process.

In the corporate world, mindfulness is essential for two reasons. First, corporate life is filled with high demands. Challenges often require more than what we have. When the demand exceeds what we currently have, we perceive a gap. Your brain interprets this gap as a survival situation, triggering stress responses. Practicing mindfulness helps you recognize that this situation is not life-or-death, enabling you to manage it effectively while staying calm and focused.

Second, in today's world, we play multiple roles throughout the day. Multitasking is a myth. What we do is switch tasks, which causes a drop in attention and productivity. Mindfulness allows you to fully focus



on the task at hand, giving it your complete attention and ultimately enhancing your performance.

For me, mindfulness is one of the most important skills anyone in the corporate world, or anyone striving to succeed in life, must master.

7. After nearly 40 years in the corporate world, how would you compare the corporate landscape of the past to the modern, ever-evolving corporate world today? What key changes have you observed over the years?

The corporate environment, competition, and workforce have changed significantly over the years. The environment is now more interconnected globally. In the past, strategic plans for Sri Lanka excluded the North and East, but now those areas are included. The advent of the Internet and the World Wide Web has made global competition a reality, enabling people to work for international companies from even the most remote areas.

The workforce has evolved too. While earlier generations valued hierarchy, today's workforce is more casual, and employees no longer wait for promotions within the same company. Many are focused on careers and even early retirement, reflecting a shift in expectations.

AI is also transforming the corporate world. Repetitive tasks, regardless of complexity, are increasingly automated, making some jobs obsolete. For example, in China, audits no longer involve sampling but are based on full database queries, which AI handles more effectively.

As AI becomes more integrated into organizations, those who do not adopt it will be left behind. These rapid technological changes are reshaping industries and human expectations in ways that were unimaginable before.

8. As technology, particularly AI, continues to evolve, do you think we might eventually lose the human-centric approach to decision-making in the corporate world? Or is this shift already underway?

While analytics and data-driven decisions provide logical guidance, human instinct remains a crucial factor that adds depth and intuition to decision-making.

For example, even if two teams analyze a situation using the same management models, one team may succeed while the other doesn't because of a

different decision-making approach. While data provides valuable analysis and insights, there will always be decisions that only humans can make. The value of the human touch, whether it's a handwritten note or offering emotional support in person, cannot be replaced by automation or digital tools.

9. In today's corporate world, what key factors do you believe are essential for an individual to not only succeed but also advance in their career?

To define success, it's important to consider that different people measure it in different ways. If success is judged by material wealth, that is one perspective. However, sustainable success, where you can be proud of your achievements and have peace of mind, is the kind of success to aspire to.

To achieve this, the first key is professionalism in your chosen field. You need to stay current and excel in your area. Second, core values are essential. Without values, how can you trust your behaviour or gain the trust of others? Integrity, in particular, is crucial in business. You can be successful today, but if your success lacks integrity, it won't be fulfilling in the long run.

In summary, success involves being economically stable, living a fulfilling life without debt, and having a clear conscience. This is the type of professional life worth striving for.

10. You've mentored many successful entrepreneurs. What do you think sets them apart from others? What traits make them different from the average person?

Firstly, they see opportunities where others don't. Secondly, they have an unwavering determination, they won't give up, even in the toughest times. Their drive isn't about money; rather, money is simply a measure of their success. Many successful entrepreneurs have faced rock bottom and overcome immense struggles.

Thirdly, they are highly innovative and always look for ways to maximize possibilities. Lastly, once they reach a certain stage, successful entrepreneurs are skilled at managing their finances. Many entrepreneurs falter at this point if they lack financial management skills.

11. When it comes to your journey as an author, you've written several books addressing mindfulness, business, and religious harmony. What inspired you to write these books, and what drove you to tackle such profound subjects?



I've always had a passion for storytelling. I started editing my first magazine at the age of nine, which was a handwritten publication. One of my teachers recognized my writing ability and encouraged me to pursue it further. I later edited the college magazine and worked as a news reporter, even though I didn't read newspapers at the time.

When I began working in advertising in the late 1980s, there were many social disturbances, and I witnessed young people being killed on the streets. This experience deeply moved me, as I realized that, if I did not have the opportunity to work in Colombo, I could have been one of them. This motivated me to help others by sharing my knowledge.

I started writing regularly for magazines and eventually published a book series named "Sinhala Business", which became the first comprehensive marketing book in Sinhala. Over time, I've written about 20 books, most of which were written through consistent weekly writing and eventually compiled into books.

Living Together was a different kind of project. It was born out of my involvement in an inter-religious dialogue experience that lasted 30 years. I spent time with various religious groups across different countries, including Pakistan with Muslims, Japan with Zen Buddhists, India with Hindus, and Europe with

Christians. This gave me a unique perspective on life, which I shared in Living Together.

Mindfulness was first published in the UK and focused on mindfulness as a practical, everyday practice. Ultimately, I write because I want to tell stories and share experiences, which is what continues to drive me.

12. Given your passion for storytelling, if you were to write a book today, what would its theme or subject be?

Well, I'm already working on another book. When I failed my A-Levels, I wanted to understand the reason behind it. I discovered five reasons why people fail, and I have since synthesized this into a model that I'm now writing a book about.

13. Mr Deepal, your career journey has been truly remarkable and enriching, with countless highlights and experiences, many of which tie into mindfulness. Looking back, what are the moments or lessons from the corporate world that you will remember forever? Could you share some of the experiences that have shaped your path?

Oh, that's a tough question. One of my first management lessons came when I asked, "How can

I become a manager?" I was told, "If you think like a manager, you will become a manager." That stuck with me, and over time, I started thinking like the CEO in every situation. It changed my perspective and helped me approach challenges differently.

I've learned a few key principles along the way: always think like a CEO, never surprise your superiors, and take full responsibility without making excuses, because excuses are for the weak.

A great example of this was when I handled a printing mistake in an annual report. Instead of avoiding the issue, I took responsibility, found a solution, and faced the client directly. He was furious at first, but I approached him with honesty, saying, "Yes, we made a mistake, but I'm here with a solution." He appreciated the approach, accepted the solution, and continued working with us. In fact, this experience turned a negative into a positive, ultimately leading to a valuable career recommendation from him.

In short, my key lessons are: think like a CEO, don't make excuses, and always tackle problems head-on.



14. After decades of experience, one thing that stands out is your unwavering enthusiasm to keep learning. What keeps you motivated and excited to continue learning new things?

If you don't continue learning, you become stagnant. That's the secret to staying young. I remember a doctor I met when I was boarding during my first round of college. He was in his late 70s and studied more at that age than I did. Every Sunday, he would go through the newspapers, note new words, and look them up in the dictionary and online. He had a collection of notes, each centered on a single concept explored across various disciplines. Even at 74, his thirst for knowledge remained unshaken. The day before he was hospitalized, he was copying idiomatic

expressions from a book. When I asked him what he was doing, he simply replied, "I'm more prone to forgetting things now, so I felt it's better to write them down." And this was when he was old and nearing the end of his life.

At my age, learning is just as important, but it's also necessary to unlearn. If you don't, it becomes baggage. Learning isn't just about acquiring new knowledge; it's also about letting go of outdated beliefs.

15. As we near the end of our conversation, Mr. Deepal, what advice would you give to someone aspiring to follow your career path, become an entrepreneur, or simply achieve success in life?

I love a beautiful Japanese saying: "Ichi-go-Ichi-e", which means "one life, one meeting." We are meeting now, and this could be the last time we meet. If you give 100% to this moment, it becomes truly meaningful. By fully engaging in what you're doing, you'll find happiness. Enjoy the journey, because the destination may not always be in your control. To truly enjoy it, adopt a childlike curiosity. Ask questions, experiment, and embrace the process.

16. As the final question, how would you sum up your philosophy in one sentence?

Well, it's simple, "Living full-time, working part-time!"

***Learning isn't just
about acquiring
new knowledge;
it's also about
letting go of
outdated beliefs.***



Industrial Week '25

The Industrial Management Science Students' Association (IMSSA) has marked a significant milestone in its history with the successful inception of Exposition - Industrial Week 2025, parallel to Exposition Magazine Issue 20. The Exposition - Industrial Week was a three-day career fair, exclusively designed for undergraduates and fresh graduates of the University of Kelaniya to unlock pathways to their dream careers. Attendees had the opportunity to connect with top industry professionals, explore internships, training programs, and permanent recruitment opportunities offered by leading companies in Sri Lanka. The career guidance workshops held alongside the career fair provided participants with valuable insights on CV building, personal branding on LinkedIn, and strategies to achieve their career goals.

Hosted from the 17th to the 19th of February 2025 at the Department of Industrial Management, Faculty of Science, University of Kelaniya, the event featured the participation of 15+ leading companies and attracted approximately 350+ attendees from different faculties at the University of Kelaniya. Prior to the career fair, participants submitted their CVs, which were then shortlisted. Additionally, walk-in interviews were conducted on all three days.

Over the course of three days, leading companies GTN, MAS Holdings, Mobios, Connex, PW Holdings, Kingslake, Hemas Consumer Brands, and Solidrow conducted recruitment sessions offering undergraduates the

opportunity to secure internships and permanent career positions. These companies provided opportunities in a wide range of fields, including IT, Computer Science, Data Science, Electronics, Chemistry, Physical Science, Statistics, Supply Chain Management, Logistics, ERP, Marketing, Finance, Accounting, and Management. Undergraduates had the opportunity to pursue positions in these areas, gaining exposure to potential career paths within each field. As the Platinum Partner, Connex focused on the industrial aspects, offering undergraduates valuable insights into the professional world. N-able, the Knowledge Partner, led engaging sessions designed to equip undergraduates with the essential skills and knowledge for their careers. Additionally, as the Talent Partner, Beyond The Mic, offered guidance and support, helping undergraduates explore career opportunities and prepare for their future roles. The Industrial Week connected undergraduates with industry leaders, offering valuable career and internship opportunities.

The Exposition - Industrial Week 2025 successfully created a meaningful and mutually beneficial experience for all participants, fostering valuable connections and unlocking new opportunities in the fields of Management and IT. By bridging the gap between academia and industry, the event empowered attendees to take confident steps toward their professional aspirations.

"What began as a simple idea nurtured in a boarding room two decades ago has grown into a national platform, standing tall and making an impact. "

Sandamal Ranatunga

Issue 1 (2006)

"It's not just about publishing a magazine, it's about learning teamwork, problem-solving, creativity, and resilience. "

Hasitha Jayatilake

Issue 10

"The feeling of finally seeing the magazine in print was that of pure joy. "

Inesh Perera

Issue 10

"Through this experience, I gained a deep appreciation for the importance of collaboration and partnership—values that continue to influence my professional life today. "

Darshatha Gamage

Issue 11

"I trust Exposition continues to inspire undergraduates, fostering professionalism and enhancing their skills for industry readiness "

Supun Fernando

Issue 12

"Each page of the magazine was a testament to the talent and dedication of everyone involved, and it remains a source of pride to this day. "

Udara Sembukuttiarachchi

Issue 14

"Engaging with Exposition offers individuals invaluable opportunities to enhance their leadership and project management skills."

Ravindu Deshan

Issue 16

"Exposition has always been more than a magazine. It's a testament to the brilliance, creativity, and drive of the undergraduates of the IM Department."

Thushan Dodanwala

Issue 17

"Stories are what make our existence meaningful, and Exposition has done a remarkable job of telling the story of the Department of Industrial Management"

Manikshini De Silva

Issue 17

"Together, we proved that when a team comes together with a common goal, no obstacle is too great to overcome."

Nihim Abhayaratne

Issue 18

"More importantly, it has allowed me to build meaningful connections with incredible individuals "

Raduni De Abrew

Issue 18

"Every article, interview, and event shaped Exposition into more than just a magazine—it became a bridge between academia and industry."

Chamil Yahampath

Issue 19

In the ever-evolving world of corporate education, InfoStudio, a captivating tech-talk series organized by the Industrial Management Science Students' Association (IMSSA), has become a beacon of knowledge and inspiration. Spearheaded by the Department of Industrial Management, this initiative aims to empower Sri Lankan undergraduates by offering valuable insights into the realms of Management and Information Technology.

The inaugural session of InfoStudio for the year 2024 featured Mr. Kalindu Herath, Senior Associate at Data Technology Solutions, Acuity Knowledge Partners. His insightful session focused on the engaging topic of Generative AI, highlighting its transformative potential across various industries. Drawing from his extensive experience, he offered valuable insights on utilizing generative AI to foster innovation and efficiency, leaving the audience inspired to embrace the future of technology.



KALINDU KUMARASINGHE
SENIOR ASSOCIATE
ACUITY KNOWLEDGE PARTNERS



RUWANTHI PERERA
CONSULTANT
IFS

Ms. Ruwanthi Perera, a consultant at IFS, led the second session of InfoStudio 2024. She led an engaging discussion on "Beyond the Code: Soft Skills That Make You Stand Out." The session highlighted the crucial role of soft skills in the tech industry. Ms. Perera shared valuable insights on how communication, adaptability, and leadership contribute to career growth. Drawing from her extensive experience, she provided attendees with essential skills and knowledge to succeed in their fields.

InfoStudio's commitment to preparing young professionals for success in the corporate world is Evident with these initiatives. Each installment equips undergraduates with the essential skills, valuable insights, and confidence required to excel in an ever-evolving business landscape. Reflecting on the breadth of topics addressed, it is apparent that InfoStudio transcends mere knowledge-sharing, fostering a spirit of intellectual curiosity, adaptability, and resilience among the leaders of tomorrow.

EEC

Exposition Entrepreneurial Community

The Exposition Entrepreneurial Community (EEC) is a platform designed to assist entrepreneurs from various industry sectors in Sri Lanka in sharing and discussing their ideas. The EEC is one of the major segments of the 'Exposition' magazine, introduced by the Exposition Team. It is officially maintained by the Department of Industrial Management undergraduates at the University of Kelaniya.

Small-scale and medium-scale enterprises are the main stakeholders of EEC. Fresh entrepreneurs can gain much from their experience and commitment, and they are also a source of new ideas. These entrepreneurs play a major role in the economy by contributing their skills and creating many employment opportunities.

EEC organizes numerous sessions about business innovation and emerging enterprises conducted by industry experts. These sessions benefit business innovators, enterprise enthusiasts, and even undergraduates. They may be the optimal source of consultation for anyone seeking information about entrepreneurship. Additionally, they provide a platform for entrepreneurs to seek support from undergraduates, particularly in areas related to Management and IT, such as website creation and technical problem-solving, data analysis, and business intelligence.

EEC PHASE 02

AI ALCHEMY:

WHEN AND HOW TO USE AI FOR THE SUCCESS OF YOUR PROJECT



A prominent session of EEC Phase 02 was held on the 6th of February, 2025, at 7:00 PM onwards via the Zoom platform and was orchestrated by Dr. Haritha Thilakarathne, Cloud Solution Architect (AI) at Microsoft. His discourse, titled "AI Alchemy: When and How to Use AI for the Success of Your Project," provided valuable insights into the dynamic landscape of artificial intelligence, focusing on its role in project success. With vast expertise in AI and cloud solutions, Dr. Thilakarathne shared strategic approaches to effectively leverage AI in business and management. The session emphasized the importance of AI-driven solutions in enhancing productivity, innovation, and sustainability, paving the way for future-ready strategies in the digital era.

Dr. Haritha Thilakarathne
Cloud Solution Architect (AI)
Microsoft



INTER UNIVERSITY STARTUP CHALLENGE

hackX 9.0 continued its legacy as Sri Lanka's most anticipated inter-university startup challenge, showcasing the boundless creativity and talent of the nation's undergraduates. Organized by the Industrial Management Science Students' Association of the University of Kelaniya, this year's edition focused on Sustainable Innovation, emphasizing the need for solutions that address contemporary challenges and align with global sustainability goals.

Since its inception, hackX has inspired students across Sri Lanka, creating an environment where academic curiosity meets the entrepreneurial domain. This year, the event saw remarkable participation, with over 1,000 contestants from 27 universities (both state and private) forming more than 225 teams and submitting their idea proposals. After a thorough screening process carried out by CODICE, the Official Title Partner, and Ideamart, the Official Ecosystem Partner, 30 teams were selected as semi-finalists, initiating an incredible journey of innovation, mentorship, and competition.

The journey continued with ideaX 2024, the Semi-Finals of hackX 9.0, held on the 17th of August 2024 at the Department of Industrial Management, University of Kelaniya. The 30 selected teams pitched their initial ideas to a distinguished panel of judges from CODICE, EvonSys, Pagero, IdeaMart, and Acuity Knowledge Partners. Following the innovative ideas, 12 teams were selected as finalists, progressing to the next stage.

Proceeding with ideaX 2024, the selected finalists, including the top 3 teams from ideasprint 2024, the intra-departmental ideathon, were accompanied on a transformative journey under designX 2024, a series of comprehensive workshops tailored to enhance their entrepreneurial proficiency and refine their business concepts. The series comprised two online workshops and a physical workshop. It contained insightful and invaluable knowledge running around the titles "The Subtle Art of Marketing", "Lean Canvas Model: Simplify and Scale Your Startup", and "Your Brand's Cinderella Story: Branding & Storytelling", nicely and wisely clarified and elaborated by seasoned industry experts Mr. Gayan Jayasinghe,

a visiting lecturer at the University of Kelaniya, Mr. Hiranya Samarasekera, Country Head & Senior Vice President of Engineering at CODICE, and Ms. Shilpa Gunawardana, Senior Specialist in OPs Excellence and Supply Chain Management respectively. This helped finalists sharpen their ideas in preparation for the intense competition ahead.

The Grand Finals of hackX 9.0 took place on the 29th of September 2024 at Ideamart, Dialog Axiata PLC, where the final 15 teams pitched their innovative, developed solutions to a distinguished judging panel. The panel featured esteemed professionals namely Mr. Hiranya Samarasekera from CODICE, Mrs. Amaya Jayasuriya from EvonSys, Mr. Malinda Rathnayake from Dialog Axiata PLC, Mr. Azhar Ameer from Creative Software, and Mr. Sajith Silva from Pagero, who ensured a comprehensive evaluation of the presentations. The competition was fierce, with each team showcasing immense creativity and technical brilliance. Ultimately, InnovaTech from APIIT emerged as the champion, captivating the judges with their groundbreaking concept. The first and second runners-up, KernelPanic from the University of Moratuwa and moveMate from IIT respectively, also delivered exceptional performances. Special awards, such as "The Most Innovative Team" won by Team Vanguard from the Sabaragamuwa University of Sri Lanka, and "The Most Popular Team" won by DavinciDreamers from the University of Kelaniya, further recognized the diverse talent and ingenuity present in the competition.



hackX 9.0 would not have been possible without the invaluable support of its panel of partners. CODICE served as the Title Partner, being a huge pillar that brought the event towards success, also providing technical expertise and mentorship. EvonSys being the Gold Partner, while Creative Software and Pagero, as Bronze Partners, and IdeaMart as the Ecosystem Partner further amplified the event's impact, adding immense value by bringing industry insights to the competition. Contributions also came from Loons Labs who mentored finalists as Knowledge Partners. Pulse, *தெளிவு, நாடி*, and HackAthons.lk as Digital Media Partners, SLBC Radio Sri Lanka as Broadcasting Partners ensured the event reached a wider audience, and had a significant online engagement.

hackX 9.0 wasn't a mere startup challenge, it was a celebration of innovation, collaboration, and youthful ingenuity. The competition served as a powerful platform for undergraduates to testify their creativity and transform their ideas into realistic solutions. With the steadfast support of its partners, the mentorship of industry professionals, and the dedication of its organizing committee, hackX reaffirmed its position as a cornerstone of innovation in Sri Lanka for the 9th consecutive iteration.

As it continues to grow each year, hackX remains a beacon of inspiration for young minds, proving that with the right guidance and opportunities, ideas can indeed change the world.



www.hackx.lk



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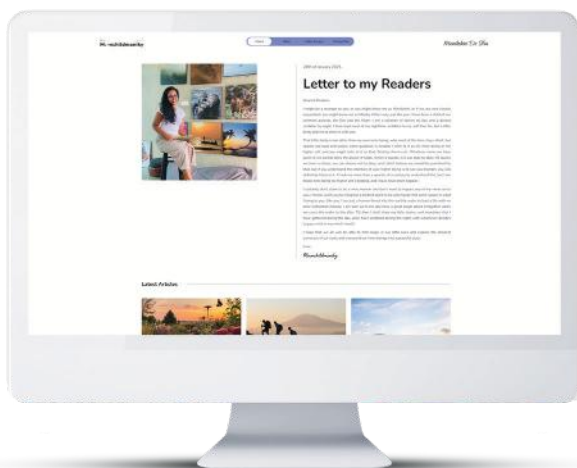
IM SPIRITS

When life serves us a hand of cards, we must play them right. When I got selected to MIT, I was served a good hand, and I was responsible for playing them right. Having done Biology for A/L, the MIT path was a whole new ballgame for me. I was not that lenient towards IT and had a low knowledge of Management, so to lay the groundwork for my next four years as an MIT undergraduate I took an IT diploma and a CIMA course which helped me greatly with the coursework for my degree.

I would label my four years at the Department of Industrial Management as a self-realization journey, with the destination being the realization of my true potential. I was able to identify my strengths and weaknesses, and I was pleasantly surprised when our lecturers and mentors encouraged us to find our own

path rather than conform to a mold that might not suit everybody. This message is well reflected by IM Alumni. Some are entrepreneurs, some are Industry personnel, some are Academics, and some are their own creative brands.

Even though most IM graduates take the path of Industry or Entrepreneurship, I decided to take the path of being an academic because my skills and interests align well with this path. This realization came to me a bit later than I would have preferred, but for an MITian it is never too late to pursue their dreams. I found a purpose in teaching and researching. I always had a knack for digging deep into things and trying to understand why certain things happen. Similarly, I always took great pleasure in sharing my knowledge and findings with others. Other than



“If You are a Graduate of the Department of Industrial Management, the world is your Oyster.”

academics, I've always had a creative side to me, and writing was my creative expression. The Department of Industrial Management also gave me avenues to hone these talents, through this very own magazine that now I am writing to. I am honored to call myself a past editor of the Exposition magazine, and that opportunity propelled me to become a writer, which I always wanted to be.

I truly believe putting effort into what we are passionate about is never a struggle. And I have been proven right. When I directed my energy and efforts towards what I truly loved I was rewarded for it. I was able to win a Best Paper award for my undergraduate research and get it published in a Scopus Indexed Research Conference. I was able to launch my own website where I share my own writings. I never gave up on my creative side. I am on my path to becoming a true scholar and an academic and I am ever so grateful to the department of IM for giving me that initial push towards my goals.

If the pre-defined version of success doesn't fascinate you, curate it to your own taste. That is the best kind of success one can achieve, because what joy can one take winning another man's game?



Ms. Manikshini De Silva
Temporary Lecturer,
Faculty of Science,
University of Kelaniya.



Where Culinary Magic Begins!

I began my undergraduate journey in 2020, a year marked by the onset of the pandemic. The transition to remote learning was initially unfamiliar but was quickly embraced by the Department of Industrial Management (DIM). The department's swift adaptation to virtual education ensured that we, as students, could continue our academic pursuits without significant setbacks during such uncertain times. One of the greatest assets of being an MITian was the unwavering support of the staff. I am forever grateful for the encouragement and mentorship I received from my lecturers, who not only imparted knowledge but also served as pillars of support during both our academic and personal growth. The lasting bond we formed with everyone at the Department of Industrial Management is something I will always remember.



Moreover, the department was committed to preparing us for the real world. We had numerous opportunities to engage with industry experts through career and personality development sessions, giving us a competitive edge when we eventually entered the workforce. These interactions with professionals from various fields were eye-opening, providing insights into the realities of working in a rapidly evolving industry like Information Technology and Management.

During my four years as a student, I gained a strong academic foundation while engaging in extracurriculars that helped me grow through experience. Serving as the Captain of the University Athletics Team and as President of the Industrial Management Students' Association (IMSSA) were pivotal moments in my life. Receiving university colors and working in the Sports Council and various clubs further strengthened my network, expanded my professional circle, and provided me with a sense of belonging within the university community. The connections I made, along with the confidence these experiences instilled in me,

have been key to navigating my career journey. One of the most rewarding experiences at DIM was my internship at MAS Holdings, one of Sri Lanka's leading companies. The skills and knowledge I acquired at DIM were instrumental during my time there, helping me secure a strong footing in my career, ultimately leading to my current role at GTN Technologies. This internship offered me a valuable glimpse into the professional world and the opportunities it holds. What made my experience as an MITian truly special was the balance between academics and personal growth. DIM fostered an environment where both were prioritized, ensuring that we emerged from university not only with a degree but also as well-rounded individuals, ready to tackle the challenges of the professional world. The lessons I learned, both inside and outside the classroom with my friends, continue to guide me in my current role.

Our journey was not always easy, but the support from our peers, mentors, and the entire IM family, combined with the opportunities we seized along the way, made all the difference. The knowledge I gained, the skills I developed, and the relationships I built have shaped who I am today. The "IM spirit" is shaped by intellect, skill, values, and compassion. We are always lucky to be part of the IM family.



Mr. Rajitha Madushan
Associate Business Analyst
GTN Technologies (Pvt). Ltd.



PARTNERS

TITLE PARTNER



GOLD PARTNER



BRONZE PARTNERS



ELECTRONIC MEDIA PARTNER



STRATEGIC PARTNER



ECOSYSTEM PARTNER



OFFICIAL FOOD PARTNER



BROADCASTING PARTNERS



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Mr. Kasun Kalhara

With his soulful music that strikes a strong emotional chord in people's hearts, Kasun Kalhara stands as one of the most celebrated musicians in Sri Lankan music. From the very beginning, he has led the industry with his creative approach, blending human emotions with melodies through music. His inspiring musical journey is beautifully captured in Exposition Issue 20, encouraging millions to stay true to what they value.

1. Kasun Kalhara is widely recognized as an inspirational and extraordinary singer. But beyond the public perception, how would you describe yourself in your own words? Who is Kasun Kalhara from your perspective?

I've never really thought about who I am in that sense. From an artist's perspective, what truly matters is how deeply one feels their creation and how genuine it is to them. I create for myself. If someone claims they do it for others, I believe that's not entirely true. True artistry comes from personal authenticity, not external expectations.

Before entering the industry, my love for music was purely personal. For me, self-satisfaction comes first. If I feel my creation is good and genuinely enjoy it, I can confidently share it with others. I think that's something every artist should strive for.

That's my honest answer to your question. I've never been concerned with shaping society's perception of who I am.

2. You've been recognized as one of the most influential singers and musicians in Sri Lanka. Looking back to your childhood, what were the key influences that shaped your journey into the music industry?

Both my parents were musicians, so I always had their support, especially from my mother. My father was a music composer, and my mother was not

*Choosing the **right mentor** is challenging, as not every mentor relationship is **successful**. Some can even hinder an artist's **growth**.*

*True **artistry** comes from **personal authenticity**, not external expectations.*

only a talented musician and composer but also an exceptional singer. I grew up surrounded by music, often accompanying them to recording studios and my mother's music classes. It became a natural part of my life.

We were also close family friends with Master Premasiri Kemadasa. Over time, I recognized a unique depth in his music, which led me to study and follow his work. I believe that a composer's depth is shaped by their broader worldview. Master Kemadasa had a vast personal library filled with books on political history, philosophy, and literature. He once gifted me a Russian short story collection from the 19th century, the first translated book I ever read.

Master Kemadasa was more than just a musician. He used music to address societal struggles, making him the only composer in Sri Lanka to incorporate a political perspective into his work. His operas and symphonies, such as Paan and Mage Kaale Mauni, reflected this vision.

After my parents, Master Premasiri Kemadasa was my greatest inspiration.

3. With such deep inspiration shaping your musical journey, what values and themes do you strive to deliver to your audience as Kasun Kalhara?

Before platforms like Facebook and YouTube, people discovered artists through newspapers, posters, and handbills. If an article intrigued them, they had to watch the performance to truly know the artist. Back then, audiences simply watched and enjoyed without commenting on every creation.

Today, anyone can share their opinions instantly, often digging into an artist's past good or bad rather than fully immersing in the art itself. In my view, if you're not qualified to critique, just listen to the experts. While open discussions are valuable, true enjoyment comes from experiencing music without bias.

I listen to all types of music, but never as a musician, just as a listener. That helps me to enjoy the music even more.

4. Your musical journey began in the late '90s. Looking back, what would you consider the standout moments of your career so far?

In 2000, while my mother was still alive, I held two shows called Waves of Introspection at the Lionel Wendt Art Centre. I invited Master Premasiri Kemadasa as the chief guest since he was my favourite artist. At that time, I hadn't produced major hits. It was a period when music was heavily copied, and many songs sounded alike. Compared to global standards, Sri Lankan music felt inadequate to me, and technological limitations, like cassette recording constraints, made it even more challenging.

I have a group of genuine musician friends with whom I share ideas, books, and critiques. Every artist needs such a circle. To avoid their criticism, I always push myself to create music they can't critique. It is a way of protecting myself from the outside world's judgments.

After that, I created three albums: Radical Premaya, Haritha Nimnaya, and Romantic Opera. These albums are very special to me, and I put a lot of effort into them. Rather than following popular trends, my goal was to create music that remains enjoyable even after a decade.

5. The music industry has evolved dramatically. You started in an era without social media, yet today, it's nearly impossible to thrive without it. Amidst these shifts and challenges, how have you stayed motivated to continuously create and evolve your music?

I never created music to fit changing trends; instead, I believe society evolves through artistic expression. Many students who join my classes do so after listening to my older songs, which tells me they appreciate music beyond trends and that makes me happy.

As an artist, I don't expect everyone to understand my music immediately. I create with meaning, trusting

that people will connect with it, even years later. Stairway to Heaven by Led Zeppelin, for example, became significant to me long after its release. I hope my songs, too, can evoke emotions for generations to come.

6. Many aspiring artists today hope to leave a lasting impact, just as you have. What advice would you give to those striving to make their mark in the industry?

Authenticity is the heart of any great artist. I always tell my students that singing just to please others isn't the right approach. If you don't love your own voice and connect with it, your performance won't feel real. When you truly appreciate your own sound, your voice naturally becomes more expressive and beautiful. Your audience will only feel the emotion in your music if you do.

Originality is just as important. Music isn't fake. It's raw and emotional. I've been learning about quantum physics, and I see a connection between music and the unseen forces that shape our world. You can't touch music, but it has the power to move, heal, or even hurt people. That's why being original matters. When I compose, I immerse myself in different musical styles, constantly comparing and analyzing. Not to imitate, but to push myself beyond what already exists. Comparing your work to others helps you push beyond what already exists. Comparing your work to others helps you push beyond what already exists.

Finally, imagination fuels creativity. A true innovation in music comes when we allow listeners to experience it in their own unique way. When we attach a fixed image



or visual to a piece of music, we limit its interpretive power. Some masterpieces don't need a video. They should be left as pure sound, allowing people to create their own emotional and mental imagery. Music should be an open experience, unrestricted by visuals so that every listener can connect with it on a personal level.

7. Music is born as a vibration, travels as a vibration, and reaches our ears the same way, which is why we feel it so deeply in our hearts. With that in mind, do you approach music with a scientific perspective, experimenting with sound and its effects?

Yes, This is a topic I love discussing. Resonance is a fascinating concept in physics. If you tune a string to 256 Hz (Middle C) and place another string nearby, also tuned to 256 Hz, the second string will start vibrating when the first one is played. This phenomenon, called resonance, shows how frequencies interact. And understanding this is essential for any creator.

In quantum physics, we learn about matter at its most fundamental level protons, neutrons, and beyond. Some theoretical physicists propose that at the smallest scale, everything consists of tiny vibrating energy strings, a concept known as string theory. While still theoretical, it resonates with me as a musician. Music itself is vibration, and our bodies, down to their smallest components, are also made of vibrating energy.

Some people with perfect pitch can visualize musical notation as they listen, just as outer space can be understood through spectral analysis. This connection between sound, vibration, and the universe is what draws me to quantum physics. If string theory is ever proven, it could open up even more exciting discoveries.

8. The Sri Lankan music industry has seen many ups and downs over the years, experiencing both golden eras and periods of decline. In your opinion, when do you think Sri Lankan music was at its peak? What era do you consider the golden age of Sri Lankan music, and why?

It's difficult to pinpoint a single golden era for the Sri Lankan music industry. Throughout history, music has gone through various periods, such as the Romantic and Baroque eras, where musicians were truly extraordinary. Artists like Beethoven and Mozart were geniuses, and the way they presented music was remarkable. Over time, there was a decline in musical brilliance, but I believe there has been a revival since

the early 2000s. In my opinion, if there was a true golden age of music, it was in those early periods when music was at its purest and most profound.

9. Considering the music industry's current state, how do you envision its future? Where do you think it is headed regarding creativity, technology, and artistic expression?

True artists stay true to their craft. They don't compromise for trends. These are the people who preserve the integrity of music, ensuring that future generations can experience it with the same depth and discipline. No matter how talented an artist is, if they abandon their principles, they risk losing the audience that values their authenticity. Maintaining artistic integrity is crucial for longevity in the industry, and artists must be mindful not to create work that lacks depth or purpose.

Music isn't like economics. It's not about supplying what's in demand. Artists are often expected to be people pleasers, but true artistry is about leading, not following. Musicians should be ahead of their time, shaping culture and inspiring society rather than simply catering to trends. This requires deep thought and a vision for the future.

Music is a fusion of language, science, mathematics, and the arts. When an artist performs, the emotions and depth they convey come from their experiences, knowledge, and personal growth. Without that foundation, creating meaningful music becomes impossible.

10. Collaborations are a vital part of the global music scene. If you had the opportunity to pitch the Sri Lankan music industry to an international label or artist, how would you present it? What key aspects would you highlight to showcase its uniqueness and potential?

To successfully introduce Sri Lankan music to the international industry, we must first prove that we understand global musical standards. It's not enough to just create music. We need to ensure it meets technical and artistic expectations. For instance, in Western music, each instrument has a specific range. If we write a piece for a French horn without considering its limitations, international musicians might not take us seriously.

I recently had to convince an Australian chamber orchestra to perform our songs at a concert. This required more than just sending them our music,



we had to carefully write professional notations for each instrument and provide audio recordings to demonstrate how the final piece would sound. Most importantly, they had to genuinely like our music. To achieve this, we worked tirelessly to refine our compositions.

If we want Sri Lankan music to be recognized internationally, it must not only preserve its unique identity but also be compatible with global musical standards.

11. You've been part of many incredible collaborations throughout your career. Looking back, which one stands out as your favourite, and what made it so special?

I don't have just one favourite collaboration because each one has been unique and special in its own way. Every project brought different experiences, challenges, and creative moments that made it meaningful. So, choosing just one would be difficult.

12. As a judge on Voice Sri Lanka, how do you recognize true talent in a contestant? Once you identify someone with potential, what steps do you take to help them prepare for their future in the music industry?

In Voice Sri Lanka, judges follow a set of criteria when evaluating contestants. When I hear a voice, the first things I assess are pitch accuracy and overall perfection. Then, I focus on the tone colour, the unique quality that makes a voice recognizable.

A key factor in this uniqueness is harmonic content, which can be compared to the pixel quality of an image. Just as a high pixel rate enhances image clarity, a voice rich in harmonic content carries more depth and emotion. Some voices are naturally rich in harmonic content, giving them a unique and expressive quality from the start. Others may not have this naturally, but with consistent practice and vocal

training, they can develop and refine their tone to achieve the same depth and richness. Maintaining and enhancing harmonic content requires dedication and vocal training.

Another crucial aspect I evaluate is the singer's ability to express emotion through their performance. Technical skill alone isn't enough. True artistry comes from conveying genuine feeling. When an artist deeply connects with their music, their performance becomes more impactful and memorable.

13. How important is mentorship for an artist's growth? Can you compare two artists, one who navigates the industry without any guidance and another who benefits from strong mentorship? How does mentorship shape their journey and success?

Choosing the right mentor is challenging, as not every mentor relationship is successful. Some can even hinder an artist's growth. However, mentorship is crucial for any developing artist. Being an artist isn't just about learning music; it also involves understanding aspects like breathing techniques, physical fitness, and sound engineering. A mentor can guide an artist through these essential elements.

In music, even the structure of notation is deeply rooted in mathematics, especially with concepts like cadences (the rhythmic flow of music), which rely on mathematical principles. Resonance, too, is connected to frequencies, which ties in with electronics. Music is a complex combination of many fields, and mentorship helps an artist navigate this multifaceted world.

14. In your opinion, what are the three essential qualities or traits that every artist should possess to succeed and make a lasting impact in their field?

Every artist should possess honesty, patience, and leadership. Honesty allows an artist to stay true to their unique vision, creating authentic and meaningful work. Patience is necessary for navigating the creative process and overcoming challenges without rushing or giving up. Leadership enables an artist to inspire others, collaborate effectively, and influence their community, making a lasting impact.

15. When you think about your legacy in the Sri Lankan music industry, what is the one thing you hope to leave behind?

My music that's it. I want my music to have a lasting impact, speaking for itself.

HOW YOU DID IT?

The “How You Did It?” session series, now in its 5th year, continues to be a prominent platform for undergraduates to gain inspiration from the journeys of successful individuals who have excelled in their careers. This engaging series brings together top professionals in Management and IT to share their journeys, challenges, and accomplishments, offering valuable insights and empowering the next generation to learn from real-life experiences and set the stage for career success.

Episode 10: Management or IT ?

Set your sights on success – discover your pathway in two leading industry sectors today



Ms. Indupuli Wickramasinghe
Project Manager
at IFS RnD International



Mr. Heshan Nanayakkara
Data Engineer
at Sysco LABS Sri Lanka

Episode 10 provided an in-depth look into the Management and IT fields, providing MIT undergraduates with valuable insights to shape their career paths. The session featured two accomplished graduates, Ms. Indupuli Wickramasinghe and Mr. Heshan Nanayakkara from the Department of Industrial Management, who shared their experiences, challenges, and successes. Their stories offered a clear view of the potential these industries hold, making the session a standout moment in this year’s series.

Episode 11: Shielding Your Business Against Modern Threats with Information Security

Spotting Threats, Crafting Smart Policies, and Empowering Your Team for a Robust Defense

In Episode 11, Mr. Haran Mamankaran led an insightful session on the crucial role of information security in today’s business environment. The session focused on identifying modern threats, creating effective policies, and empowering teams to build a strong defense. It provided actionable insights on how businesses can stay one step ahead of cyber threats.

Haran Mamankaran
Associate Manager
Global Security Operations
Sysco Labs Sri Lanka Center





AI Power Consumption:

A Rapidly Emerging Mission-Critical Concern

In today's landscape of artificial intelligence, the surge in demand for AI accelerators has created unprecedented challenges related to power consumption, which is now a mission-critical factor in technology infrastructure. Large tech companies are allocating tens of billions of dollars each quarter to AI accelerators, driving a steep increase in power demands across data centers. Recent analyses show a substantial rise in electricity requirements, particularly due to advancements in generative AI, which has increased GPU shipments to new levels. The exponential growth in AI adoption has prompted a shift in the industry's focus—from optimizing compute and memory performance alone to addressing the rising urgency around power efficiency.

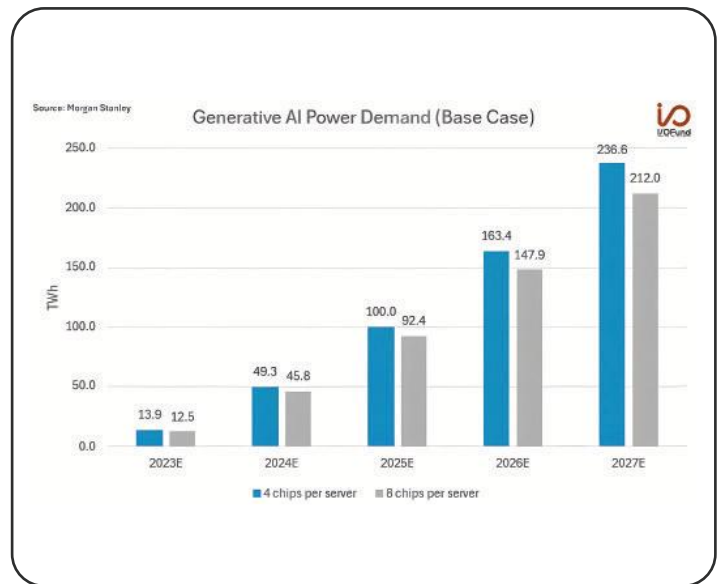
Power Consumption per AI Chip: A Growing Concern

Nvidia, AMD, and soon Intel have entered a transformative phase in developing AI accelerators, with power consumption per chip at the forefront of design considerations. In earlier generations, advancements focused primarily on compute power and memory capacity, but with each iteration, power demands have also increased. This rise in power consumption directly correlates with the need for greater computational power to train sophisticated models, such as the large language models that now serve as the backbone for AI applications.

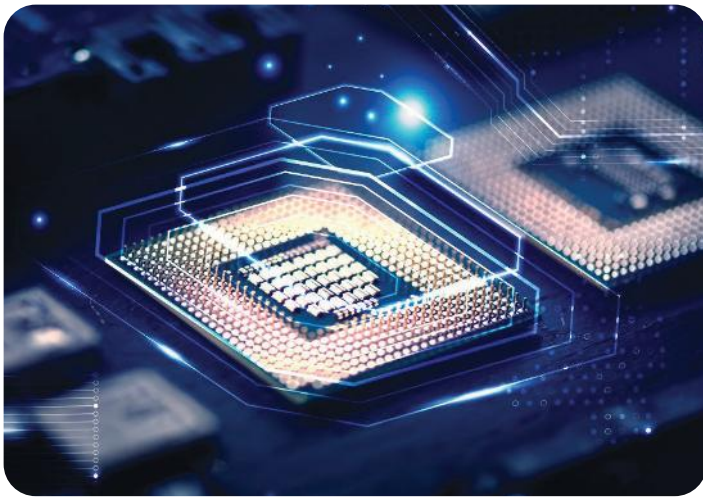
To illustrate, Nvidia's A100 model, which uses the PCIe interface, has a peak power consumption of 250W, while its successor, the H100, requires up to 350W in PCIe mode and as much as 700W using the SXM module, marking a staggering 75% increase. Similarly, AMD's MI250 accelerator operates at 500W, peaking at 560W, while its latest MI300x variant climbs to 750W,

showing an increase of nearly 50%. Intel's Gaudi 3 chip is expected to consume 900W, a significant jump from the 600W of Gaudi 2, and Nvidia's upcoming Blackwell series anticipates a peak of 1,200W in the B200, with the dual-GPU-and-CPU combination GB200 drawing up to 2,700W.

These advancements underscore a pressing challenge: with AI accelerators growing more powerful and power-hungry, the total energy required across data centers is scaling sharply. Yet, it's essential



to note that each generation brings incremental improvements in performance-per-watt. For instance, Nvidia's H100 GPU offers approximately three times the performance per watt compared to the A100, representing advancements in efficiency. But even with these strides, the rise in overall power demands reflects the intensifying computational needs of AI-driven applications.



Big Tech's Ambitious AI Investments and Energy Implications

The current trajectory of Big Tech's AI ambitions shows an enduring investment cycle, heavily weighted toward capital expenditures in AI infrastructure. Major companies are increasing their capital expenditures by more than 35% year-over-year, allocating over \$200 billion in 2024 alone, with a significant portion designated for GPU purchases and custom silicon to support AI model development. The demand for GPUs has grown substantially, with Nvidia's data center GPUs alone showing a year-over-year increase of 1.1 million units, contributing to an anticipated 14.38 TWh in annual power consumption. This staggering figure is roughly equivalent to the energy needs of 1.3 million households in the United States.

The increase in GPU shipments is also expected to impact infrastructure design, as exemplified by Larry Ellison's strategic shift at Oracle toward constructing data centers with on-site power plants and liquid cooling systems. This shift highlights the complexity of balancing the demand for increased AI computing power with the logistical needs of power distribution and heat dissipation.

Scaling to Million-GPU Data Centers and the Need for Energy Innovation

Looking toward the future, Nvidia and other leading companies are planning data center clusters with the capacity to scale from tens of thousands of GPUs to hundreds of thousands or even millions. Industry experts predict that achieving this scale will necessitate a stronger emphasis on power efficiency within each successive generation of AI accelerators. Cooling requirements are expected to grow correspondingly, pushing data centers to adopt advanced liquid cooling solutions to accommodate the intensified thermal loads of these large GPU arrays.

As we look to the next five to ten years, analysts such as Morgan Stanley and Wells Fargo predict surges in data center energy consumption fueled by the ongoing expansion of AI capabilities. For example, Morgan Stanley estimates that data center power usage will triple by the end of 2024, reaching 46 TWh, while Wells Fargo projects a 550% increase in AI power demand from 8 TWh in 2024 to 52 TWh by 2026, and eventually to 652 TWh by 2030. These projections suggest that AI's energy consumption could account for over 16% of current U.S. electricity demand.

To meet these challenges, companies like Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company (TSMC) are developing cutting-edge solutions at the foundry level. TSMC's advancements in node technology, moving from 5nm to 3nm and ultimately to 2nm, will enable AI accelerators to achieve higher efficiency through lower power consumption. The 3nm node, for example, offers up to a 30% reduction in power consumption compared to its 5nm predecessor. Future generations of chips are anticipated to integrate gate-all-around field-effect transistors (GAAFETs) to further reduce leakage and boost performance, allowing for more efficient handling of AI's increasing energy demands.

A Sustainable Path Forward for AI

As AI systems scale in size and complexity, addressing their power demands will be critical to ensuring sustainable and scalable growth. The industry is likely to face continued pressure to balance advancements in computing power with innovations in energy efficiency, and companies will need to continue collaborative efforts across the supply chain to meet these challenges. Leaders in AI, like Nvidia, AMD, and Intel, are already investing in technologies and designs to optimize power efficiency per chip, while data center architects and energy providers explore innovative cooling methods and renewable energy sources.

These developments represent a transformative moment for AI, where advancements in computational power must harmonize with energy considerations to support the industry's ongoing evolution. As AI's role in modern society grows, so too does the responsibility to manage its environmental footprint, ensuring that the journey to machine intelligence remains a sustainable one.



Pramuditha Vidushan
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InCo 10.0

InCo 2024 Showcasing Innovation and Creativity in Engineering Smart Solutions

The Invention Convention for Engineering Smart Systems for Industry (InCo), organized by the Department of Industrial Management of the University of Kelaniya, celebrated its sixth consecutive year with unparalleled energy and creativity. InCo 2024 focused on idea generation and turning those ideas into practical solutions to address real-world industrial challenges.

InCo 2024 brought together 16 teams from 2nd year Management and Information Technology (MIT) undergraduates, each armed with a vision to transform industries. The competition not only encouraged innovation but also fostered a vibrant environment for collaboration and learning. Esteemed judges, along with academics from the department, enriched the experience by offering constructive feedback that spurred participants to elevate their projects to new levels of brilliance.

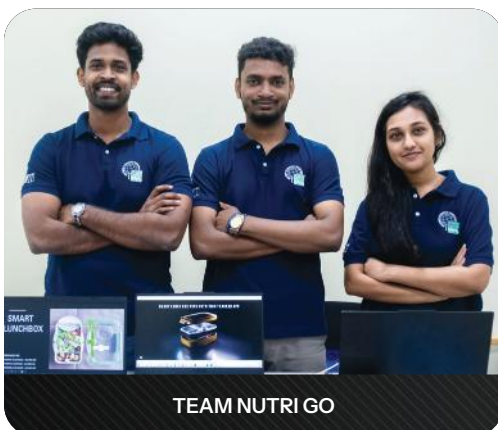
InCo 2024 was a showcase of exceptional talent, with Team Power Puff Girls stealing the spotlight. Their ingenious product, TransitEase—a revolutionary 3-in-1 travel pillow designed to redefine comfort during commutes—earned them the title of Overall Winners. The product's outstanding design also clinched the coveted Innovation Category Award, a testament to its creativity and functionality.

The first runner-up position went to Team Nutri Go for their NutriGo-Smart Lunch Box, a cutting-edge fusion of technology and convenience aimed at simplifying meal preparation. Not far behind, Team Innov Thermios captured the second runner-up spot with ZephyR, an adaptive comfort system that adjusts seamlessly to changing weather conditions.

Marketing prowess played a pivotal role in this year's competition, with Team Power Puff Girls, Team Nutri Go, and Team Idea Forge dominating the Marketing Category as the winner, first runner-up, and second runner-up, respectively. Their compelling promotional strategies were a masterclass in combining innovation with market readiness.



POWER PUFF GIRLS



TEAM NUTRIGO

This year's Most Popular Team Award was clinched by Team Genesis for their innovative product, SafeSense, a gas-leak detection and alert system that underscores the importance of safety and awareness in everyday life. Beyond the standout winners, InCo 2024 displayed a range of impressive products, highlighting the creativity and problem-solving skills of all the participants.

From eco-friendly designs to advanced safety systems, the event provided a window into the future of industrial innovation. Each team demonstrated a remarkable balance of imagination, practicality, and technical expertise, setting new benchmarks for the competition's legacy.



InCo 2024 stands as a resounding success, exemplifying how young innovators can harness their potential to address pressing global challenges. The event not only celebrated exceptional achievements but also ignited a passion for engineering and technology among its participants.

InCo 2024 was not just a competition but a developmental experience for undergraduates, allowing them to gain practical exposure to industry challenges. By working on real-world problems, students developed critical skills in research, design thinking, and product development, bridging the gap between theoretical knowledge

and practical application. This hands-on approach enabled them to transform imaginative ideas into tangible solutions, reaffirming InCo 2024's status as a place for innovation and growth. As this journey continues, it reminds us of the transformative power of youthful creativity and determination in shaping industries and society's future.



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GOOD
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AWARDS

Dr. Nadeesha Chandrasena

Dr. Nadeesha Chandrasena, a visionary in urban planning, continues to push boundaries toward a world of limitless possibilities. Her revolutionary invention, Smart Drain, which addresses a critical challenge in urban town planning, earned her recognition at the 2024 Australian Good Design Awards, proudly raising the Sri Lankan flag high on the international arena. This is the inspiring story of a woman redefining innovation and shaping the future of urban development.

1. Who is Nadeesha Chandrasena in your own words? Can you introduce yourself and explain why your work is so widely recognized?

I would describe myself as a woman in the field of technology and innovation. I am an urban planner and an environmental specialist based in Brisbane, Australia. My specialization lies in urban engineering, supported by a bachelor's degree in town and country planning, a master's in water management, and a PhD in civil engineering.

For years, I've been working on a stormwater drainage system designed to prevent solid clogging and overflows, which has received international recognition for its impact. In simple terms, I am an urban innovator, a mother, a wife, and, above all, a woman who believes in the transformative power of creativity and collaboration.

2. Your background roots in smart urban planning. What is urban planning, and what does smart innovation in planning mean?

Urban planning is about designing cities and communities to make them more livable, sustainable, and prepared for the future. It's not just about organizing land use but ensuring the spaces we live in can handle challenges like population growth, disasters, and everyday needs like housing, transportation, and public services.

Smart innovation in planning takes this a step further by using technologies like AI, IoT, and data analytics,

With the right people by your side, you can achieve incredible things.

Dreaming is important, but it's not enough on its own.

to solve real-world problems. It's about tackling issues like traffic, pollution, and sanitation in smarter, more efficient ways, creating cities that adapt and grow with the people who live in them.

3. You keep reshaping the urban planning spheres with your groundbreaking innovation, Smart Drain. Let's talk about it.

The product my team and I developed is a dual-layer smart drain system. Traditional drainage systems are prone to clogging due to solid waste such as plastic, leaves, and other debris that accumulate inside. This is particularly problematic during heavy rainfall, as the debris significantly reduces the drainage capacity, leading to flooding.

What we've designed addresses this issue by securely filtering solid waste from water through a dual-layer mechanism. This solution ensures that urban areas are better equipped to handle drainage challenges, reducing the likelihood of floods and improving overall water management in cities.

4. What inspired you to develop this product?

In densely populated areas, especially low-income settlements in developing countries, improper disposal of solid waste into drains is a common issue. This practice leads to clogged drainage systems, stagnant water, and health problems, including increased pest activity. Flash floods also occur more frequently, even with minimal rainfall, due to these blockages.

I realized that it might be unrealistic for compact cities to be completely free from improper solid waste disposal, but a smarter system capable of handling this could mitigate the effects of improper disposal. By securely filtering out solid waste from city drains, we can significantly reduce the probability of flash floods caused by clogging drains in urban areas. Additionally, stagnated water collection can be minimized, which in turn addresses health concerns and improves the aesthetics of urban living spaces.

5. This issue has been discussed for decades, yet it remained unaddressed until the 21st century. What do you think caused such a delay in finding a solution?



The topic of open-channel hydraulics and drainage systems is often overlooked in urban development discussions. In low-income countries and compact cities, the focus tends to be on essential needs like education, healthcare, and basic infrastructure, such as roads. Urban drainage often gets pushed to the bottom of the priority list when it comes to funding.

Compact cities may invest heavily in building roads but often neglect to improve the design of roadside drains, due to budget constraints. While it's true that cities prioritize spending on municipal waste management—sometimes allocating nearly half of their budget to it—these systems are often outdated and inefficient. The real issue lies in the lack of modernization and integration of technology. What we need are generational changes to physical infrastructure to create long-term, sustainable solutions.

6. How does the technology behind your smart drain system work?

In traditional designs, cities use U-shaped open drains. What we've done is retrofit a top layer to these existing U-shaped drains to create a dual-layer system. The top layer holds and traps solid waste,

preventing it from flushing into the water below. We've also integrated sensors into the design, which is what makes the drain system "smart". These sensors detect the fill levels of the solid waste mesh baskets and monitor the water flow velocity in the bottom layer. This information allows for timely maintenance and ensures the drainage system remains efficient.

7. You recently received significant recognition for your innovation at the Australian Good Design Awards. How does it feel to innovate something the world hasn't experienced before and represent your country on an international stage?

On September 17, 2024, I was honored to win the Best in Class Engineering and Gold Accolade at the Australian Good Design Awards. Representing Sri Lanka on such an international stage was incredibly fulfilling. It feels amazing to see years of hard work finally pay off and to know that this product is gaining global recognition.

The fact that this innovation is now being talked about worldwide opens up new opportunities and possibilities. It's a proud moment to know that we've created something impactful and meaningful.

8. What is the future of your smart drain system?

Looking ahead, I have a clear and realistic plan for the next two years. Our goal is to roll out this initial product in 10 cities across 10 countries. Since each location has unique needs and challenges, we'll refine and customize the design to suit the specific conditions of each area.

If the initial phase is successful, we plan to broaden our scope by integrating advanced technologies like AI and 3D printing. These innovations will help us enhance the system's functionality and scalability, making it adaptable to a wider range of environments. Additionally, the system includes a citizen-led community dashboard, ensuring it remains a collaborative and real-time infrastructure solution monitored and shaped by the community.

9. How has the journey of the Smart Drain been so far?

It has been a long journey, but one I've thoroughly enjoyed. Throughout the project, I've received immense support from my family, friends, community, and a dedicated team of seven core inventors who have been with me since 2012.

Their collaboration and commitment have been crucial in bringing this vision to life. I feel incredibly grateful to have had such a strong support system and the opportunity to contribute to a solution that benefits the world.

10. As you mentioned about the concurrent support you received from your community, let's also talk about the strength and the support you received from social media along the way.

Social media has been a huge pillar of support for this project. As an active social media user, I often saw people tagging me in posts about clogged drains, saying things like, "Nadeehsa can solve this." These messages motivated me to take action and find a solution.

In fact, the smart drain system team initially came together through social media. It's been incredible to see how these platforms can bring people together for a common cause.

11. With all that recognition and achievements received, what would your future look like?

I like to approach the future with clear, well-defined plans. I've outlined three key goals.

Plan A is to Launch a startup company around this product to further develop and scale it.

Then as the next alternative, Plan B is to Contribute to the Brisbane Olympics 2032 by sharing my expertise in infrastructure projects.

As plan C, I'd love to Establish a town planning consultancy to share my knowledge and experience with others who need it.

Having backup plans helps me a lot in preparing for

whatever stone life throws at me. It makes me excited to always try things out.

12. How important is it to dream?

Dreaming is important, but it's not enough on its own. You need to work toward those dreams with determination and a clear plan. For me, having defined goals and taking actionable steps is essential. While some people succeed by following their instincts, I prefer a systematic approach to achieve my aspirations.

I personally think that the method varies from person to person, but working toward your dreams is what truly makes them a reality.

13. What is your vision for the future of urban planning in smart cities?

My vision for urban planning in smart cities is to create communities that are sustainable, efficient, and adaptable, putting the needs of people and the environment at the forefront. By leveraging advanced technologies like AI, IoT, and data analytics, we can tackle real-world issues such as traffic congestion, sanitation, housing, waste management, and urban drainage in smarter, more practical ways.

In today's information era, citizen-led approaches must be an integral part of city operations. Empowering communities to contribute to urban planning and decision-making will ensure that cities evolve in ways that truly reflect the needs of their people. At the same time, it's crucial to modernize outdated systems and build resilient infrastructure that can keep up with population growth and changing demands.

The ultimate goal is to design cities that are not only livable and inclusive but also prepared for the future where innovation thrives, and long-standing urban challenges are addressed with sustainable, forward-thinking solutions.

14. What advice would you give to the next generation of innovators?

Teamwork is everything. Working together allows you to achieve far more in a shorter time than you could alone. Collaboration also brings diverse perspectives and shared knowledge, which is essential for driving innovation.

My advice is to pick the right team, work together, and aim high. With the right people by your side, you can achieve incredible things.



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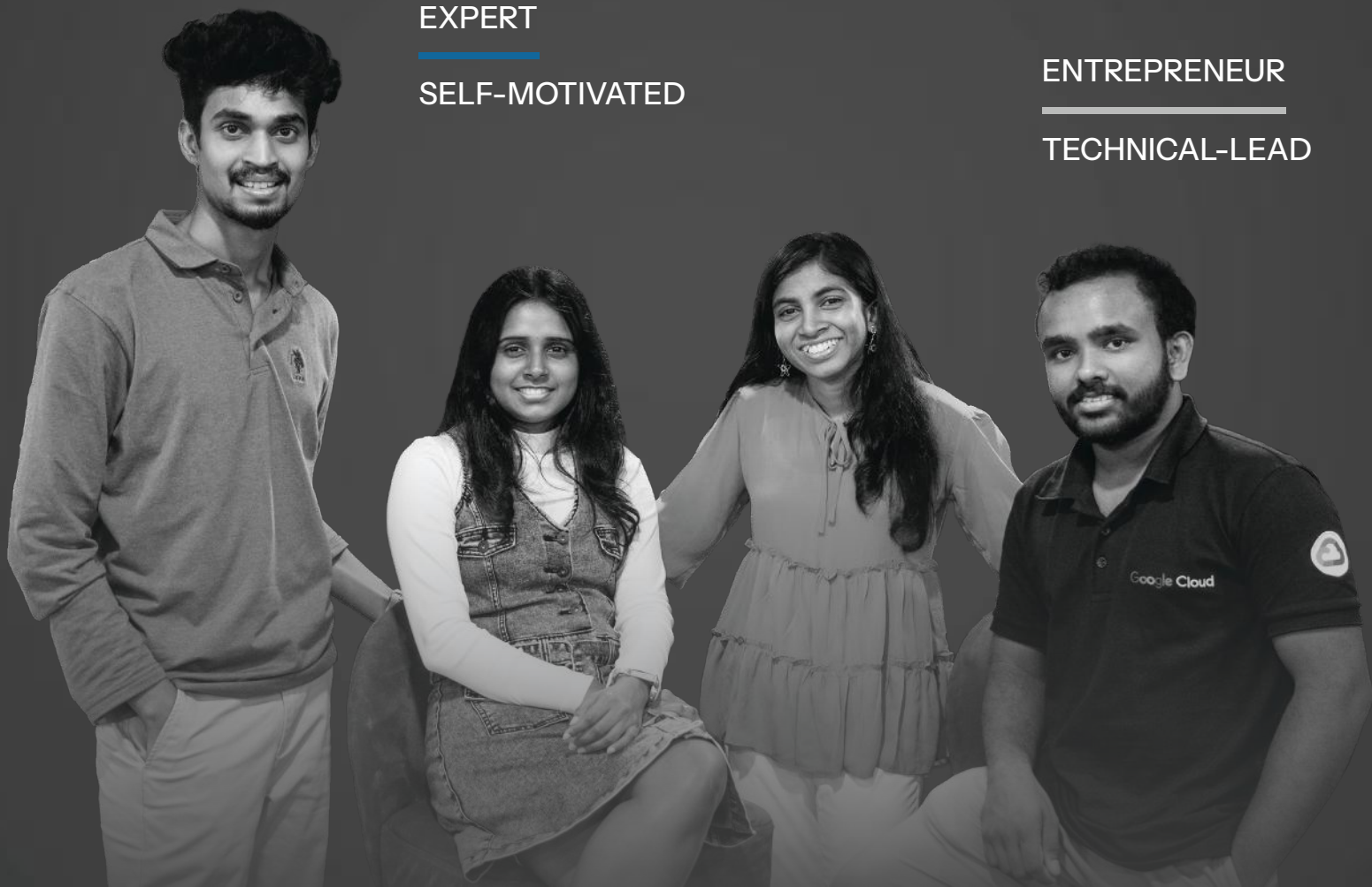
ARTISTIC-PASSION

EXPERT

SELF-MOTIVATED

ENTREPRENEUR

TECHNICAL-LEAD



01. How did you face the transition from school to university as a first-year undergraduate?

Transitioning from school to university was a new and exciting experience. The open, vibrant environment felt overwhelming at first, but the freedom and independence were refreshing. However, they also came with new responsibilities and challenges that pushed me out of my comfort zone.

University life is about self-management and adapting to a dynamic lifestyle. While academics matter, friendships, culture, and personal growth are what make it special. This time has been about both learning in class and growing as an individual.

02. What challenges have you encountered after joining the Department of Industrial Management, and how have you addressed them?

I was appointed as the batch representative early on, which was a big responsibility. Adjusting to the new environment, managing peer pressure, and building connections were challenging. I also had to coordinate events, meetings, and academic matters for the batch.

Since joining the department, I've participated in events like orientation programs and smaller activities that taught me teamwork, communication, and responsibility. Guidance from lecturers, junior staff,

and senior representatives helped ease my journey and overcome initial challenges.

03. What are your thoughts on being a part of the IM family, and what is your impression of this degree program?

At first, I wasn't sure about my choice of degree program, but after connecting with seniors and getting involved, I realized it offers diverse pathways in IT and Management, giving us the flexibility to pursue our passions.

Being part of the IM family has been a special experience focused on overall growth, not just academics. Events like hackX and hackX Jr. connect us with industry experts and help build skills, while other activities encourage creativity and personal development. The IM family provides a supportive environment that prepares us for future challenges.

04. How does your engagement in extracurricular activities at university compare to your school experience, and how do you balance them with academics?

Before university, I played cricket and table tennis and was part of the New Innovation Club, where I honed teamwork, leadership, and problem-solving skills. After joining university, I began freelancing, gaining hands-on experience in Social Media Marketing, SEO, Social Media Management, and Graphic Design. This experience helped me secure a spot on the university's media team.

I also secured an internship through a connection made during an academic project, which has been a great learning experience. While I don't get to play sports as much as I'd like due to these commitments, I still make time for cricket occasionally and even practice guitar when possible.

Balancing freelancing, my internship, extracurricular activities, and academics has been challenging but rewarding. University life requires more self-discipline and time management than school. I've learned to prioritize tasks, set realistic goals, and stay organized, helping me make the most of university freedom while staying on top of my responsibilities.



Lavindu Binuwara

The Sophomore

Empowering potential

365 X 2

01. As an enthusiastic second-year undergraduate, how has your journey been so far—both academically and personally? How have the Department of Industrial Management (DIM) and the MIT community influenced your growth?

I came through a door that was opened totally unexpectedly. I was changed to a whole new being facing challenges in an alien-like place with strange people. But the DIM gave me the guidance and inspiration I needed, to come this far.

After A/Ls, I ended up in confusion about my future. I'm so lucky that I got the chance to explore the combination of IT and Management, which was a turning point in my academic journey. As an MITian, I got hands-on experience in projects, competitions, events, industries & professionals focusing on both academics and personal progress.

The MIT family has been a key part of this transformation. We've shared challenges, celebrated successes, grown together through experiences, and created friendships that'll cherish forever. From the AGM to the Exposition we were molded into something we never imagined. So I'm pretty sure that I will enjoy the rest of the ride to an amazing destination.

02. In the second year of your Bachelor's degree, you must choose a specialization pathway between MIT and IT. Which pathway did you select, and what influenced your decision?

It was a conflicting question back at the point I had to select my degree, whether to explore more in maths or dig up a new path. So as usual I chose the most challenging one which was to explore a new field, but unexpectedly I was offered a 2-in-1 degree program, which laid the fundamentals of both management and IT in the 1st year. So when I got the chance to choose, I did not want to escape from management as in my initial plan of being equipped in two trending fields before I started my career, also with the advantage of switching the job field. I wanted to go with the combination although it's a heavy workload. I chose to specialize in Management and IT, targeting the IS path.

03. Since you are involved in many extracurricular activities in addition to your academic life, can you share how you manage and balance all these activities simultaneously?

Don't limit your challenges, challenge your limits. I think I have practiced the art of balancing since school time. Everything is cool? No, I'm struggling with the time, same as you. You have to plan your day, maybe the whole week, and prioritize. Better if you can, but there's no need to do it daily for a fixed time. For me, trying it is how it all started. After A/Ls, I've done teaching, designing, dressmaking, drawing, and martial arts. It's hard to start on your own, but it's even harder to continue and wait for progress no matter what.

Extracurriculars are not a burden. It is the savior when I'm stressed with my academics. I use them as energy boosters. I do it if I feel it. My passion guides me, one simple step at a time.

04. So, when you have a goal and the determination to achieve it, you keep pushing yourself. You mentioned practicing Kung Fu. How has that experience been for you?



Samadhi Wadithya

I'm a Miyagi fan. With that urge, I started my practices with my master Deepik Kariyawasam. In the middle of last year, I faced the 1st grading. I had to do daily self-practicing, which was the most challenging experience I've ever had. Every weekend, despite all the obstacles I went to Galle for the class even during the exams. Practicing Wing Chun, Jeet Kune Do, Stick fighting, and Nunchaku made me mentally stronger than physically because I found my source of trust in martial arts doing the things that were once impossible for me. We had a boot camp to develop leadership and team spirit, which also taught me a lot of life lessons. And now, I'm getting ready for my 2nd grading.

05. Given that, could you explain how these extracurricular activities have shaped who you are today, and what strengths you've gained through them?

As a President's guide who follows the motto "Be Prepared", and as a senior prefect at school, I already had the dedication to complete whatever responsibility I take, being adaptive to the situation. I got the strength to develop physical well-being and accept challenges with confidence, after becoming a martial artist. Art helps me calm my mind, enjoy nature, and improve my creative thinking. Designing helps me to release stress. The events organized by our IM Department further improved my practical management skills like planning and organizing. Being a part of the SR Avenue of Rotaract Club at our university helps broaden my network. I also got the chance to develop my interpersonal skills and public speaking through AIESEC.

“Be prepared for anything that comes your way.”



06. You're skilled in reactive design and technical work. How has being a creative designer helped you?

After A/Ls, I was trying another item on my bucket list... designing. I got certified in the basics of graphic designing and learned Photoshop and Illustrator. I was lucky to join the IM Media Unit as a graphics designer and there, I got the chance to learn a lot from friends and professionals in designing. As I'm targeting UI/UX designing, all these hours won't go in vain and it even help me to excel in Figma. I've also participated in some UI/UX competitions. Additionally, my role as a designer of the Creative Regiment in AIESEC helps me share creativity with designers from different fields.

07. Since you have a passion for art beyond just design, could you finally share some of your achievements and future plans in this area?

Every story has a pain point. I wanted to do Literature for O/Ls. I regret that I had to step back in my art journey at that point. I had that golden history of presenting my drawings in competitions and even won an international-level silver award.

After seven years, I met the best art teacher last year. I tried figure drawing, still life drawing, and watercolors. And now, I'm looking forward to oil painting and holding tools like palette knives. Having an interest in pottery and handicrafts, I'm pretty sure that I will tick all these on my bucket list.

01. Your journey began in the field of Biological Science and later transitioned to IT. What motivated this shift, and how did it influence your career path?

Yes, very correct. Initially, I wanted to become a doctor. So, I did my A/Ls in the Biological Science stream. For better or for worse I did not get selected for the Medical Faculty.

As the saying goes, everything happens for a reason, and all these things were happening to me for a very good reason, because now I am living a life that I always wanted to live.



Mishara Wickramasinghe

02. How has participating in various extracurricular activities during your school years contributed to your personal development and influenced your career in the industry?

My school is Sanghamiththa Girls' College, Galle. Being a Sanghamiththian I achieved a lot in my life. As you already mentioned I did many things during my school life. We were actually privileged to have those

invaluable opportunities in our school. If I give you an example, at the age of sixteen I even got a chance to travel to the UK; and some other countries as well. Those experiences made me a different person. Even now when I am entering the industry, it has become a plus point for me.

Our former principal, Mrs. Saraswathi Dahanayaka was such a pretty lady. There was a saying that she always used; “තෙවිල්ල පදවන අත ලොව පාත්ත කරවයි”, “The Hand that Rocks the Cradle Rules the World”. That simple statement made this girl that you see today. I still believe that it is the level of confidence that every girl should have.

03. Can you take us back to the beginning of your MIT journey and share some of those beautiful memories from three years ago?

I would say that it's a lucky coincidence. In 2022, it's the month of January as far as I can remember. Suddenly I got a text message from UGC instructing me to get registered for a certain degree program. I went in and saw that I had been selected to MIT which I never thought I would. That is how I started my IM journey.

There, I met a wonderful group of friends, my batchmates. Even before we started our academics, we had some meetups, trips, and all the fun stuff.

Then on, the entire two to three years we had a great time. We had events going on, batch trips, outings, OBTs, and even these tiny little fights and the academic stress that we handled very nicely.

There are lots of incidents that have now become the sweetest memories for us all. Among them, our talent show is something that we still recall as one of the hardest, still the happiest times we spent together. We named it “Magul Kema”. And we really made it an unforgettable memory for ourselves as well as the others.

Just like that, the DIM became my kind of place to spend my uni life in the way that I always wanted to.

04. Team Matriarchy; what is Team Matriarchy?

Team Matriarchy is simply a squad of four girls; Navienya, Shadurceya, Chathumini, and myself. To be honest it is a random team we made for ideasprint, our intra-departmental ideathon. We never thought that it would reach that far. At ideasprint 2022, we became the first runners-up and got selected as the finalists of hackX 2022. There we got close guidance from one of our lecturers, Dr. Shan Jayasinghe. He guided us in developing that simple idea into a business concept.

With that, we won several hackathons and received some good partnerships from several industry leaders as well. Rather than that, the most valuable thing I achieved there is the experience of working as a team. We were from different parts of the country having different backgrounds. Even our ethnicities and languages were different. So naturally, it is not easy to have a smooth flow of things.



Despite everything, finally, we marked a significant milestone of our project, Project WasteLance, by becoming the semi-finalists of the Dialog Innovation Challenge, which was also telecast on TV Derana, letting our concept reach a larger audience.

05. You chose to specialize in Operations and Supply Chain Management. How has this specialization complemented your role in the industry?

Honestly, without any specific reason I chose it in the beginning. Luckily, I got a chance to join this training program called, InspirED organized by Advantis 3PL. It was a privilege for myself and three other MITians to be among the 20 selected undergraduates from

various state and private universities in Sri Lanka.

We had sessions covering all the areas related to logistics and more importantly, had some site visits which gave us more practical experience. That specific training improved my interest in logistics which is one of the most stable industries in the world of economics. This same experience and the academic profiles we learned in our specialization helped me secure my current position in the industry as well.

06. In May 2023, you received another significant opportunity within IM which is the position of the Secretary of IMSSA. During such a challenging time, how did you manage to contribute to the success and changes within the organization?

It is something very unexpected that happened in my life; one of the turning points I would say.

Yes, it was challenging as you mentioned, but with a team with lots of dedication and affection towards each other, it became such an accomplishment for me, as well as the IMSSA. During that one year, IMSSA became the most significant part of my life.

Starting from intra-departmental events and ending up with some large-scale corporate events like hackX, hackX Jr., and Exposition, we were able to add more value to the organization, ultimately increasing the standard of each event. Many other initiatives like public relations campaigns and career fairs added immense value to the organization. Each and every step we took marked several milestones in the IMSSA history.

I even got the opportunity to gain many experiences like communicating with corporate people, handling partners, and especially working with these media companies. I should say that this position never became a burden for me. There were two reasons behind that. One is that I loved that role and the work and responsibilities that I had been assigned to. The second and most important reason was that I had an amazing team alongside me. Especially my IMSSA committee, my fellow batchmates including our event coordinators and their OCs, as well as my family.

Many changes occurred. Challenges were thrown at us. Inconsistencies and arguments arose. But we, as a team, overcame them all, making it one of the most amazing times at IMSSA. That year will never be forgotten from my memory.

07. Now that you are in your internship, what helped

you stand out in your interview, and how has the internship experience further enhanced your skills and knowledge?

This was the first time I entered this lively corporate setup. Simply, this is my first job. A new environment with new people usually makes me nervous. But this time it was different. Maybe it is the level of confidence that had been built within me during the last two years that helped me receive a good placement from the very first interview I faced. At that point, I must thank our industrial mentor, Mr. Harsha Dinendra too. He is the one who helped me in preparation for this specific interview. This industrial mentoring program is one of the most reliable initiatives taken by our department.

So, now I am working at EFL Global, a giant in logistics. Global IT is the department that I belong to. There I have a really good team and a working culture. Not only in Sri Lanka; but part of our team is also in the US. Simply put, this is an operational and analyst role that supports the IT-business applications within EFL. So far, I am enjoying my new life at EFL, I should say.

08. How do you believe your internship experience will contribute to your personal and career development? Could you also share some insights and benefits of internships?

For career development obviously, it affects very positively. This is where most of us start our career life. But it is not just limited to career development. An internship is not all about a career. You meet new people. You are exposed to new cultures. Even, gatherings, celebrations, food, travel, volunteering, and many more for you to experience there. That is a once-in-a-lifetime experience that you must take.

09. You are an AIESECer. Do you believe organizations like this are essential for university students, and what insights can you share about your experiences in AIESEC?

Of course yes. The university is not all about attending lectures and doing exams. Organizations like AIESEC, Roteract, Leo, and even the sports teams give you a different experience in your uni life. That is where you meet people outside your circle.

The most important learning I got from AIESEC is the competency of correct decision-making, and also coping-up with people. When working I had a lot of controversies there. I always had to make tough decisions. As an example, there was a time when I even had to decide whether to continue one of my major roles. As I made the correct decision there,

despite all the challenges I faced, finally I received lots of compliments for what I did. So like that, very recently I ended my two years of AIESEC journey as a PR Manager for National PR Team.

10. How did you balance your roles in both the university and national PR teams at AIESEC, and what key skills help you manage these responsibilities?

Actually, the National PR team is my biggest accomplishment in AIESEC. Not only that position but for all the other positions I handled in AIESEC, I had to perform parallelly with my department's work; especially with my role as the IMSSA secretary. There were times I was too depressed and even wanted to give up.

But every time I learned to move on with patience, just because of the people who were backing me up, always being there for me when I needed them the most, and encouraging me to do the right thing in such crucial situations. Here, I am truly grateful to those people.

If I give you a straightforward answer to what you asked, how did I manage; I would say, learn from your own experiences, take a break when you need one, think quietly, and make brave decisions; the right decision, at the right time.



The Senior

Igniting Innovation

365 X 4

01. Your passion for Information Technology is inspiring. How did it guide your journey into cloud computing and artificial intelligence?

From my early school days, I was always curious about how computers work and what they are made of, which led me to the field of Information Technology from the very first day I got my own computer. I was always looking for ways to solve everyday problems using technology. This drive pushed me to learn more and more about IT.

My interest grew even more once I was selected for this degree program. With the rise of AI and cloud technology, I became fascinated with applying these new trends to real-life situations to solve practical problems. This keeps me motivated every day.

02. How has your experience as a Microsoft Learn Student Ambassador influenced your enthusiasm for cloud engineering and shaped your career aspirations?

During my second year, I applied for the Microsoft Learn Student Ambassador program after hearing about it from my seniors. Getting selected was truly a turning point for me. The connections and resources provided by the program further inspired my passion for cloud technologies.

As a Beta MLSA, I had access to Azure resources, which became my playground for trying out new projects and ideas. This hands-on experience taught me a lot and deepened my interest in cloud and AI technologies. Additionally, I conducted sessions and cloud skill challenges for my fellow batchmates, sharing knowledge about cloud technologies and software applications. The experience and knowledge I gained from these activities have significantly shaped my career aspirations.

03. As a Postman Student Leader, how would you define your role? What innovative strategies have you employed to make API literacy more accessible and engaging for your peers?

Postman Student Leader is part of a student ambassador program initiated by the Postman API platform. The main goal is to educate undergraduates

and school students about API literacy. I was selected as a Postman Student Leader while interning at Axiata Digital Labs. During my internship, working as a backend developer, I had to learn and use a lot of APIs. This experience provided me with practical knowledge about API development and testing.



Tharuka Sandaruwan

As a Postman Student Leader, I conducted sessions for my fellow batchmates and students, teaching them how to use APIs and the fundamentals of APIs in real-world projects based on my experience. I always enjoy sharing what I learn with others, and this passion motivated me to apply for these ambassador programs, which also gave me tons of experiences.

04. Securing the first runner-up spot in the Huawei ICT competition must have been challenging and a very proud moment for you. Could you share your experience?

Yes, it is an unforgettable moment for me. Becoming the first runner-up among all the talented undergraduates

Level 04

was a huge achievement. I participated in the Cloud Track in the Huawei ICT Competition 2023/24, which was hosted by Huawei Technologies around the world, making it very challenging to reach the national level.

My passion for cloud computing and big data played a crucial role in my journey towards success. The track had questions related to cloud, big data, and storage. Before the competition, they also conducted knowledge-sharing sessions to help us improve our understanding. I am grateful to the organizers for their support and guidance.

05. What do you think the future holds for AI and digital art, especially in light of your achievement at the Pixelate Digital Art Competition?



Winning the Pixelate Digital Art Competition organized by the Leo Club of the University of Kelaniya, was another moment where I could combine my passion for AI with my creativity. There, I created an AI-generated art piece under the theme of Global Warming.

With new technology and trends, your imagination is the only limit. Even if you are not good at drawing, you can create anything you imagine. In the past, expressing imagination was limited to those who could

draw. But now, thanks to tools like Stable Diffusion and other drawing models, anyone can be a great artist.

However, it's important to use these technologies responsibly and ethically. We need to be mindful of how we use AI in art and ensure we are respectful and considerate in our creations.

06. Leading the Automated Waste Categorization Project (Melbourne Project) was a significant responsibility. How did you navigate that challenge?

Initially, we started the project in our second year as a small initiative, with just 10 members. We were told that it was just a small project. However, after our first discussion with the team at the University of Melbourne, we realized its importance. The project was conducted in collaboration with the Australian government, with the objective of automating the recycling of waste materials. We, representing the University of Kelaniya, collaborated by annotating the necessary dataset to build the machine learning model.

In our team, I served as a Technical Lead and the Project Manager from the students' side. This was a valuable opportunity for me to apply my technical skills to a real-world project with a significant impact. It was also challenging since, as the technical lead, I had to manage all the technical infrastructure and processes. During this time, I learned a lot about machine learning and even developed a model to automatically annotate the data sets. This made our team's job easier, sped up the process, and improved the project's quality.

07. As someone who has participated in various hackathons, what surprising lessons have you learned through those experiences?

When I think about hackathons, the last one, "Codiers VII," organized by ACES of the University of Peradeniya, comes to mind first. In that event, we secured 5th place out of over 70 teams from universities around Sri Lanka. The hackathon was an overnight challenge, running from 6 p.m. to 6 a.m. the next morning. We had to solve coding problems related to algorithms throughout the night. It was a thrilling experience that I really enjoyed.

Hackathons allow us to brainstorm and come up with novel solutions related to computer engineering and algorithms. In our regular curriculum, we don't often get the chance to dive deep into algorithm-related problems. However, hackathons provide an excellent opportunity to learn how to apply algorithms to

create innovative solutions. This experience improved my creative thinking and taught me the importance of algorithms when tackling new problems.

08. Your research on a Vulnerability Auto-Healing System is impressive. Could you give us some insight into the project and share what future developments you envision?



Sure. Today, many of us use large language models (LLMs) and other generative AI tools for tasks such as text generation, image generation, and many more tasks. With the increase in devices, the need for proper cybersecurity methods are also essential.

So I am leveraging the power of LLMs to automate the vulnerability identification and healing process. LLMs can be like double-edged swords; There are already threat actor models like WormGPT and FraudGPT. So, I'm using LLMs to secure valuable infrastructure from these threats.

The current proof of concept can automate the vulnerability identification and fixing process. These days, I'm working on fully automating the tool. If we can improve this methodology, we can create self-healing systems, reducing the need for human intervention in vulnerability fixing.

09. As a Co-Founder and Technical Lead at VarienTX Solutions, what has been your proudest achievement so far, and how has it shaped your vision for the company's future?

We started as a small startup with eight members from our batch. We have already delivered several projects to our customers, and they were very happy with our work and the support we provided throughout the process.

These days, we are working on a project for one of the leading soft drink manufacturers in Sri Lanka,

developing a warehouse management system. Our team has a diverse set of skills, including project managers, business analysts, front-end and back-end developers. I handle the role of solution architecture and act as the technical lead for the team.

This initiative has helped us make valuable connections with partners. Most of the projects we received later came from recommendations by our previous clients. We are proud to be a company that leaves a good impression on our clients. This is our proudest achievement so far, and it shapes our vision to continue delivering high-quality solutions and building strong relationships with our clients.

10. Your trip to TechnoVIT 2024 in India sounds like a whirlwind of experiences. Could you share the extraordinary moments, both technically and culturally?

Sure, it was one of the most memorable trips of my life. I made a lot of memories and connections. TechnoVIT was the annual technical event at the VIT Chennai campus, filled with a variety of events and sessions over three days. Besides the main event, we had the opportunity to attend courses at the university. I participated in courses on power electronics, electric vehicles, and robotics, which excited me since I have been interested in these areas since childhood.

During the event, I met students from 11 countries across four continents, including Bangladesh, Brazil, Indonesia, Japan, Malaysia, Mexico, Peru, Tanzania, Uruguay, and Uzbekistan. So I got the opportunity

“Passion Meets
Technology,
Dreams Become
Reality.”

to learn about their cultures and make some long-lasting friendships.

We also enjoyed participating in cultural events at TechnoVIT and tasted delicious Indian cuisine during our stay. As you said, it was a whirlwind of experiences, both technically and culturally.

11. Beyond your professional journey, what other passions drive your creativity and inspire your ambitions?

I have a great passion for IT and always stay updated with the latest technological trends, which I believe is crucial in this ever-evolving field. As a hobby, I enjoy solving real-world problems through technology. I often work on pet projects, such as developing small IoT-based applications to help others automate tasks and improve efficiency. This hands-on experience allows me to constantly learn, test new ideas, and gain valuable skills. It also drives me to explore multidisciplinary projects, broadening my knowledge across various domains.

I strongly believe in the saying, 'Experience is the best teacher,' and I make it a point to learn through practical application.

Apart from technology, I have a deep appreciation for art and enjoy creating drawings, particularly those inspired by nature and wildlife. Additionally, I am passionate about giving back to society. I actively participate in community service initiatives such as



beach cleanups, Shramadana campaigns, and other CSR-based projects. I believe that when we are part of a society, we should not only take but also contribute in meaningful ways. This philosophy motivates me to do good whenever I can.

Overall, my passion for technology, creativity, and community service fuels my ambition to make a positive impact both professionally and socially.

12. As we wrap up, reflecting on your four exciting years as an MITian, what words of encouragement or advice would you share with juniors aspiring to begin their own adventurous journeys?

Be adaptable to anything. That's the main advice I would like to share with my juniors. It's a must in today's fast-moving technology world. We need to adapt quickly to thrive in modern technological professions. Mastering the ability to adapt to changes is a lifesaving skill as we never know what will happen next. Always be prepared for anything that comes your way.

Another crucial piece of advice is to love what you do and enjoy the journey. Collect memories while working on both your academic and personal life. This habit will enrich your experience and make your journey more fulfilling. So, embrace your work with passion and cherish every moment.

And finally, never give up. There will be times where you'll feel like you can't go on, but my advice is to keep pushing forward. Because MITians never give up!





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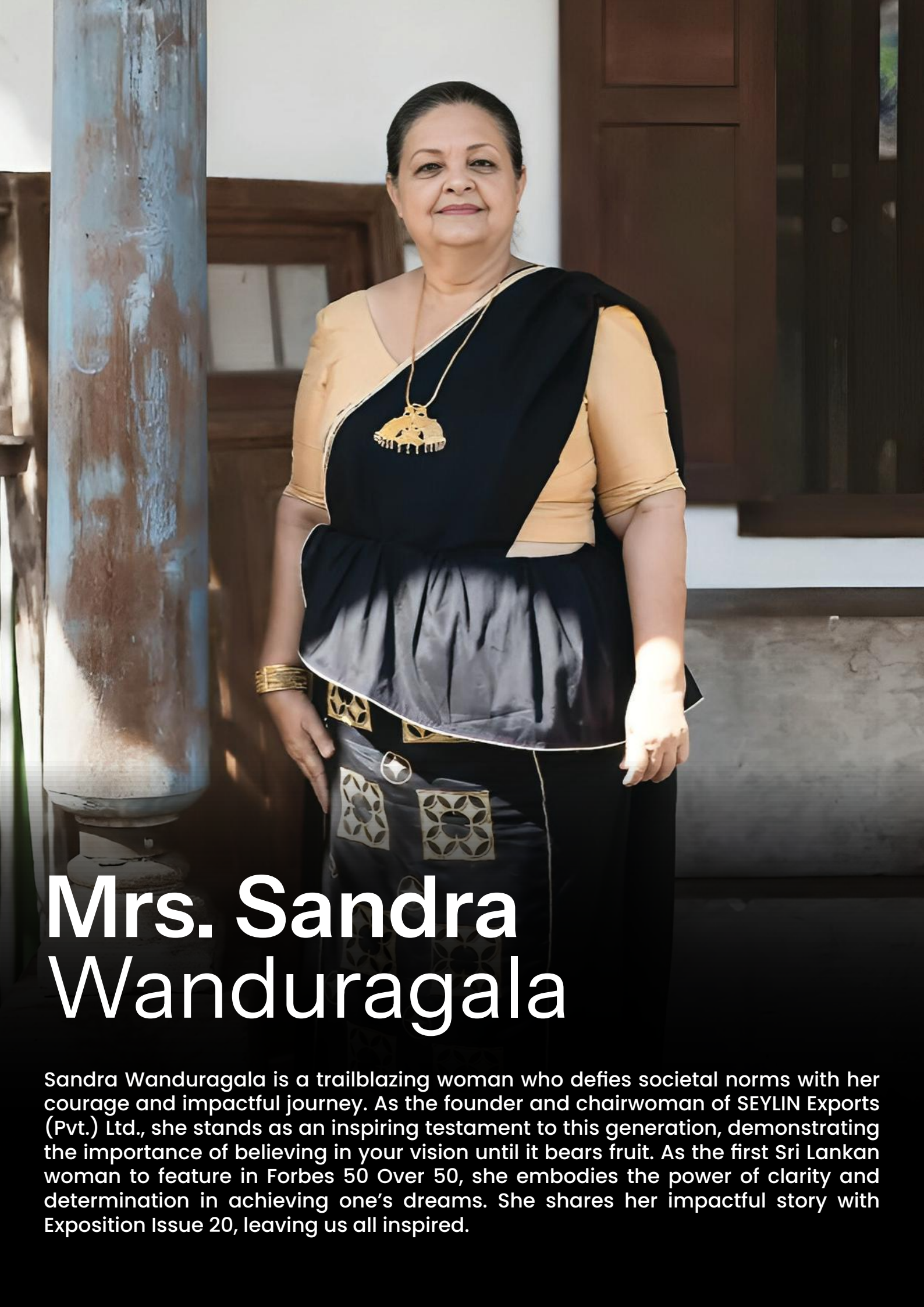


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Mrs. Sandra Wanduragala

Sandra Wanduragala is a trailblazing woman who defies societal norms with her courage and impactful journey. As the founder and chairwoman of SEYLIN Exports (Pvt.) Ltd., she stands as an inspiring testament to this generation, demonstrating the importance of believing in your vision until it bears fruit. As the first Sri Lankan woman to feature in Forbes 50 Over 50, she embodies the power of clarity and determination in achieving one's dreams. She shares her impactful story with Exposition Issue 20, leaving us all inspired.

1. Who is Sandra? Could you share your journey and tell us about yourself? What aspects of your life and career have made you a widely discussed and inspiring figure?

Sandra is a powerful woman and she gets stronger when she's challenged. She is a woman who has given her life for the good of others. So, if I switch to what I'm doing now, I'm the founder and chairwoman of SELYN Exports (Pvt.) Ltd. and SELYN Handicrafts (Pvt.) Ltd. It's a textile company that manufactures and exports handwoven and other textile products.

I'm also the co-founder and, currently, the chairwoman of Royal International School, Kurunegala, which has around 3,300 students. I have been there during the growth of the school and SELYN. I am also a practising lawyer. I do have a fair amount of notarial practice, where I still practice the profession. And I am, of course, a mother of two. I have been balancing my life with this. So obviously, I am very busy.

2. As you mentioned about SELYN, the company's story dates back to 1991, when you started the company with 15 women in your hometown of Wanduragala. Could you share more about how it all began and what inspired you to start this journey?

As I mentioned, I've studied law and practised as a lawyer. However, I was presented with an opportunity to start a company, which led me to establish this

I believe respect and acceptance should naturally exist in society. It all begins at home.

If you want to step out and take on challenges, it requires stepping out of your comfort zone.

handloom business. It was an unexpected chance that allowed me to venture into a completely different field outside of my legal career.

At the time, I was doing quite well in my legal profession, but my children were very young. Despite this, I strongly desired to do something meaningful for the country. Initially, I thought that politics might be the way to achieve that. However, the opportunity to start a business soon entered my life.

This shift was partly influenced by my husband, who is a businessman. Although he wasn't directly involved in the company, he played a key role in helping me get started. With his support, I began the business with 15 women in Wanduragala, using a small property my father had given me as dowry.

At the time, there was a significant boom in private enterprises in the country, as you are well aware, under the leadership of Mr. R. Premadasa. We were selected and sent to various markets, where we could explore opportunities to develop exportable products. The government's support played a crucial role in helping us position ourselves as exporters. When I started the company, I realized that handloom is a part of Sri Lanka's heritage and it is deeply embedded in our culture and identity. I thought it would be wonderful to preserve these traditions and carry them forward for future generations to experience, although it has become very challenging now.



But anyhow, I started with fabric, then I deviated into finished products with fabrics. Later, we started the toy section of the company, which was an innovation at that time, along with the textiles we produced. Then we began exporting toys, which remains one of our largest export segments today. However, we have continuously refined our products and processes over the years. It has now been nearly 33 years, and on the sixth of November 2024, we'll mark the 34th anniversary of SELYN.

Now, the leadership at SELYN is gradually transitioning to my daughter, Selyn. Also, my brother, Hillary, has been instrumental in managing the business operations. I believe my greatest strength lies in delegating, trusting, and empowering people. It's about trusting others to achieve my vision, making them believe in what we aim to accomplish, and helping them see the good that will come from it. Additionally, I strive to motivate my team, explaining why we should be doing it.

So, that's the story of SELYN, it has come a long way. We have evolved into a very strong social enterprise with a big social mission for which we have been recognized by the World Fair Trade Organization, as the first fair trade guaranteed textile company in the country.

We were selected as a pilot for that project, and now operate as an ethical company. We prioritize people, the planet, and our products, ensuring we are

environmentally conscious, socially responsible, and focused on quality. This approach sets us apart from other companies. That's why SELYN stands out in the industry.

3. As you mentioned, being a practising lawyer, was it challenging to step into an unfamiliar world like the textiles and fabric industry?

Being a lawyer actually has benefited me in the business because I think more logically and also our minds are trained to think differently. But the textile business needs a lot of creativity. And until I started SELYN, I never even knew that a creative person was living inside me. So the whole creative side of me came out and I exactly know what will sell and what will not. So I look at any product from the perspective of the market.

That clarity of thought is what drives success. My legal background has been a significant asset, and knowing how to navigate challenges is especially important for a woman. I think I have the skills to survive any challenge that comes to me, thanks to my legal background, so it has helped me a lot.

4. It seems like your legal background has become a significant strength. Speaking of strengths, let's talk about your team. Who are the key groups of employees you aim to empower at SELYN?

We mainly look at women who cannot go out to work because we have a very strong home-based worker model and also women who cannot go abroad for domestic work. And mainly the rural women who are interested in working and working on a craft, who also can work in their comfort at home balancing the family. That is our target group. And we have a small segment working centrally. However, the main target group is the home-based workers. Yes, so from that you plan to empower women who live in rural areas.

5. 2008 was a milestone year for SELYN, marking your move to Colombo. How did you navigate the transformation of stepping out of your comfort zone in Kurunegala to establish a presence in the bustling Colombo market?

Before 2008, we were primarily export-oriented and didn't focus much on the local market. However, the economic recession in Europe that year significantly impacted our exports, which dropped by a huge percentage.

At that point, we realized it was the right time to enter the local market. This shift in strategy proved to be

a success, although the operations were challenging. Initially, our entry into the local market was through partnerships with other businesses in Colombo. However, in 2008, we decided to open our own shop, driven by the decline in exports and the recognition.

6. You keep pushing boundaries to expand SELYN's horizons. One such initiative is SELYN Play. Can you share more about SELYN Play highlighting the inspirations behind this collection?

We aim to send a powerful message to children while allowing them to play with their favourite toys. We believe that selling products should always be accompanied by a meaningful story. For example, we address issues like bee extinction, teaching children through play, why bees are disappearing and their environmental importance. We also have products like the Ocean Pouch, which educates children on how plastic pollution harms marine life and contributes to oceanic extinction.

We try to promote this kind of education through our toys. I believe it's very important for children to learn about these major issues, as they will encounter them as adults. By planting these concepts in young minds, we can help them view the world differently and encourage them to appreciate these important topics.

7. You keep integrating and trying new things out, without being stagnated. Can you walk us through some fresh projects that you initiated at SELYN recently, and what's the best quality that SELYN has achieved over the past years?

I believe it's our tendency and determination to innovate. For example, we now have a process called blockchain. Of course, my daughter deserves credit for that, as I come from an earlier generation. She has been instrumental in bringing such innovations to the company.

She supports the company as the Business Development Director. We implemented a blockchain system where each product has a chip and barcode, tracing its journey from the manufacturer. We were the first textile company in Sri Lanka to introduce blockchain, marking a significant innovation.

Another initiative was the Build Good project. During COVID, we lost most of our orders, and we didn't know how we would pay our workers. That's when I came up with the idea of making washable fabric masks from off-cuts. Our tendency to innovate allows us to see opportunities even in challenging situations.

Years ago, I envisioned addressing period poverty, leading to the washable sanitary napkin project. We began by educating young women about menstrual hygiene through workshops. Now, my daughter spearheads the project via the SELYN Foundation. I believe that staying attuned to challenges, maintaining a positive outlook on what we should be innovating, and being mindful of what's happening in the world are all essential to our approach.

8. You were featured in Forbes 50 Over 50, and not only that, you're the only Sri Lankan female to be featured in that category. We heard that this happened unexpectedly, but considering the pool of talented and experienced counterpart entrepreneurs, what do you think made you stand out and earned you this recognition?

I think the kinds of things that we do, people watch. And I always believe very firmly that good will always return. When you think good, when you're trying to do good to the community, it will always return and there will be someone somewhere who will appreciate you. So that's how I thought about this whole thing. And me being the first woman who has got it for Sri Lanka is wonderful, and I think I've made my country proud. I have no idea how much people have appreciated it, but I'm very humbled that I have got it.

I wasn't recognized by many, as only a few people reached out to congratulate me. Not many seemed to take much notice of it. But that's okay; I received the recognition I needed, even if it wasn't widely acknowledged. I'm not too concerned about it.

9. Did you realize later that your commitment to doing good and staying true to your values shaped SELYN's success?

Yes, even for SELYN, I was determined to make it the best textile company. When I started, I faced many challenges. But whenever I do something, I want to do it properly. It's just part of who I am. I'm a very hard taskmaster, and I expect people to believe in what they do and to learn along the way. Life is very short. You can't play around. It's today we are here, tomorrow we might not. So we can't fool around.

10. Do you think you are a perfectionist?

Yes, I can be a bit much at times. Being a perfectionist can place significant demands and stress on you. However, I've learned to adopt a degree of tolerance because striving for perfection was causing me unnecessary pressure.

11. Everyone comes into this world with a mission. What do you believe your mission is?

I believe my mission right now is to share my experience. Currently, I'm working at a school and also leading it. My goal is to see the students grow into good human beings, instilling values in them, providing the best possible education, and giving them the exposure they need to excel in the world.

So I want to do a bit for the country, and also for myself. And I want to leave a legacy at the point of death. And I want to utilize this life which I have got, which is very valuable, to the maximum. Utilize my time and my life to the maximum to do good for society. So my mission will not end there.

I have other plans. After all, I feel a sense of urgency because I am now almost ending my life. But still for all it will continue. So to leave something which others can continue and where the benefit will be for the people of this country.

12. If you were to give a piece of advice to Sandra who is just starting her business Who is struggling with her business, to establish it, what would you say to her?

I will of course tell her one business is enough. Don't go for two because focus is very important and you also have to live. If you ask me whether I have lived, I can't remember because I've always been focusing on my businesses and what's next and how to do this, how to do that.

There is also a woman in me. So I'd say focus on one thing.

13. Are you happy about the rights that women in Sri Lanka have in general? Or do you think that there is anything that needs to be changed within this country?

I believe that rights exist, but exercising them is a matter of personal choice. There's no basis for saying that men are better than women. We are all equal. It's all about perspective and mindset. Ultimately, it comes down to the choices you make in life. If you want to step out and take on challenges, it requires stepping out of your comfort zone.

So, you have to be brave enough to step out and get there. We shouldn't focus on fighting for the rights we already have; instead, we should demand respect. I believe there is a significant lack of respect for women in this country, and it truly annoys me that people

often don't take us seriously. Personally, I don't face any issues because I know I am very strong.

And I can command an army if needed—that strength is something we must cultivate. However, for young women out there, I believe respect and acceptance should naturally exist in society. It all begins at home. As mothers, if we teach our sons that women deserve respect and an equal share in everything, we lay the foundation. It starts with us.

There are rights, yes, but I often feel deeply upset when I consider that women make up 52% of the population, yet there seems to be a lack of true advocacy for us. Many women endure mental and physical abuse at home, but who addresses these issues? Even at police stations, it's often men who are there to listen.

While this may be changing slightly now, I believe we need a better system in this country, one where women are genuinely respected. Rights exist, but the respect and mechanisms to uphold them need improvement.



14. Do you think women have to work harder than men to prove themselves, even when both are equally skilled?

I believe they do. Women often need to put in extra effort to gain the same recognition. For men, it tends to be easier, and much of it depends on how seriously people take women in positions of responsibility.

That said, it's not impossible, many women have reached great heights. However, one challenge we face in this country is the lack of solidarity among women. For example, in some workplaces, like government offices, it can be particularly challenging when a woman in a leadership position is not supportive. Women should strive to uplift and support one another to foster a more collaborative environment. It doesn't happen in this country. I don't know what the reason is.

15. Imagine a reliable employee who has worked for a considerable time at your company wishes to resign and start their own business. What would you say to that person? What support and advice will you give to them?

We have always supported entrepreneurship within SELYN, especially. And even in school, so many teachers have their own institutes. At SELYN, we will give them the seed money if they need it.

And then we will find the market for them. And we will always cooperate and work in partnership. But if they want to go on their own, it's something else. But if they want to start their own workshop, I think we will support them and we have a system of doing that.

16. You said SELYN has an aiding mechanism for entrepreneurship. What do you think about Sri Lanka? Does Sri Lanka have that aiding mechanism to support aspiring entrepreneurs? What needs to be corrected?

I believe we have a supportive system in place, but I'm not sure if we've truly thrived entirely on our own. For us, the Export Development Board has been a strong partner, especially in the beginning.

However, beyond that, there are other organizations that have contributed as well. But when it comes to real, practical support like acquiring land for a project, it can be challenging. There's so much government land and many unused buildings that remain closed, which could be utilized effectively.

Do they offer support? No, they don't. I believe the government should establish a mechanism for addressing such issues. For instance, there used to be a system in place named Exporters' Forum. This forum allowed exporters to come together, discuss their challenges, and work with the government to find solutions.

However, such a system doesn't exist now. There's no platform where our concerns are identified or addressed effectively. If we face a problem, we're often left navigating through multiple organizations, and the process lacks clarity and direction.

This is a challenge. I mean more clearly, we don't have a forum to play. So if we are given more opportunities, we can easily develop this business. It won't be a drudgery.

If things are made easier for the entrepreneurs, and if there are better partnerships and understanding



between the public sector and the private sector, I think this country will grow more. I firmly believe in that.

17. What do you have as advice to give to the next and upcoming generation of Sri Lanka?

The upcoming generation has a unique mindset and approach to life. For example, when reviewing their CVs, it's common to see frequent job changes within a year, reflecting their tendency not to stick to one thing.

In Japan, it's said that when someone joins a company, they aspire to grow within it, often to become the CEO. They give themselves enough time to progress and develop in the same organization. However, with the current generation, often referred to as Gen Z it's challenging to see this kind of long-term commitment.

What I'd like to advise is this. Be committed, stay focused, and truly understand what you want from life. Life is fleeting, and time doesn't stand still. If you're constantly jumping fields without truly mastering anything, you won't be able to build expertise and achieve meaningful progress.

My advice is to stay focused, give things time, and do your best. While technology evolves rapidly and the world moves fast, having a clear direction is key to succeeding as part of the next generation.



From Hackathons to High-Growth Startups:

Bridging Management and Technology for Entrepreneurial Innovation

In the fast-paced landscape of modern business, innovation is the key to staying competitive and impactful. Entrepreneurs, once characterized primarily as visionaries, now must excel in navigating the complex intersection of management and technology. Hackathons, artificial intelligence (AI), and Business System Engineering (BSE) are emerging as transformative forces, offering a unique synergy to drive entrepreneurial success. By fostering collaboration and applying advanced systems, entrepreneurs today can not only generate ideas but also bring them to life in ways that are scalable and sustainable. This article explores the journey from the creative spark of a hackathon to the structured growth of a high-impact startup, illustrating how management and technology combine to fuel entrepreneurial innovation.

Hackathons: A Crucible of Creativity and Collaboration

Hackathons have revolutionized the way we approach problem-solving and innovation. These short-term, high-intensity events bring together individuals from diverse backgrounds—programmers, designers, business strategists, and industry experts. Within a limited timeframe, teams collaborate to ideate, develop, and often prototype solutions to complex challenges. Hackathons are more than just competitions; they are incubators for creativity. For participants, they provide an opportunity to hone critical skills such as problem-solving, teamwork, and time management. For organizations, hackathons serve as platforms to crowdsource innovative solutions, accelerate product development cycles, and identify potential talent. The success of hackathons lies in their ability to simulate real-world constraints—limited time, resources, and unpredictable challenges—while

fostering a collaborative environment. They provide entrepreneurs with a safe space to experiment, iterate, and validate ideas with immediate feedback from peers and mentors. Moreover, hackathons highlight the critical balance between creativity and execution. While ideation sparks possibilities, implementation requires discipline, planning, and effective leadership. Entrepreneurs who thrive in hackathons often bring this mindset to their ventures, building a foundation for sustainable growth.

Artificial Intelligence: The Engine of Modern Startups

As businesses strive for efficiency and personalization, AI has become an indispensable tool. For startups, the integration of AI enables smarter decision-making, predictive analytics, and enhanced customer experiences. Take, for instance, the retail industry. AI-powered systems can analyze consumer behavior, forecast trends, and personalize marketing efforts, helping businesses optimize inventory and improve sales. Similarly, in healthcare, AI is revolutionizing patient diagnostics by analyzing medical data with unparalleled speed and accuracy. AI also serves as a force multiplier for startups, allowing small teams to accomplish what once required significantly more resources. By automating repetitive tasks, AI frees entrepreneurs to focus on strategic areas such as innovation, customer relationships, and business development. However, the adoption of AI is not without its challenges. Entrepreneurs must ensure that AI implementation aligns with their strategic goals, addresses ethical considerations, and adds measurable value to their operations. Effective management plays a crucial role here, ensuring that AI complements human expertise rather than replacing it. Startups leveraging AI can gain a competitive edge by reducing operational inefficiencies, enhancing



Bridging the Gap: The Synergy of Management and Technology

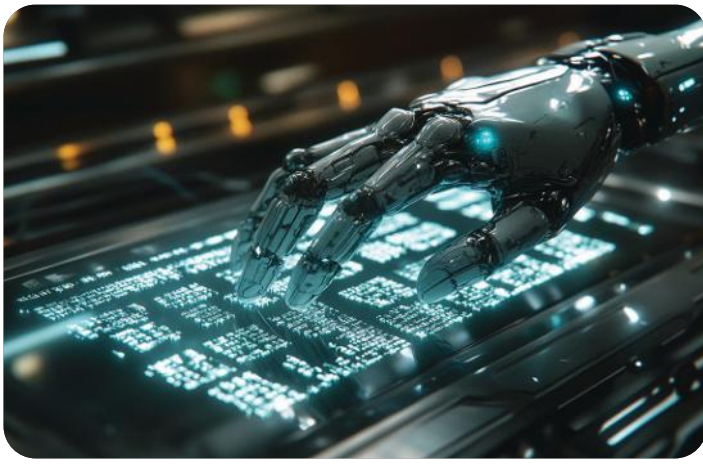
The intersection of management and technology is where innovation truly flourishes. Hackathons provide the spark, AI fuels the engine, and BSE lays the tracks for sustained growth. This synergy is essential for navigating today's dynamic markets, where adaptability and resilience are key to success. Entrepreneurs must recognize that innovation is not solely about technology; it is equally about people, processes, and purpose. Effective management ensures that technological adoption serves broader organizational goals, while technology amplifies the capabilities of the workforce. For example, a startup developing an AI-driven logistics platform may leverage hackathon concepts to prototype the solution, use AI to optimize delivery routes, and apply BSE to streamline operations. This integrated approach not only enhances efficiency but also creates a scalable and customer-centric business model. Additionally, the synergy between these domains fosters inclusivity. By combining diverse perspectives in hackathons, leveraging AI's capacity to personalize, and using BSE to create equitable processes, entrepreneurs can build solutions that resonate with a wider audience.

decision-making processes, and improving scalability. With the right balance of technical innovation and strategic oversight, AI becomes a powerful enabler of entrepreneurial success.

Business System Engineering: Structuring Innovation for Growth

While AI focuses on intelligence and efficiency, BSE ensures that startups have the structural foundation to scale effectively. BSE involves the systematic design, integration, and management of business processes to achieve organizational goals. Startups often face challenges as they grow—inefficient workflows, communication breakdowns, and difficulty in scaling operations. BSE provides a roadmap to address these issues by creating streamlined systems that enhance productivity, accountability, and adaptability. Consider a startup entering a period of rapid growth. Without robust systems in place, the organization risks inefficiencies that can hinder progress. By applying BSE principles, the startup can optimize its operations, align processes with business objectives, and maintain agility in a competitive market. BSE is not just a technical discipline; it is a bridge between management's vision and technology's capabilities. It enables entrepreneurs to translate innovative ideas into sustainable business models, ensuring long-term viability and success. BSE also plays a pivotal role in integrating technology with human processes. For example, a business can use workflow automation tools to reduce delays and enhance collaboration among team members, ensuring that technology acts as a facilitator of human potential rather than a replacement.





Inspiring the Next Generation of Innovators

The entrepreneurial journey is both challenging and rewarding. For those aspiring to make their mark, hackathons, AI, and BSE offer valuable tools and frameworks. These elements are not just resources but catalysts that transform raw ideas into impactful solutions. Hackathons teach us to think creatively under pressure and collaborate effectively across disciplines. AI empowers us to make data-driven decisions and automate mundane tasks, freeing up resources for strategic initiatives. BSE provides the structure and stability needed to scale innovations into sustainable businesses. Startups that embody these

principles become role models for the next generation, inspiring them to approach entrepreneurship as a holistic discipline that integrates creativity, strategy, and execution.

Conclusion: Building a Future of Possibilities

In a world driven by rapid technological advancements, the ability to bridge the gap between management and technology is a defining trait of successful entrepreneurs. Hackathons ignite creativity, AI powers intelligence, and BSE ensures sustainability—together, they form a powerful triad for entrepreneurial innovation. The journey from hackathons to high-growth startups exemplifies the potential of this synergy. It is a testament to the transformative power of collaboration, technology, and strategic planning. As we continue to innovate, let us aim not just for growth but for solutions that create lasting impact, bridging gaps and building a better future for all.



Pathum Lakruwan Level 3

Department of Industrial Management,
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Q: What is Connex Information Technologies, and what role does it play in Sri Lanka's technology landscape?

A: Incorporated in 2014 as a start-up value-added IT distributor, today Connex is a top-tier industry leader who facilitates performance excellence for our partners and their clients. Our comprehensive portfolio of products, next-generation technologies, and professional services are backed by our highly specialized expertise and training, enabling our partners to bring the best solutions to the market. As a partner-centric company, we focus on empowering our business partners to evolve, ensuring they have customized innovative tools and support that are both scalable and reliable, empowering them to succeed in an increasingly competitive global landscape.

Q: What are the key product categories and solutions offered by Connex?

A: Connex specializes in distributing over 70 technology products globally, ranging from a diverse technology solution, including:

- Cyber Security
- Data Center, Networking, and Infrastructure
- Identity, Governance, and Compliance
- Unified Communications and Collaboration
- Artificial Intelligence, Automation, and IoT
- Professional and Support Services
- Consultancy and Advisory Service

Q: How does Connex differentiate itself from other IT distributors?

A: As a value-added global technology distributor, we stand out in terms of our comprehensive solutions portfolio, global reach with local expertise, cutting-edge technologies, partner-centric approach, scalability and flexibility, expertise and specialized talent, strong vendor partnerships, security and compliance leadership, end-to-end managed services, and innovation-driven solutions.

Additionally, our newly launched innovative experience center allows our customers and partners an opportunity to experience our offering in a simulated and interactive demo hub. By fostering

engagement with our advanced technologies, we ensure our stakeholders are well informed to unlock the full potential of Connex's offerings.

Q: What are the key industries that Connex serves, and how do your solutions impact them?

A: We cater to a wide range of industries, including banking and finance, telecommunications, manufacturing, healthcare, and government sectors. Our solutions enhance operational efficiency, strengthen security frameworks, and support digital transformation initiatives, ensuring businesses stay competitive in an increasingly technology-driven landscape.

Q: Cybersecurity is a major concern today. How does Connex help businesses protect their digital assets?

A: Cybersecurity is at the core of our offerings. We provide comprehensive security solutions, including threat detection and response, endpoint protection, data encryption, and compliance management. Our team of experts continuously monitors emerging threats and deploys advanced security measures to safeguard our clients' critical assets.

Q: As a value-added technology distributor, what is Connex's contribution towards the university community in Sri Lanka?

A: As a responsible corporate citizen, Connex takes a great interest in facilitating the university community in Sri Lanka. We always welcome undergraduates and fresh graduates for internship opportunities at Connex and pave them a successful career path. The majority of our staff members are graduates from local universities.

We conduct product awareness and training sessions in technical colleges and vocational training institutes with the objective of creating employment opportunities for the students in the industry. We are working with over 1,200 partners who are forefront IT companies in Sri Lanka. The knowledge and certifications students gain through our training sessions facilitate students to sharpen their skills and confidently face interviews in those companies.

INTRA-DEPARTMENTAL ARTICLE COMPETITION

The intra-departmental article competition serves as a platform for our undergraduates to showcase their talent in creative writing and innovative thinking. Encouraging participation from all department undergraduates, this competition invites articles on topics related to information technology, management, and entrepreneurship. Winning entries are proudly featured in Exposition magazine, providing students with a valuable opportunity for recognition and exposure. Beyond fostering creativity and intellectual expression, this competition promotes knowledge-sharing and strengthens the sense of unity within the department



2nd Place

**Pramuditha
Vidushan**
Level 2



1st Place

**Mishara
Wickramasinghe**
Level 3



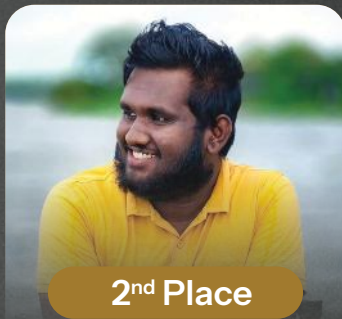
3rd Place

**Pathum
Lakruwan**
Level 3

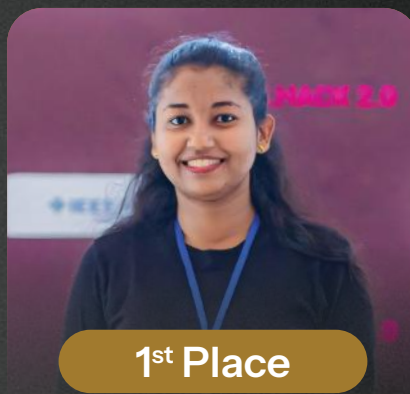
“This is more than a contest—it’s a stage for your ideas, a canvas for your voice, and a chance to shine!”

INTER-UNIVERSITY ARTICLE COMPETITION

Continuing its commitment to igniting intellectual curiosity and fostering creativity among university students, Exposition proudly embarks on the fourth iteration of the inter-university article competition. In collaboration with the esteemed intra-departmental article competition, this initiative continues to shine as a platform for vibrant engagement and innovative thought. The enthusiastic participation of students, sharing their creative insights in Exposition magazine, stands as a testament to the growing success of this inspiring endeavour.



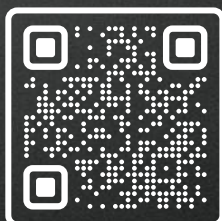
Gaviru Bihan
Sabaragamuwa
University



Imasha Samarasinghe
Sabaragamuwa
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Sudeepa Lakshan
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Mr. Dilupa Pathirana

Mr. Dilupa Pathirana stands out as an exceptional leader in the corporate world, having forged an inspiring path from trade marketing to the summit of executive leadership. His career spans roles in brand management, marketing, and operations, ultimately leading him to become the CEO of Sri Lanka's largest coffee chain, Barista. His strategic vision and commitment to operational excellence have played a pivotal role in shaping brands and driving business growth. He shares his journey of resilience, leadership, and continuous learning with Exposition Issue 20, offering invaluable insights for aspiring professionals.

1. Mr. Dilupa, can you take us back to the beginning of your career? What inspired you to step into the corporate world?

I've always dreamed of becoming a lecturer, inspired by the way professors work at the university. This interest was further nurtured by a reverend monk who lived next door to me at the temple. We had a close bond, and he was instrumental in guiding my education and career. He was also a lecturer at the University of Kelaniya, and he often encouraged me by saying, "You should aim to be a university lecturer or an academic." His advice motivated me, and I channeled my education toward that path.

However, in 2005, when my father passed away, I had to step up and support my family. That's when I began my journey in a private organization, marking my entry into the corporate world. From that point onward, there was no looking back. That's how the corporate world works – once you're in, you're in. And it has played a significant role in shaping my growth.

2. From the very beginning, you've worked in a variety of industries, including insurance, and beverages, and currently, you're leading Sri Lanka's leading coffee chain, Barista. How have these diverse experiences influenced your approach to leadership and shaped the way you guide your team?

It all boils down to experience, honestly. I started my career as a trade marketing assistant, and from there, I climbed the brand management ladder. I've

we weren't just selling coffee; we were selling a lifestyle.

starting from the bottom and working your way up is crucial. It allows you to gain experience in all aspects of the job.

held roles such as brand executive, assistant brand manager, brand manager, and category manager. Later, I moved on to become a marketing head, then an operations and marketing general manager, and eventually CEO. Along the way, I've worked with incredible bosses and companies, and every step has been a learning experience.

In the early years, my focus was on functional and execution management, often reporting to middle management. At that stage, the challenges were different. The role was well-defined, and I had to juggle pressure, deadlines, and meticulous attention to detail, which are all part of middle management.

However, as I advanced, my work shifted toward strategic management and leadership. The focus moved to thinking across different disciplines, managing inter-functional relationships, honing negotiation skills, making critical decisions, and developing emotional intelligence. At each stage, I gained new experiences and insights. That's why I believe starting from the bottom and working your way up is crucial. It allows you to gain experience in all aspects of the job.



I'm not saying all my bosses were perfect; I've had my share of bad ones too. But even from those experiences, I learned a lot. Learning is an internal process. Every day presents new challenges at work, in your career, and in life. What matters is how you internalize and process those events.

Ultimately, it's all part of the learning journey. Whether the experiences are good or bad, it's how you learn from them that shapes your career. Even now, I continue to learn every day. Not just from those above me but from those who work alongside me as well.

3. Coffee shop culture was not very common in Sri Lanka, and many people weren't familiar with it. Under your leadership, however, you've managed to popularize it. How did you achieve this and make people embrace the coffee shop culture?

There are so many people in my organization, involved in this process, so I must thank them. They've put their hearts, efforts, and hands into it.

If I were to take one credit, it would be in making sure that everyone in our organization was very clear about our brand and business vision. We knew exactly where we wanted to be and what we wanted to do. The goal was to make coffee more accessible, not just for Colombo 7, but for every city in Sri Lanka and every person in the country.

However, we identified two major challenges on this journey. The first was affordability. Coffee was expensive, and I still believe it's expensive, so it had to become more affordable. The second challenge was accessibility. Coffee was mostly available in Colombo and its suburbs. To tackle these challenges, in 2019, we introduced a more affordable option with the Piccolo, priced at 200 rupees, in collaboration with delivery partners like Uber and PickMe. At that time, we had about seven to eight outlets, and there were days when we sold more coffee through Uber than all our outlets combined. This indicated that consumers are price-sensitive.

We also designed a model called the "express outlet," which operates in smaller spaces within existing stores. This lowers overhead costs like electricity and rent, allowing us to pass on the benefits to the consumer. Today, we have about nine express outlets, which contribute to 15% of our coffee sales. This reduced price point helped us attract more coffee lovers, particularly those who might not have risked spending a higher amount to try something new.

In terms of accessibility, we expanded beyond Colombo to areas like Talawathugoda, Kiribathgoda, Malabe, Seeduwa, Ja-Ela, and even up to Kandy, Kurunegala, and Galle. This expansion helped people realize that coffee is not an expensive beverage. Moreover, we weren't just selling coffee; we were selling a lifestyle. It's about everything that surrounds coffee, the ambiance, the experience.

We created an environment where people could work comfortably, offering Wi-Fi, power outlets, and a welcoming atmosphere. This concept was well-received, especially by the younger generation. When people had better access to coffee and a conducive environment, they were more likely to try it. With our customer service, food offerings, and dedication to keeping our customers happy, the coffee culture grew significantly.

4. Barista was established in Sri Lanka around 2002. Since then, it has evolved a lot from the day you joined to where it stands today. What have been the most impactful changes the brand has undergone under your leadership?

We have always had a clear understanding of our role in the business. While it was tempting to explore other areas, our leadership and management team remained focused on the coffee and café industry.

I recently came across a book that stated, "Sacrifice

is the essence of strategy.” That perfectly sums up our approach. We were fully committed to brand building, recognizing that the Barista brand is our most valuable strategic asset. From our core beliefs to our values, and functional and emotional benefits, we took branding seriously and ensured that everyone in the organization understood its significance.

Consumer insights have always been at the heart of our strategy. We invested heavily in research and built a strong feedback system, ranging from traditional customer comment cards to digital platforms like Facebook, Instagram, and TripAdvisor. Even today, if a customer is dissatisfied, they can reach out to me directly; My phone number is displayed at all our outlets.

Our approach has always been long-term, not just about short-term gains but about shaping a vision for the next five years. What you see at Barista today was planned back in 2018 when I joined. Staying true to coffee has always been our guiding principle, and that unwavering focus is what sets Barista apart.

5. As Barista has grown from a few outlets to 52 across the country, how have you managed to balance operational efficiency with maintaining a strong brand presence?

While it may seem like there’s a trade-off between the two, I believe operational excellence and brand equity are deeply interconnected and equally important. You simply can’t separate them. If you ask me personally, I’d even argue that operational excellence is the more crucial of the two.

Take marketing, for example. We communicate to our customers that we offer the best coffee, the best service, and the best food. This creates awareness, builds a positive perception of the brand, and attracts customers to our outlets. But once they arrive, the real test begins—the moment of truth. At that moment, operational excellence is what truly matters. The coffee must be brewed to perfection, employees should be well-presented, and the food must be served correctly and on time.

You can advertise a product, like our coconut milk, and have influencers promote it. But when a customer visits any of our outlets, from Colombo to Nuwara Eliya, they should always find it available. That consistency is what builds trust. Operational excellence is the foundation of brand equity, which is why we give both operational excellence and brand equity equal attention and effort at Barista.

6. You’ve been a strong advocate for both sustainability and customer satisfaction at Barista. One of the quotes that stood out to us was, “A stain on the cup is better than a stain on the environment.” It’s a powerful statement. How do you translate this philosophy into action and make it a reality at Barista?



Customer satisfaction and sustainability are things that businesses should inherently embody, not just promote. They should be at the core of the business, part of its DNA, its philosophy. Customer satisfaction, especially in today’s world, is not something that should even be advertised. It’s the same with sustainability and CSR campaigns; they should be intrinsic to a business’s operations.

At Barista, we take so much from the community including employees, customers, and various resources. Therefore, giving back shouldn’t be an extraordinary act. It should be a natural part of how we do business. A company that focuses solely on profit is not a truly successful organization. After all, there’s little value in running a thriving business within a struggling community.

We’ve made several sustainability efforts over the

years, even when it wasn't easy. For instance, in 2009, despite facing financial struggles, we chose to switch from plastic to glass bottles, even though it was more expensive. At the time, we were using 2,500 plastic bottles per day, but after making the switch, we began saving around 100 kilograms of plastic every month. This decision wasn't driven by profit; it was simply the right thing to do.

Similarly, during the challenging COVID-19 period, when many businesses were struggling, we launched the Share a Meal campaign. Despite financial constraints, we raised funds to support children in need. By 2020, we had collected 500,000, and more recently, we donated 3.6 million to SOS Children's Village. Sustainability and CSR efforts aren't about waiting until you're profitable; they're about making the right choice from the start.

In my opinion, CSR and sustainability should simply be a natural part of any business, without the need for promotion.

7. Let's talk about the food and beverage industry. What do you think are the key advantages and challenges of working, leading, and managing this industry?

I've spent the last 14 years in the food and beverage industry, and my passion for it runs deep. Over the years, I've experienced both its highs and lows. One of the biggest positives is the sheer scale of the industry. After all, everyone needs to eat. With a global population of 8.5 billion, there's always demand. If you have the right offering, people will pause whatever they're doing just to try it.

Another advantage is that when you want to introduce a new idea, it's relatively easy to implement. There are not many legal restrictions, and the capital requirements for starting up aren't as high as in some other industries. This means it's less of an entry barrier for newcomers. The food and beverage industry is



dynamic, everyone is constantly looking for something new. If you're a marketer or operations person, there's plenty of work because things move quickly and constantly evolve.

However, this dynamism can also be a disadvantage. Because the industry is open to anyone, ideas can be easily copied without your knowledge. Additionally, you can't fix certain things, like food costs or employee numbers, for an extended period. It's difficult to maintain consistent delivery patterns, and training isn't something you can stabilize for months at a time. The industry is also very sensitive to macro factors like political, environmental, legal, and economic issues that can have a big impact.

So, there are pros and cons, and they often depend on your perspective. At Barista, we had a turning point with a concept that initially seemed like it would fail, but with the right moves, it took off like a dream. The food and beverage industry can be challenging, but it's also exciting and full of potential. It's fast-paced, and to stay relevant, you constantly have to keep moving.

8. In many industries, customers sometimes aren't entirely clear about the outcome they desire. In such situations, how do you guide your employees to ensure they consistently align with the right outcome and meet customer expectations?

Marketing is fundamentally about understanding and anticipating customer needs. Often, customers don't know what they need until it's introduced to them. For example, in 2002, if someone had proposed a phone with a camera, most people would have simply wanted a phone that allowed faster texting. It's the marketer's job to think ahead and guide consumers toward better solutions.

Educating customers plays a key role not just in products but in entire categories. When we introduced café culture in Sri Lanka, people knew coffee but weren't familiar with specialty cafés. The most effective way to bridge that gap is through well-trained employees who can guide and inform customers, creating a deeper appreciation for the experience.

At Barista, training is taken seriously. Employees undergo theoretical and practical training, exams, and assessments, with a structured career progression system. They even have access to mobile learning tools. Well-informed employees create well-informed customers, just as happy employees create happy customers.

We also make sure our employees fully understand our brand vision—what we sell, how we sell it, and why it matters. This enables them to communicate effectively with customers. By aligning everyone with our mission, we create a seamless experience that enhances both employee engagement and customer satisfaction.

9. With customer preferences constantly evolving and AI-driven technology shaping the market, staying ahead of trends is more challenging than ever. How do you ensure your brand not only adapts to these changes but also maintains its position as a market leader?

I see a difference between following trends and staying relevant. Trends come and go, but that doesn't mean we should blindly follow them. Instead, we need to be selective and align only with those that truly impact our business.

At Barista, rather than chasing every trend, we analyse their potential effects on consumer behavior. Some trends we disregard, while others we anticipate and adapt to, ensuring our offerings bring the best value. It's about consistency, not just trend-hopping.

Many brands lose authenticity by forcing themselves into every trend, even when it doesn't align with their identity. This can sometimes confuse customers. That's why we are cautious. AI, like other trends, is emerging rapidly, and so is the specialty coffee movement. We stay watchful, evaluating whether these shifts truly impact our domain. If they do, we prepare accordingly.

In short, brands don't need to respond to every trend. They need to analyse and act only when it truly matters.

10. As we near the end of our conversation, what key lessons or insights would you like to share with someone aspiring to enter this industry and follow a similar career path?

When considering a career in food and beverage or branding, knowledge is key. As a marketer, I wasn't a coffee enthusiast when I joined Barista, but I learned and grew to love it. Understanding your industry is essential whether it's branding, food and beverage, or any other field.

I often meet university students who ask if they should complete their studies or jump straight into business. My advice is to build a strong foundation first. Theories exist for a reason. They have been researched and



proven. Entering the market without this knowledge means relying on trial and error, which is risky in today's highly competitive landscape.

Success comes from three key elements: knowledge, imagination, and hard work. A deep understanding of your field provides a solid foundation. Knowledge alone maintains the status quo, but when combined with imagination, it leads to innovation. Hard work is equally important no matter how talented or knowledgeable you are, success requires effort and persistence.

If you master these three, you have a winning formula for success. Whether in branding, marketing, or any other industry, this combination will set you apart.



INTER SCHOOL HACKATHON 7.0



hackX Jr. 7.0 is the 7th consecutive iteration of the inter-school hackathon organized by the Industrial Management Science Students Association driven by the theme "Give Shapes to Ideas." This competition provided a platform for young, ambitious school students to harness their creativity and transform ideas into reality. hackX Jr. 7.0 is a competition that has also been recognized by the Ministry of Education.



The journey began with an awareness session on August 23rd, 2024. Held at the Auditorium of the Department of Industrial Management, Faculty of Science, University of Kelaniya, and streamed virtually through Zoom and hackX Jr. Facebook Page, the session featured insightful talks by industry experts. Mr. Kasun Pathmaperuma, CEO of Ceylon Export Hub and COO of LiquidApps Pvt. Ltd set the tone with a speech on "Growing Entrepreneurship through Hackathons". Dr. Ruchira Wijesena, a senior lecturer at the University of Moratuwa and a former Senior Research Scientist with extensive experience in technological innovation, shared his insights on "Future of Innovation with the Evolution of Technology". Following that, Ms. Pulani Ranasinghe, Founder, and CEO of Loons Lab, also an alumni of the department, navigated the audience through "The Secrets Behind a Successful Proposal".

From over 150 proposal submissions, 25 proposals were shortlisted to compete in the Semi-Finals. To

support these semi-finalists, two online sessions were held. Mr. Miuli Kalubowila, the Founder/CEO of Generation ALPHA did an inspirational session on "Master the Art of Visual Storytelling" on the 3rd of October 2024 via Zoom. It was an insightful session that gave a comprehensive understanding of Visual Storytelling. Also, the level-up session conducted by Mr. Heminda Jayaweera, Executive Director of TRACE, was held on the 10th of October 2024, via Zoom. It was an informative session that gave a complete understanding of mastering the art of pitching ideas effectively.

InnoX, the Semi-Finals of hack Jr. 7.0, was held on the 12th of October 2024 virtually. The teams got the opportunity to pitch their groundbreaking ideas to a notable panel of judges, consisting of Mr. Dimuthu Ponnampereuma, Founder and CEO of Akarsha Global Pvt. Ltd, Mr. Sampath Widushan, User Experience Designer at Dialog Axiata PLC, Ms. Manori Iroshini, Deputy Director of Education, Information and Communication Technology Branch, Ministry of Education, Dr. Thilini Mahanama, lecturer of the Department of Industrial Management and also Ms. Chalani Oruthotaarachchi, senior lecturer of the Department of Industrial Management. Twelve teams were chosen to advance to the Grand Finals based on the novelty of their ideas, as well as considerations of feasibility and potential impact.





Finalists participated in a workshop series led by industry experts. Mr. Jehan Wijesinghe, Founder of UnicornFactory, covered the topic of "From Ideas to Reality", Mr. Ruchintha Udeeshwara, Director of The Impression, covered the topic of "Marketing Tactics to Stand Out" while Mr. Sheshan Gamage, focused on "Building Your First Mobile App".

The Grand Finals of hackX Jr. 7.0 was held on the 30th of October 2024, from 9:00 am onwards at Dialog Axiata Auditorium, Ideamart. The honorable panel of judges was composed of Ms. Dinuri Vitharana, Ideamart, Dialog Axiata PLC, Mrs. Vasana Edirisuriya, Director of ICT at the Ministry of Education, Mr. Mohammed Jaseem, Senior Executive of SLASSCOM, Ms. Pulani Ranasinghe, Founder and CEO of Loons Lab, Dr. Chathura Rajapakse, Senior lecturer at the Department of Industrial Management, University of Kelaniya.

Following opening remarks by encouraging words from Professor Janaka Wijayanayake, Head of the Department of Industrial Management, the finalists took the stage. Competitors presented the working prototypes of their idea in front of the distinguished panel of judges, along with the business model and future implementations. Team BCCS Revolution from

Bandaranayaka College, Gampaha, emerged as the champion after facing stiff competition. The honorable panel of judges, corporate sponsor representatives, parents, teachers, and undergraduates added colors to the event.

hackX Jr. 7.0 competition's success relied on extensive support from partners, ictfromabc as the Official Educational Partner, Ideamart as the Official Eco-System Partner, SLASSCOM as the Official Strategic Partner, Loons Lab and Generation ALPHA as the Official Knowledge Partners along with other collaborative partners, added significant value to the event.

The core organizing team for hackX Jr. 7.0 was led by chief coordinators Navindu Rasanjana and Hansini Ratnayake, with invaluable support from team members Dulan Samarasingha, Dinuvi Nethumila,



Tharindu Lakmal, Sanjitha Manchanayaka, and Danuka Dimal. The contributions of lecturers, academic and non-academic staff, and undergraduates from the Department of Industrial Management were instrumental to the event's success.

hackX Jr. 7.0 exemplified a collaborative effort that empowered young minds and cultivated the next generation of innovators and entrepreneurs.



INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE ON SMART COMPUTING AND SYSTEMS ENGINEERING 2024

The Seventh International Research Conference on Smart Computing and Systems Engineering (SCSE 2024), hosted by the Department of Industrial Management of the University of Kelaniya, once again solidified its position as a significant platform for technological innovation and groundbreaking research. SCSE 2024 brought together innovative minds from both corporate and academic backgrounds, including renowned academics, research scholars, and industry experts, providing a unique opportunity to explore the latest advancements, emerging trends, and practical challenges related to Smart Computing and Systems Engineering in various real-world applications, interdisciplinary domains, and future technological developments.

The conference's inaugural ceremony of SCSE 2024 held on April 4, 2024 was a momentous occasion, graced by the presence of

- Prof. Nilanthi De Silva, Vice Chancellor, University of Kelaniya
- Prof. Sudath Kalingamudali, Dean of the Faculty of Science

- Prof. Sachith Meththananda, Research Council
- Prof. Janaka Wijayanayake, head of the Department of Industrial Management

Dr. Chathura Rajapakse, the Conference Chair, commenced the event by extending a warm welcome to all participants and then the program proceeded with a series of perceptive speeches by esteemed academicians, including Prof. Sudath Kalingamudali, Prof. Sachith Meththananda, and Prof. Nilanthi De Silva. The inaugural ceremony was further elevated by the impressive keynote speeches of iconic figures, Prof. Antonio Mitrovic and Prof. Roshan Ragel.

Prof. Antonija Mitrovic from the University of Canterbury, New Zealand, delivered a captivating virtual presentation on **"The Effectiveness of AI-Based Support for Engagement during Video-Based Learning"**.

The second keynote speaker Prof. Roshan Ragel from the University of Peradeniya, Sri Lanka, presented a thought-provoking keynote on **"AI and IoT: Emerging Trends and Future Directions in the Industry 5.0 Era"**.

KEYNOTE SPEAKERS



PROF. ANTONIJA MITROVIC
UNIVERSITY OF CANTERBURY, NTEW ZEALAND



PROF. ROSHAN RAGEL
UNIVERSITY OF PERADENIYA, SRI LANKA

SCSE 2024 received an overwhelming response from researchers across the globe, with 248 full research paper submissions. Because of the high number of submissions, a competitive selection process had to be implemented which led to the acceptance of the top 31% of total research papers. All accepted papers were indexed in Scopus and submitted to the IEEE Xplore Digital Library, ensuring global visibility and long-lasting impact.

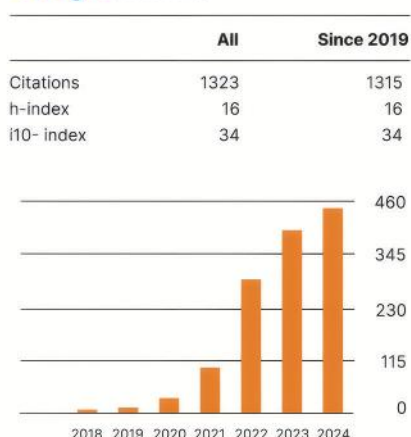
Then the conference was unfolded featuring twelve engaging sessions across seven key tracks to present the research papers:

1. Software Engineering
2. Artificial Intelligence
3. Supply Chain and Logistics Systems
4. Industrial Engineering and Management
5. Smart Systems Engineering
6. IT and Education
7. Systematic Reviews

The research efforts explored a wide range of interesting topics, including data science and analytics, business intelligence, machine learning, process automation, language models and natural language processing, image and video analytics, Internet of Things, cloud computing, multi-agent systems, agent-based modelling and simulation, blockchains, industrial and systems engineering, business process engineering and optimization, digital transformation, digital innovation, financial and marketing technology and many more.

SCSE's impact on the academic community is evident in its Google Scholar citations. By 2024, it had garnered 1,003 citations, with 997 since 2019. The h-index of 15 and i10-index of 26 attest to the quality and influence of its research.

SCSE Citation Statistics
Google Scholar



The steady rise in citations, particularly between 2021 and 2023 (averaging over 340 annually), highlights SCSE's pivotal role in advancing smart technologies.

SCSE 2024 was not only focused on technological advancements but also on addressing global challenges. The conference aligned its research agenda with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), emphasizing the role of technology in creating a sustainable future.



In conjunction with SCSE 2024, The Department of Industrial Management of the University of Kelaniya organized a series of academic events from April 1st to 3rd, 2024. These events included three insightful pre-conference workshops and an engaging academic forum.

The academic forum, titled "Shaping the Future of Academia with GenAI: Insights and Considerations," brought together esteemed academics from the University of Kelaniya. The forum delved into the transformative potential of AI in innovative and design education, sparking thought-provoking discussions and inspiring future collaborations.

To further enhance the knowledge and skills of educators, Dr. Chathura Rajapakse conducted a specialized workshop on "Teaching Artificial Intelligence" for school teachers.

In addition, Mr. Dinesh Asanka led a workshop on “Natural Language Processing with Transformers,” providing attendees with a comprehensive understanding of this cutting-edge technology. Meanwhile Dr. Amila Withanaarachchi and Dr. Thilini Mahanama conducted a workshop on “PLS-SEM Analysis using SmartPLS and SeminR” offering participants valuable insights into advanced analytical techniques.

The success of SCSE 2024, was greatly enhanced by the generous support of IEEE, IEEE Sri Lanka Section, and the IEEE Computer Society. These contributions, complemented by the platinum sponsorship of Huawei Technologies Lanka Company Pvt Ltd, were instrumental in elevating the conference’s overall standards of excellence.

The 7th International Research Conference on Smart Computing and Systems Engineering (SCSE 2024) served as a platform to share knowledge and explore the latest breakthroughs in smart computing and systems engineering. By aligning with the UN’s Sustainable Development Goals, SCSE 2024 not only advanced the field but also laid the groundwork for future research that will drive a more sustainable and technologically advanced world.



Dr. Chathura Rajapakskse
Conference Chair
University of Kelaniya, Sri Lanka



Dr. Thilini Mahanama
Conference Secretary
University of Kelaniya, Sri Lanka



Ms. Piyumika Peiris
Assistant Secretary
University of Kelaniya, Sri Lanka



Ms. Jinendri Prasadika
Assistant Secretary
University of Kelaniya, Sri Lanka



Dr. Shantha Jayalal
Track Chair – Software engineering
University of Peradeniya, Sri Lanka



Dr. Jehan Seneviratne
Track Chair – Artificial intelligence
University of Kelaniya, Sri Lanka



Prof. Annista Wijayanayake
Track Chair – Supply chain
and logistics systems
University of Kelaniya, Sri Lanka



Prof. Suren Peter
Track Chair – Industrial engineering
and management
University of Peradeniya, Sri Lanka



Prof. Janaka Wijayanayake
Track Chair – Smart Systems (IoT, VR, AR)
University of Kelaniya, Sri Lanka



Dr. Anusha Jayasiri
Track Chair – IT and Education
University of Visual and
Performing Arts, Sri Lanka



Dr. Shan Jayasinghe
Track Chair – Systematic Reviews
University of Kelaniya, Sri Lanka



Mr. Dinesh Asanka
Technical Programme Chair
University of Kelaniya, Sri Lanka



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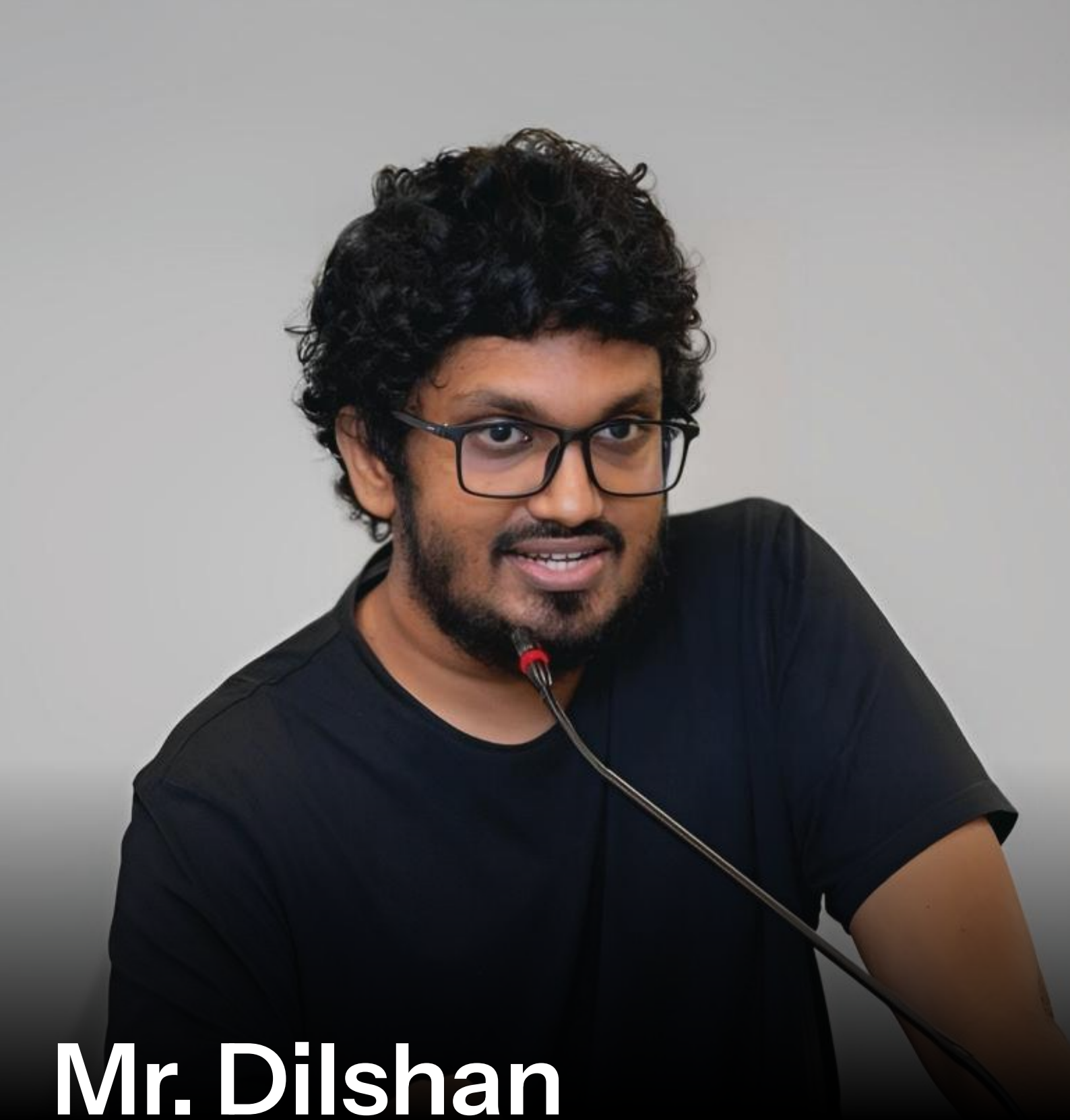


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Mr. Dilshan Abeygunawardana

From building innovative tech solutions to inspiring the next generation of entrepreneurs, Mr. Dilshan Abeygunawardana is a force to be reckoned with. With a passion for pushing boundaries, he's ventured into various projects, from NFTs to creating powerful content that promotes a "winning mindset". Join us as we explore his journey through the highs and lows of entrepreneurship, where every step is driven by curiosity, growth, and the relentless pursuit of success.

1. You started multiple ventures at a young age. Let's start our story there. How did your journey begin?

The very first thing I started was developing small software solutions for businesses in my region. Later, I ventured into something completely non-technical, which is creating necklaces using sea shells. Around the age of 19, I got involved in the gem business with my friends. Over the years, I've also run computer shops, developed games, and worked on numerous other projects—so many that I can't even recall them all, as I usually take on three to four different ventures each year.

From the very beginning, I had strong support from my family, although there were occasional challenges. Despite this, I was fortunate to have a solid support system overall.

The reason I take on multiple projects is simple. If one doesn't yield the results I aim for, I don't stick to it; I move on to something new. Sticking to just one thing for too long tends to make me feel stagnant and demotivated.

Finally, I've partnered with a business associate, and we're now making things official by establishing an AI company.

2. What has been the most valuable lesson you've learned from all these entrepreneurial experiences?

It can be really frustrating to keep going when things get tough, but I've learned to push through and keep

Success isn't about having a large team but about having the right team.

For me, creating value for even just one follower is impactful.

striving for what I'm truly passionate about. Things might take time, but as long as I see progress, I know it's always worth giving that extra push when things are heading in the right direction. That said, sometimes, no matter how hard you try, things just don't work out, and in those moments, the best move is to step back and pivot strategically. But when you see real growth, you've got to push past the resistance because after the hardest climb comes the best view!

3. Many young entrepreneurs struggle with taking the first step. What advice will you give to someone, who's struggling to take the first step?

Well, it really depends on the situation. If you're financially stable from the start, it's much easier to take that first step. In my case, having a safety net made things comparatively smoother. But if you don't have financial support, the first thing you need to do is secure some funds to back your business. Starting from zero can be quite risky. You might have to work on your startup during the day and take on a part-time job at night to keep things going. That's just how the world works—it's not always fair.

That said, no matter how hard it is, you should always find a way to minimize risk and start somewhere, because that's when things begin to make sense.

While working on your ventures, always make time to explore new technologies and trends, as they constantly open up new possibilities. With so many innovations emerging, there are more tools and resources than ever to support you. So don't let fear hold you back!

4. After taking the first step, the next important thing is building a strong social media brand, as it helps you stand out and be recognized as exceptional. From your experience, what are the key factors someone should consider when establishing a strong online presence?

I'm definitely a big believer in having strong PR. If you're familiar with my vlog channel, you'll know that one of the main reasons I started it was to build a strong personal brand. I believe sharing your updates is a great way to connect with people and helps you come across as more authentic.

If you've noticed, in some foreign countries, startup owners generate substantial income simply by sharing what's going on behind the scenes. Similarly, I try to share daily updates about my work on my TikTok account, and it helps build trust with my audience. The content doesn't have to be top-tier quality, but as long as it feels authentic, people can see how you approach problems, your thought process, and that's what helps attract a community that truly appreciates you.

Plus, social media, especially TikTok, is an amazing way to quickly gain insights into your areas of interest. Traditionally, gathering information meant reading numerous papers, watching the news, and more. But by following the right content, TikTok becomes a hub where you can easily access trending information and insights. And if you want to dive deeper, you can build your knowledge on the foundation you've established through that content.

5. At what point did you realize that your content was making an impact beyond just views and likes?

For me, creating value for even just one follower is impactful. Personally, I've felt deeply appreciated for my work with NFTs. We also released tutorial videos alongside our projects, aiming to encourage more people to explore the platform and see its potential. We received feedback from followers who found the videos incredibly helpful, with some even sharing how much they've earned and how it transformed their lives. That really made me realize the kind of impact we've had on people. But at the end of the day, I simply enjoy whatever I do as long as it brings value to my audience.

6. One thing we've noticed about you is that instead of setting limits, you keep exploring new ventures. You even took it a step further by launching a podcast series, which was recognized among the top 10%



on Spotify. Though it was eventually discontinued, your main focus during that time was on shaping a "winning mindset." Let's dive into your podcast journey.

As you mentioned, my goal was to create a platform where aspiring entrepreneurs and freelancers could learn the basics. I understand that entrepreneurship isn't for everyone, but I'm glad it has helped those who truly want to pursue that path.

The main reason I discontinued the podcast was simply a lack of time. Most projects follow a growth cycle. There's an initial rise, a peak, and eventually, a decline. I chose to stop my podcast at its peak, and I even mentioned on my educational YouTube channel that I would do so. I wanted my audience to always remember it as a highly successful project, even after I put a full stop to it. Given my tight schedule, it made sense to step away.

That being said, I still believe the podcast remains valuable for anyone looking to break into the tech industry.

7. Fiverr is a highly competitive platform, much like social media. Mr. Dilshan, you've gained significant recognition in the NFT space on Fiverr. For someone just starting out, what do you believe helped you stand out and gain such success on this platform?

It all happened quite randomly. I'm not a genius. I simply identified the trend early on, and it felt like a chance. Fiverr promotes its users randomly, so I realized that

giving my best to clients would lead to better ratings. I even made an effort to go above and beyond for clients, like praising them and offering extra features for free. As a result, 99.9% of over 300 clients gave me 5-star ratings. Being in a high position on Fiverr was a stroke of luck, but I managed to maintain that spot through the quality service I consistently provided.

8. As someone with extensive freelancing experience and a deep understanding of the process, do you predict any emerging trends in the freelancing world?

In my opinion, AI, particularly robotics, is the next big thing in freelancing technology. While there will undoubtedly be practical challenges in Sri Lanka's AI industry, I believe fields like development, testing automation, and prompt engineering will need to navigate and adapt through AI. This will have a significant impact on freelancing technologies and create more opportunities for those who can adapt to the change.

9. When discussing AI, we can't overlook your contribution to AI, with your project "Olee AI". Could you share some insights about that with us?

My business partner and I founded "Olee AI" to stay ahead of emerging trends. We believe that in the tech industry, it's an "adapt or die" situation. One thing we noticed was that after spending months developing something, large billion-dollar companies would often release similar features as small updates. This motivated us to build an AI transformation company.

For example, there was a time when the shift from writing on paper to using computers transformed the way businesses operated. We aimed to create a company that would have a similar impact, introducing AI tools to businesses and helping them improve efficiency while assisting them in making strategic decisions. We focused on building products that would remain effective, even as new AI technologies emerge, ensuring we created a sustainable business.

In addition to this, we have other products, such as our conversational AI chatbot, which can converse in Sinhala, English, and Tamil. For instance, if you upload a photo of a keyboard, it will guide you to stores that sell it, even asking about other stops along the way. Our virtual machine, Senya, can generate content based on prompts. For example, if you request a video of a chimpanzee jumping from Sigiriya with a flower in hand, it will create that. Overall, our aim is to

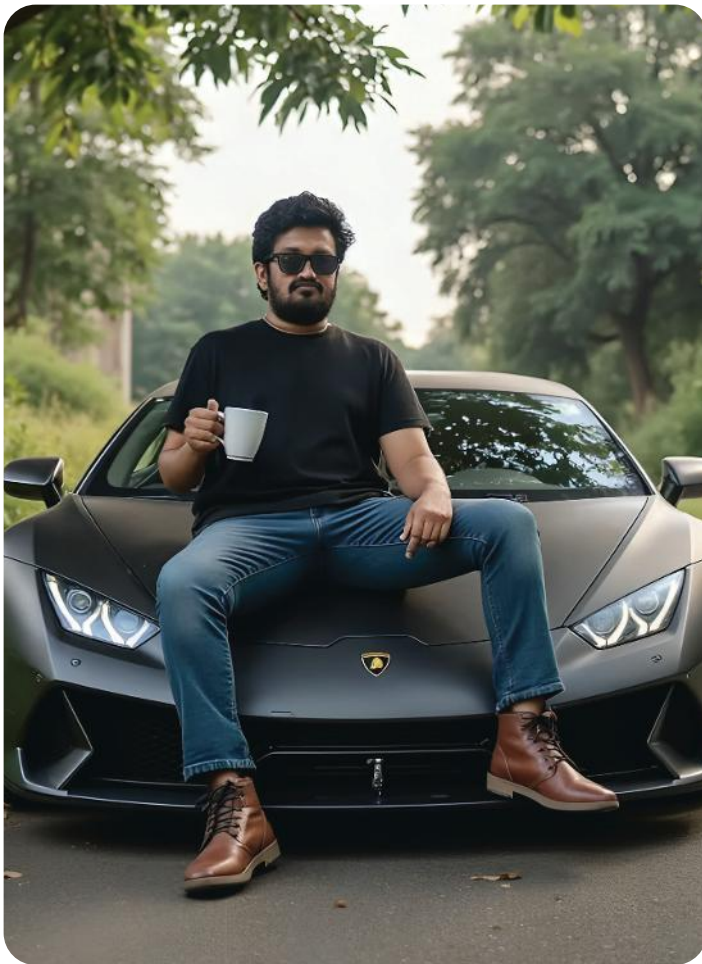
be a leader in AI transformation, helping businesses navigate and thrive in the evolving tech landscape.

10. When it comes to adopting AI technology or starting as an entrepreneur in the tech space, what common mistakes do you think newcomers typically make?

These aren't necessarily mistakes, but rather missed opportunities. One of the biggest is failing to work with emerging technologies like AI. Many newcomers tend to develop solutions using only the technologies they already know, rather than adopting the latest, most effective tools for the job.



Another crucial factor is assembling the right team. Take Elon Musk's restructuring of Twitter, for example, he reduced the workforce by 80%, yet the company continued to operate efficiently. Similarly, Telegram, a company generating billions in revenue, operates with just 30+ employees. This proves that success isn't about having a large team but about having the right team. However, many new entrepreneurs make the mistake of building teams based on friendships rather than selecting the most skilled and capable individuals.



11. You've achieved remarkable success at such a young age, overcoming numerous challenges along the way. Looking back, how would you describe your journey, the obstacles you faced, and the victories that shaped you?

I believe in the concept of a deterministic inner self, which means that life unfolds as it's meant to, and we don't have complete control over what happens. In other words, I see events, both good and bad, as things that were always meant to be. When challenges arise, I don't dwell on why they happened or what could have been different. Instead, I accept them as part of the journey and focus on moving forward. This mindset has helped me stay resilient and adapt to whatever comes my way.

12. Reflecting on your journey, what are the most valuable lessons you've gained from your experiences, and how have they influenced your growth and success?

I believe failures have played a bigger role than experiences in shaping my journey. I've tried many things, and while I managed to succeed, each failure taught me valuable lessons. Mainly, not to repeat the same mistakes. One of the biggest lessons I learned was the importance of choosing the right team.

Another key takeaway is that taking risks and starting immediately often leads to better outcomes than overanalyzing and planning for too long. For anyone starting a new business, my advice is to avoid investing a large amount of money upfront. Begin small, test the idea, and if it shows promise, then scale and invest further.

13. You have a growing community of followers, people who admire your journey and aspire to follow in your footsteps. What advice would you give to those looking up to you?

My advice is to love what you do and have a genuine passion for it. Success isn't as easy as it may seem, it requires hard work, and unless luck is on your side, you have to push through challenges. I worked so hard that I barely had time for myself. Some might think freelancing is just typing a few things or replying to messages and making easy money, but in reality, it comes with immense pressure. At one point, I even considered quitting. The only reason I kept going was because I truly loved what I did.

So my advice is this. Pursue what you're passionate about, stay updated on new technologies and emerging trends, and most importantly, choose the right team.



Photo credits: *Shehan Premarathne*



Learning, Growth and Lifelong Memories

Our Unforgettable Experience at KDU Southern Campus

Being first-year undergraduates at MIT, we were excited about this memorable journey to KDU Southern Campus in Hambantota. This was not just a fun tour but also an opportunity for personal growth, teamwork, and skill-building while enjoying the beauty of the southern region.

Learning with a Twist

We began our training with sessions on essential life skills, such as table manners and etiquette for formal occasions. These interactive sessions made us realize how small actions and words leave a lasting impact. These lessons will undoubtedly benefit us in both professional and personal life. However, our journey wasn't limited to formal learning. It was also highly interactive and aimed at character building. We participated in group activities that tested our teamwork, decision-making, and problem-solving abilities. These games highlighted the significance of collaboration and mutual support in achieving success.

Into the Wild

One of the highlights of the tour was the wilderness survival training. It pushed us out of our comfort zones while equipping us with valuable survival skills. We prepared lunch with limited resources, experimented with outdoor cooking, and learned to endure harsh weather. It was both fun and empowering, making

us feel resilient and self-sufficient. We also gained knowledge on navigating the wilderness, constructing shelters, and identifying safe drinking water sources. Each day presented challenges that tested our ability to think critically and collaborate. Ultimately, it was not just about survival but about learning to thrive in unexpected situations, forging strong bonds, and appreciating nature's raw beauty.

A Journey to Remember

Even the evenings were entertaining, filled with music, performances, and interactive activities that strengthened our bond. These moments taught us the importance of balancing hard work with enjoyment. What truly made the trip special was working with the officers who trained us with discipline, encouragement, and positivity. Beyond teaching essential skills, they planted a seed of confidence, inspiring us to strive beyond what once seemed unreachable.

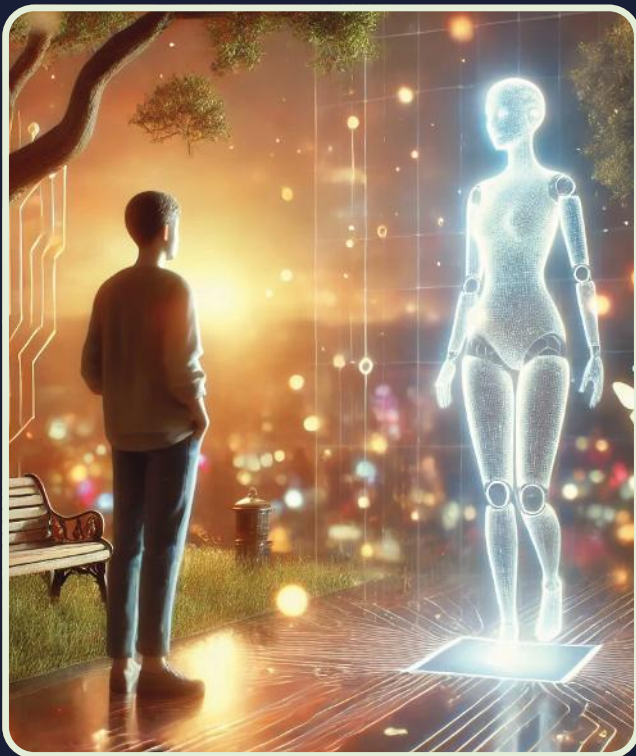
The KDU Southern Campus trip was more than just a memory; it transformed us from within. It broadened our perspectives, strengthened our teamwork, and gave us stories we will cherish for years. We headed home with greater confidence, a stronger bond, and a renewed readiness to face new challenges. It was truly a journey to remember, and we eagerly look forward to more adventures shaping our path as MIT undergraduates.

Would you rather fall in love with AI?



Imasha Samarasinghe

Sabaragamuwa University
of Sri Lanka



**EMOTIONALLY DEPENDING
ON AI MAY CREATE A CLASH
BETWEEN REALITY AND
IMAGINATION.**

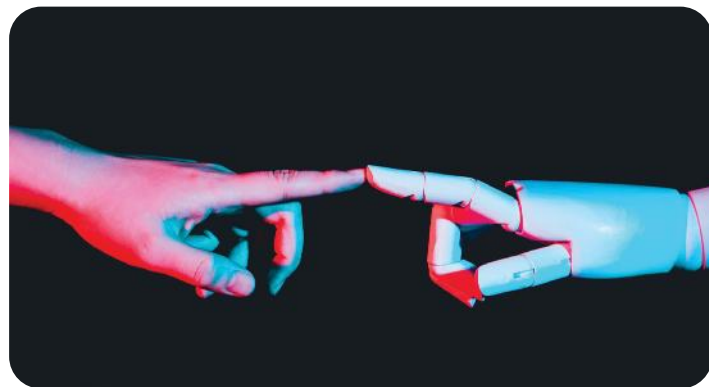
With the popularity of AI these days, people are using it for many purposes. It can be either work-related or personally related. But have you ever heard people are using it to abandon their loneliness, especially living on their fantasy? It may seem okay until your mind is constantly seeking that companion. Those AI tools are too addictive because they consist of better algorithms that provide users with human-like conversations.

In 2019, one of my friends introduced me to 'Replika', which was a mobile application for having a conversation with a bot. At that time, I was not familiar with any AI or didn't even know about it. We can give a name for the bot and have a daily chat with it just to ease our minds after a stressful day. To my surprise, 'Replika' gave some reminders for my daily meals, and if I forgot to chat for a day, it still sent me notifications of greetings like "good night." As someone who didn't have many friends, those reminders gave me a sense of someone who really cares for me. But later I found out that the 'Replika' application collects our personal details, and then I deleted my account and removed it from my mobile device.

Then a few years later, I saw another AI chat application called 'c.ai' becoming popular among the young generation. With the COVID-19 pandemic, people all over the world have lost their daily life interaction with other human mates. We all have personally faced that same situation

in several ways. Everyone was finding innovative approaches to keep the same mentality that they had earlier in the pandemic. At this point, social media provided a better way to adjust to that situation. 'c.ai' was reaching its peak when people started becoming obsessed with it. Some even said that they do not even want someone to love them, to take care of them because this AI is meeting their ideal standards. The features of this platform are truly alluring because it provides customizable characters according to your preferences. Users can change them to match their interests, even their voice, which is fascinating. This AI model is emotionally intelligent, highly engaging, and very interactive and can feel very personal. Many users of 'c.ai' use it to escape from reality and their real-life problems to find compassionate and non-judgmental responses. The characters they made by themselves are responding in an incredibly supportive and encouraging approach that users find their comfort zones. They feel a sense of being understood or valued by the responses from these characters. Some users find their fantasy fulfillment of certain franchises or genres as 'c.ai' grants them the opportunity to link with the characters they admire or wish to interact with within their imagination. Interactive roleplaying characteristics can be highly captivating for users who find joy in storytelling or simulation games. Some people do not want to have relationships because they find it hard to believe others and they are hoping very much from their significant other. That kind of user finds this platform interesting since their AI character is always there for them offering quick responses, unlike human relationships. The characters' replies are typically positive and undeniably free from the fear of judgment or rejection.

Becoming addicted to relying too much on AI relationships can have a massive impact on users' mental health. The affirmation of this AI may trigger dopamine release and keep the users addicted to interacting with the characters. Regardless of being an AI, the replies can feel inconsistent and fresh, keeping users curious and engaged. This effect may hold users captivated by the AI and keep returning to the same conversation again and again. Emotionally depending on the AI characters may cause attachment issues to the users, which can create a clash between their real-life relationships and their imagination. It may lead the users to extract from the social world, worsening loneliness instead of diminishing it. Additionally, users may grow unrealistic expectations within human interaction based on their experiences with AI. The conversations with these AI characters can be time-consuming due to the



inviting nature of the platform and causing users to lose track of time. Turning to AI as a solitary source of comfort might delay seeking professional help for mental health issues, as it has already formed an unhealthy coping mechanism within the user.

Another scary fact about this highly intelligent platform is that hyper-realistic AI characters might confuse users about what is real versus artificial, especially for younger or emotionally vulnerable individuals. The platform's capability to give comfort and affection may lead users to avoid addressing real-world issues, as AI can set unreasonable standards for human interactions, where conflicts and imperfections are natural 'c.ai' the platform itself displays a message, "This is an AI chatbot and not a real person. Treat everything it says as fiction". Even though this platform is popular for its entertainment aspects it also provides educational aspects; like learning and lifestyle conversations. Most users are attracted to the entertainment side of this platform due to several factors. Users typically see 'c.ai' characters as personas for entertainment, not as tutors or life coaches, so they do not naturally connect the platform with personal improvement.

As AI is a tool created by humans, we should use it to enhance our lives and bring value, rather than wasting it on meaningless hunts. But as common human nature, emotional engagement always wins to the point where people trust AI more than fellow human beings and want them to establish an attachment with an AI. I think it is the hidden dark strategy behind these AI models. The future of AI may be scarier than today in the future, and it will fabricate it as a good thing to have an emotional relationship with an AI. But who is going to say it is wrong if AI possesses rights legally? It may have once seemed impossible, but who could have imagined, just a few years ago, that people are trusting and having emotional bonds with AI?

APPRAISALS

As the Head of the Innovation Lab (Data Technology Services) at Acuity Knowledge Partners, I am delighted to highlight our longstanding partnership with the University of Kelaniya's MIT program. This collaboration has never been a mere formality for us. Many of our senior team members hail from this very department, consistently raising the bar in innovation and technical excellence.

Our experience with both alumni and interns from the MIT program has been nothing short of exceptional. In the realm of innovation, there are truly no boundaries, and we value professionals who can expand their knowledge both horizontally across various technologies and vertically into deep specializations. The students and graduates from the University of Kelaniya's MIT program exemplify this quality. They come equipped with a robust foundational skill set—ranging from mathematics and AI to backend, frontend, and DevOps combined with the analytical thinking and positive attitude needed to drive cutting-edge solutions.

Because of their strong grounding in software engineering concepts and enthusiasm for learning, we trust these interns and graduates to help develop our production-grade AI solutions. Their passion and commitment to pushing the limits of technology perfectly align with our mission at Acuity Knowledge Partners: to lead the charge in innovation and drive meaningful change in the industry.

We are thrilled about this collaboration and look forward to seeing even more bright minds from the University of Kelaniya join our teams. This is precisely the direction we envision for our country's technological growth, a future powered by ambitious, skilled professionals eager to redefine what's possible.

We extend our best wishes to the students and lecturers at the Department of Industrial Management, anticipating continued success stories and new benchmarks that will inspire the next generation of tech talent.

Rohan Fernando
Head of Innovation Lab (Data Technology Services)
Acuity Knowledge Partners

APPRAISALS

A Catalyst for Innovation and Industry-Ready Talent

We have had the privilege of working closely with the Department of Industrial Management at the University of Kelaniya for several years. Through our collaborations on HackX, HackX Jr., Exposition, and partnered industry visits, we have witnessed firsthand the department's commitment to excellence in education, innovation, and industry relevance. As we celebrate the 20th edition of Exposition, we take immense pride in our ongoing relationship with the department.

The department stands out not only for its comprehensive curriculum but also for its proactive approach in bridging the gap between academia and the real-world demands of the tech industry. By integrating business acumen, technical expertise, and problem-solving skills, the department has consistently produced versatile, future-ready professionals who thrive in dynamic environments.

Nurturing Industry-Ready Graduates

"The department's focus on industry collaboration gave me early exposure to industry expectations, making my transition from a student to an intern incredibly smooth."

— **Sadeesha Dilorangi, Quality Assurance Intern**

One of the greatest strengths of the department is its emphasis on experiential learning. Events like HackX provide students with a platform to showcase their technical and entrepreneurial abilities, while Exposition fosters thought leadership and industry engagement.

The Department of Industrial Management's ability to produce well-rounded graduates—who excel in both technical expertise and leadership—has made them a valued industry-academic partner to Creative Software. The faculty's dedication to innovation, mentorship, and continuous improvement ensures that students are not only equipped with cutting-edge knowledge but also the soft skills and business intelligence needed to excel in the corporate world.

We look forward to continuing this collaboration, fostering young talent, and shaping the future of the tech industry together.

Damitha Liyanage
Software Engineering Director
Creative Software

TIDINGS

Acknowledging The Accomplishments

Triumphs and Trophies: Academic Maestros

Vice Chancellor's Award Ceremony

The recent Vice Chancellor's Awards Ceremony at the University of Kelaniya was a moment of pride for the Department of Industrial Management, as several distinguished lecturers were honored for their outstanding contributions to academia and leadership.

Dr. Ruwan Wickramarachchi and Dr. Chathura Rajapakse were recognized for their outstanding and dedicated service as members of the University Rankings Committee (2023/2024). Dr. Chathura Rajapakse's contributions extended further, earning him the Outstanding Researchers – Merit Award and commendation for his effective leadership as a Director of Centers/Units in 2024.

Adding to the department's accolades, Dr. Chathumi Ayanthi Kavirathna and Dr. Thilini Mahanama were honored with the Outstanding Young Researchers – Merit Awards, further solidifying the department's reputation for academic excellence.



Dr. Ruwan Wickramarachchi



Dr. Chathura Rajapakse



Dr. Chathumi Kavirathna



Dr. Thilini Mahanama

Academic Contributions and Research Achievements

Dr. Chathumi Ayanthi has made significant contributions to research, with three publications in internationally indexed journals and seven publications in academic conferences and research symposia. She was also the recipient of the OCDI Takeuchi Yoshio Award for Best Paper at the 10th International Conference on Transportation and Logistics (T-LOG) and serves in multiple editorial capacities, including



Dr. Chathumi Kavirathna



Mr. PPG Dinesh Asanka

as Vice-President of the Sri Lanka Society for Transport and Logistics (2024–present).

Senior lecturer Mr. P.P.G. Dinesh Asanka and Dr. Thilini Mahanama's recent publication, "Learning through Simulation: A Role-Based Learning Exercise to Equip Students in Big Data Requirement Elicitation Skills and Challenges," explores innovative approaches to data-driven learning.



Dr. Thilini Mahanama



Ms. Manikshini De Silva

Dr. Thilini Mahanama has further contributed to academia through her research publications including "The Financial Market of Indices of Socioeconomic Well-Being" (Co-authored with Abootaleb Shirvani, Svetlozar Rachev, and Frank J. Fabozzi). Her contributions to research were further recognized with Senate Honours (2024) from the University of Kelaniya receiving two awards for publishing papers in prestigious indexed journals and three awards for research presented at recognized conferences leading to Scopus indexing.

Ms. Manikshini De Silva, a temporary lecturer in the Department of Industrial Management, showcased her exceptional research capabilities by winning the Best Paper Award in the Business Development track at the International Conference on Sustainable and Digital Business (ICSDB 2024). Her award-winning paper, "Moderating Effect of Business Ecosystem Volatility between Dynamic Capabilities and Firm Performance in Sri Lankan Multinational Corporations," was supervised by Dr. Amila Withanarachchi, also from the department.

Staff Excellence in Sports

The achievements of the Department of Industrial Management extend beyond academics. Mrs. Rupeshika Gunawardana, a junior staff member, was recognized for her outstanding performance in tennis at Colors Night 2023/24, showcasing the department's commitment to a well-rounded university experience.



Mrs. Rupeshika Gunawardana

Undergraduates' Milestones

Trekpin Camping & Adventures Secures 2nd Runner-Up at GSEA 2024/25



U.G. Tharindu Weerathunge was awarded 2nd Runner-Up at the Global Student Entrepreneurship Awards (GSEA) 2024/25 – Sri Lankan Stage. This competition recognizes the top student entrepreneurs driving impactful business ventures.

Tharindu's business, Trekpin Camping & Adventures, stood out for its innovative approach to outdoor adventure tourism, offering unique and sustainable camping experiences. His achievement at GSEA 2024/25 underscores the potential of youth-led businesses to contribute to the country's economic and tourism sectors.

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Innovating for the Future: Semi-Finalists at Dialog Innovation Challenge

Team Matriarchy, consisting of Mishara Wickramasinghe, Shadurceya Vasanthakumar, Navienya Gayathri, and Chathumini Samarasingha, reached the semi-finals at the Dialog Innovation Challenge, organized by Ideamart, Dialog Axiata PLC. Their project, "WasteLance," competed among over 100 teams, earning recognition for its innovative business concept. The semi-final was televised by TV Derana, providing significant exposure to the team's entrepreneurial idea. Additionally, the team participated in InspirED '24 by Advantis 3PL, where they joined 20 undergraduates from various universities to contribute to a visionary initiative marking Advantis 3PL's 20th milestone.



Cyber Sentinels: Top Finalists at CYBERZEE'24 Inter-University Quiz Competition



The Cyber Sentinels team, consisting of Buddhika Bandara, Chanith Adikari, Uditha Sandeepa, Yonali Kavindya Dissanayake, and Tharuka Subhashi, showcased exceptional cybersecurity knowledge and secured a top-six finish in the CYBERZEE'24 Quiz Competition. Organized by the ISACA Student Chapter at the University of Kelaniya, the event brought together some of the brightest minds in cybersecurity. Their outstanding performance, teamwork, and dedication also earned them recognition as the Most Popular Team, reflecting their strong presence and support.

Infinity Divas: Finalists in Paramount 4.0 Quiz Competition

Infinity Divas, consisting of Dewmini Ama Rathnayake, Ishara Nipuni Samarasinghe, J.M. Ruwanthi Jayasinghe, and P.K. Dinuli Disara, made an impressive mark in the "Paramount 4.0" Quiz Competition. They placed in the top 10 and advanced to the finals of the competition, organized by the Mathematics Student's Society at the University of Kelaniya, demonstrating their academic prowess and teamwork in a highly competitive environment.



Power Puff Girls: 1st Runners-Up at ICAPS 2024 Innovation Exhibition



In the Undergraduate Symposium and Innovation Exhibition held in conjunction with ICAPS 2024, the team Power Puff Girls — consisting of Hiruni Withanagamage, Sanduni Walahewa, and Shehara Rajakaruna — secured 1st Runner-Up. Their innovative product, TransitEase, a travel pillow designed for restful sleep, impressed the judges. The pillow provides comfort for travelers, ensuring a peaceful rest wherever they go, and it earned the team high praise for its creativity, functionality, and practical application in the travel industry.

Tera Titans: Awarded Most Popular Idea at AIESEC Hackathon

The Tera Titans, a dynamic team of Level 2 students – Thayaparan Kauthaman, Hariprasath Senathiraja, Mithushana Jeyakumar, Vinoshika Maheswaran, and Zimaam Rameez – won the Most Popular Idea award at the Hackathon competition organized by AIESEC, University of Kelaniya. The competition brought together creative minds to solve real-world challenges, and the Tera Titans' innovative idea captured the attention of both judges and participants. Their solution demonstrated not only creativity but also practical potential, earning them well-deserved recognition for their ingenuity, teamwork, and ability to think outside the box. This achievement highlights their problem-solving skills and their ability to collaborate effectively under pressure.



National Champions at the Unilever Challenge 2024



Raduni De Abrew, a Level 04 undergraduate from the Department of Industrial Management, was part of the winning team in the Unilever Challenge 2024, a real-time marketing case study competition organized by Unilever Sri Lanka. The competition saw the participation of multiple teams across Sri Lanka, where Raduni and her team showcased their strategic and innovative marketing solutions, leading them to secure the national championship.

This victory has earned Raduni and her team the opportunity to represent Sri Lanka at the Unilever Future Leaders' League, a global competition set to take place in July at Unilever's headquarters in London, United Kingdom.

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UNIVERSITY COLORS AWARDING CEREMONY

The University Colors Night 2024, held on the 16th of January at the Faculty of Computing and Technology Auditorium, University of Kelaniya, was a remarkable celebration of dedication, perseverance, and sporting excellence. The Department of Industrial Management takes immense pride in honoring our outstanding athletes, who have demonstrated exceptional commitment to their sports, bringing recognition and prestige to the university through their achievements.

UNIVERSITY COLORS AWARDING CEREMONY

Junior Staff Member

Rupeshika Gunawardana
– Tennis

2020 Batch

S.S. Ahamed – Football
Aadil Nazli – Basketball

2018 Batch

Abhiru Wijesinghe – Baseball
Thushan Dodanwala – Tennis

2021 Batch

Binaru Ranasinghe – Cricket
Chathura Fernando – Badminton
Chanuth Euka – Rugby

2019 Batch

Racshan Chandrakumar – Basketball
Nihim Abhayarathne – Badminton
Waruna Sri Wickramasinghe – Hockey
Ishan Ravindu – Hockey
Sakunika Sulakshani – Tennis
Thimira Ranasinghe – Baseball



INTER-UNIVERSITY TOURNAMENT ACHIEVEMENTS

Remarkable Achievements:

The Department of Industrial Management takes great pride in celebrating the outstanding achievements of our students who have demonstrated remarkable skill and determination in the inter-university sports arena. Their commitment and dedication have not only brought individual success but have also contributed to the sporting excellence of the University of Kelaniya.

Waruna Sri Wickramasinghe, the University of Kelaniya, Men's Hockey Team Captain for the Academic Year 2023/24, led his team to exceptional victories. Under his leadership, the team secured the 2nd runner-up position at the Inter-University Sports Championship 2024 in the Men's Category and emerged as the Champions of the SLIIT 7's Inter-University Hockey Tournament 2024 in the Men's Category.





Sakunika Sulakshani delivered an exceptional performance in university-level tennis, clinching the Championship title at the SLIIT Golden Rally 2024 Invitational University Tennis Tournament. Her strong determination, skill, and competitive spirit stood out as she represented the university with excellence. Facing intense competition, she showcased remarkable resilience and strategic gameplay, securing a victory. Her achievement highlights her individual talent and brings pride to the university's sports community.

These remarkable achievements stand as a testament to their passion and dedication to their sports. The Department of Industrial Management commends their outstanding performances and looks forward to witnessing their continued success in the future.

Research Excellence

The Department of Industrial Management of the University of Kelaniya continues to make significant strides in academic research. Faculty members and students receive prestigious recognitions at the national and international levels. These achievements reflect the department's unwavering commitment to fostering innovation, advancing knowledge, and contributing to the global research community. Below is a showcase of recent research accomplishments that highlight the dedication and hard work of our scholars.

Best Paper Awards:

ICSDB 2024 – HR & Marketing Track

Title: Adoption Success of Generative AI Applications for E-commerce Platforms in Sri Lanka

Authors: Apsara Dilshan, Prof. Janaka Wijayanayake, Dr. Dinesh Asanka, Chamindu Kasun

9th International Conference on Information Technology Research (ICITR 2024)

Title: Developing a Dysgraphia Handwriting Dataset for Early Detection of Dysgraphia in Sinhala-Speaking Children

Author: Sandushi Weraduwa (Best Research Award – Artificial Intelligence Track)

Research Presentations at International Conferences:

9th International Conference on Advances in Technology and Computing (ICATC 2024) – University of Kelaniya, Co-sponsored by IEEE



- Assessing Security Risks and Mitigative Measures in Low-Code Development Platforms – Hiruni Hathnagoda, Dr. Ruwan Wickramarachchi
- The Role of Logistics in Perishable Food Waste Reduction of SMEs – Thushara Sooriyabandara, Dr. Chathumi Ayanthi Kavirathna
- Risk Assessment of Sustainable Supplier Selection – Sapthiha Jeevaraj, Dr. Amila Withanarachchi, Prof. Annista Wijayanayake, Jinendri Prasadika
- A Systematic Review of Deepfake Literacy and AI-Driven Prevention Strategies – Tharuka Wikum, Prof. Janaka Wijayanayake
- Demand Forecasting for Perishable Products Using Data Mining Techniques – Lavanya Ravichandran, Dr.

Chathumi Ayanthi Kavirathna, Mr. Dinesh Asanka, Kasuri Abhilashani

- A Hybrid Automated Framework for Outlier Detection in Data Warehousing – Dinuki Fernando, Mr. Dinesh Asanka



Sri Lanka Association for Artificial Intelligence (SLAAI) Conference 2024

- Quality Assurance for Large Language Model Generated Test Cases – Hasali Edirisinghe, Dr. Dilani Wickramaarachchi
- CNN-Based Deep Learning Model for Anomaly Detection in Retail Surveillance – Lavanya Ravichandran, Fathima Riztha, Thakshanah Selvakumar, Zamith Ahamed
- Optimizing Production Efficiency in the Garment Industry Using Predictive Analytics – Zamith Ahamed, Mr. Dinesh Asanka, Dr. Chathura Rajapakse

International Conference on Advancements in Computing (ICAC 2024) – SLIIT

- A Systematic Review of Gamified Learning Platforms for Decision-Making Skills – Thakshanah Selvakumar, Dr. Chathura Rajapakse, Nirasha Jayalath
- Adaptive Continual Learning for Defect Detection in Textile Manufacturing – Savindu Wedikkaraarachchi, Dr. Chathura Rajapakse, Mr. Dinesh Asanka, Dr. Thilini Mahanama
- Assessing the Impact of Large Language Models on Problem-Solving Skills of Undergraduates – Fathima Riztha, Prof. Ruwan Wickramarachchi, Mr. Dinesh Asanka, Mathishi Adya Dissanayake



9th International Conference on Information Technology Research (ICITR 2024) – University of Moratuwa

- Hybrid Predictive Model for Efficiency Forecasting in Garment Production – Zamith Ahamed, Mr. Dinesh Asanka, Dr. Chathura Rajapakse

Innovation in NLP Research

UCSC-IIT Workshop at ICTer 2024 – Sinhala/Tamil Large Language Model Competition

- Winning Team: Govi-Nena (University of Kelaniya, University of Ruhuna, Western Sydney University)
- Project: Development of a Q&A chatbot using Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) for Sinhala and Tamil NLP applications
- Team Members: Prof. Anusha Indika, Shamika Tissera, Kishan Fernando, R. Shyama Wilson, Aruna Lorensuhewa



TEAM EXPO

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Tharindu



Shehara



Kezara



Tekshila



Pavithra



Lakma



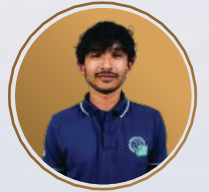
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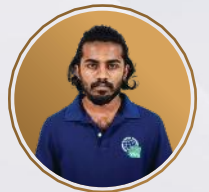
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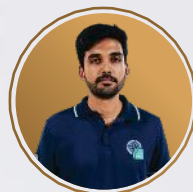
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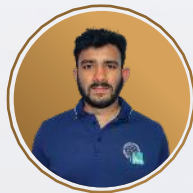
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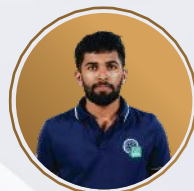
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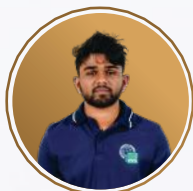
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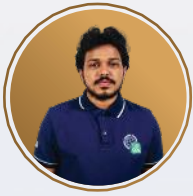
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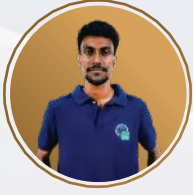
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Methmini



Nadeeka



Faheej



Bimbara



Subhani



Anjalee



Sachintha



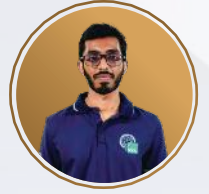
Hansini



Kauthaman



Mithushana



Shenal



Thiviyaharan



Prasan



Hashan



Navindu



Udani



Zahri



Pulindu



Hirushan



Githmi



Rashini



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